

Phil 290 The Philosophy of Religion

Numbered Transcript

PHIL 290 • Dr. James Orr

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Lecture 1: Ancient Paths to God

At a glance — Orr opens an eight-lecture introduction to the philosophy of religion, mapping the terrain and surveying ancient paths to God across early traditions.

- 1.1 Welcome to lecture one in this eight-lecture series titled Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. Philosophy of Religion. What a clunky phrase that is for something that is, for an area of human inquiry that is so enriching, so profound. We talk a lot today about the meaning crisis, people feeling a sense of dislocation, detachment from the world, from one another. Really, one way of thinking about the meaning crisis is as a deficit of proper engagement on the questions that we're going to be looking at in this course.
- 1.2 Parts of it will be quite technical, parts of it, I hope, will be less technical. I'll try to make it as accessible as possible. But really, philosophy of religion covers absolutely everything, all kinds of different forms of philosophy. It's why I love it so much. It's why it's my favorite area of philosophy.
- 1.3 What does it cover? Well, the fundamental questions for a start. Who am I? Who are we? What are we doing here? What were we doing before we got here, if there was a "we" before we got here? Where are we going? What is the meaning of life? How can we even make sense of the question that life might have a meaning, a direction, a purpose? All of these are questions that philosophy of religion touches on in a very rigorous way.
- 1.4 If you think of other areas in philosophy, if you look at any standard philosophy department in a big university anywhere across the West, there are lots of different areas. There might be metaphysics, a very big, clunky word, that. Metaphysics. What is metaphysics? It's like physics, but even deeper. It's the questions not about what the physical world is made up of, but ultimate reality. Metaphysics. What is the nature of ultimate reality? Is it ultimately material? Is it like stuff? Is it just what science tells us there is, or is there something more to it?
- 1.5 Then you'll have an epistemology department, epistemology. Another long, clunky word from the Greek *epistēmē*, meaning just "knowledge." And so epistemology is just that area of philosophy that looks at how we engage the world, how we know things about the world, how we describe our knowledge about the world. Is it opinion? Is it just belief? Is it what turns a belief into knowledge? Those kinds of questions. How do we perceive the world? How do we know that we're perceiving the world as it is? That would be epistemology. "M&E," metaphysics and epistemology, in the kind of jargon of professional philosophers.
- 1.6 Then you've got philosophy of language. You've got about how language, how our words could be about things in the world, how they hook onto the world, how they refer to things. How can we talk about unicorns, for example? What is it that our

language correctly hooks onto when we're talking about something that doesn't even exist? It's lots of interesting questions there.

- 1.7 Philosophy of mathematics, the nature of numbers, the nature of mathematical reality that doesn't seem to be material reality, but it seems to be very, very real. $2 + 2 = 4$ is a more real truth in some ways than any scientific equation, which just happens to be true because of the space-time universe that we happen to be in. It might have been $E=mc^3$, but it could never be. There is no possible world in which $2 + 2 = 5$. That's a very interesting area. And so on and so forth. Lots and lots of different kinds of questions.
- 1.8 Human nature, agency, free will, all these kinds of questions—philosophy of religion covers all of that. Let's just take the central focus of this lecture series. I'm not going to use the word God that much, but let's call it "divinity." My faculty in Cambridge, I rather like this, it's called the Faculty of Divinity. Why do I like that word? I like that word because it doesn't beg the question about what divinity might be against those who might say, "Well, I'm not a theist. I don't believe there's a God, but I believe there's lots of gods, or I believe that God and the world are one," as you see in some Indian traditions.
- 1.9 Let's just think of that word divinity, things that are divine, ultimate, however exactly we understand that word as mapping out into the different religious theistic or non-theistic traditions. So, immediately, when we're thinking about divinity, God or gods, or God and world together, we're thinking about the nature of ultimate reality. That is metaphysics, the nature of ultimate reality.
- 1.10 We're also thinking about: What is it to believe in God, or what is it to disbelieve in God? What is it to say that I know God? Some religious traditions say, "I know God." What are we talking about there? That's an epistemology question. The other department, that other big department, the two big engines of philosophy departments.
- 1.11 What are we talking about when we're talking about God? How can our puny, finite, fragile words, language, hook onto something as ultimate and transcendent and grand as divinity? So, questions about the philosophy of language.
- 1.12 Moral philosophy, questions of right and wrong, questions of value. What has value in the world, if anything? What is the right thing to do in any particular situation? Again, these have always been intimately connected with, downstream of, how you understand what the nature of ultimate reality is, in particular, where divinity is on the scene. That's pretty plausible. If God exists, then He's probably got views about how we ought to behave. If God exists, there is plausibly something of ultimate transcendent value in reality, in the world. And so, that's a question for the moral philosophers, too.
- 1.13 That's why it's so exciting, this area of philosophy of religion. It covers so much, just conceptually, looking across a philosophy faculty. But also what we call

"synchronically," that is to say, thinking at the same time about how you map out a topic or a discipline.

- 1.14 But I also want to think—we're going to be thinking "diachronically," that is to say, through the ages. When we're thinking about the philosophy of religion and thinking about the nature of divinity and the divine, we're really going back to the dawn of thought, the very beginnings of Western thought. These are the key questions.
- 1.15 The German philosopher, Karl Jaspers, J-A-S-P-E-R-S, famously coined this phrase, the Axial Age, the Axial Age, by which he meant roughly that period between the 8th century BC and the 4th or 3rd century BC. What Jaspers noticed was that, over this quite brief period, you have this sudden explosion of curiosity, of deep, sophisticated curiosity and inquiry, into the nature of the divine, into divinity, in parts of the world that had no connection to each other.
- 1.16 So in China, in the 5th century BC, we see the emergence of Confucianism, the idea that one can attune oneself to the world through cultivating virtue, through honoring one's ancestors, through taking reason seriously. We have the emergence also in China of Lao Tzu and Daoism, this doctrine that the world fits together into a harmonious whole, that it's saturated with the divine, something mysterious, something ineffable, and that human beings are attuned to it.
- 1.17 Then in India, we see in the emergence, in the 8th, 7th, 6th centuries BC, incredibly sophisticated philosophical schools, reflections on the nature of ultimate reality, of Brahman, underlying being, and the emergence of scriptural texts. And then very philosophically sophisticated reflections on scriptural texts, as we have in the so-called Upanishads, the 8th, 7th century BC—extraordinary documents, extraordinary texts.
- 1.18 And then moving westwards, you see the emergence of Zoroastrianism in Persia. The Persian Empire is beginning to emerge in the 6th century BC. Again, a philosophically sophisticated understanding of the world as being locked in a sort of wrestling, metaphysical wrestling match, between the forces of light and the forces of darkness and this great god of Ahura Mazda.
- 1.19 Then, of course, you've got the emergence of early Israelite religion that will be more familiar to us in the West. This is what is sometimes called ethical monotheism, is really beginning to emerge with the early Israelites in 11th, 10th, 9th century BC. But the Torah, the Hebrew scriptures, the Old Testament is really beginning to be crystallized as a set of texts, shall we say, in the 6th century BC.
- 1.20 Then moving from the Hebraic to the Hellenic. Think of the Hebraic and the Hellenic as the twin engines of Western civilization. These are what power the West forward, the Hebraic and the Hellenic. Often, the contrast that is made between the Hebraic and the Hellenic is belief systems that are focused on: revelation, revealed truth, revealed by God; and the Hellenic, the traditions that stress reason rather than revelation. This is a textbook dichotomy. As I think will emerge over the course of these lectures, we'll see

that that's actually not a particularly helpful distinction. It's very difficult to read the Old Testament and come away thinking that these were not extremely rational, highly sophisticated people.

- 1.21 Just as it's very hard to read a dialogue of Plato or to read much Aristotle, and come away thinking these people didn't really have much time for God or divinity or the nature of the divine quality that the world is shot through with. What is this last thing that Socrates has recorded as saying, "Don't forget to sacrifice the cockerel to Asclepius," Asclepius, the god of healing. It's the last thing he says. He says, "I'm a pious man." Plato, too, thinks that theology is very, very important. In fact, develops lots of interesting arguments for it.
- 1.22 Aristotle develops, in Book 8 of the Physics and Book 12 of the Metaphysics, a very powerful argument for something like the God of Abrahamic monotheism. That is to say, those three streams of monotheism that emerge, as it were, from the children of Abraham. That is just a quick snapshot of the Axial Age. All these different parts of the world, though disconnected, are beginning to think about the nature of ultimate reality, the nature of transcendence, and moving away from the cruder polytheistic, anthropomorphic forms of religion.
- 1.23 Polytheistic, anthropomorphic—what does that mean? Polytheistic, poly meaning many in Greek, theos meaning god, and anthropomorphic, that is to say, projections of human beings, forms of human beings, morphe, anthropos meaning man, human. And effectively, theology and religion is just a crude projection of human beings up onto this big metaphysical backdrop, which you might have, let's say, in the world of Homer, the Iliad and the Odyssey, which are beginning to be written down somewhere halfway through the 6th century BC, but as an oral tradition, is beginning in the 9th, 8th century BC.
- 1.24 Even in those poems, though, you're seeing the beginning of the emergence of something interesting and sophisticated, more than just the gods as these amoral, divine celebrity narcissists that are playing around with these poor human beings on the battlefield. The fifth line of the Iliad says, the words in the Greek is "Dios d' eteleieto boule," and the will of Zeus was accomplished. The will of Zeus is driving the whole energy of the Iliad forward. There's this sense of Zeus as almost like this force of divine fate.
- 1.25 And yet, also he's this henpecked husband who's always been nagged by Hera, his wife, and he's very sort of human. You see that kind of tension. But even in Homer, you see a great richness of reflection on the nature of human condition and a theology of sorts beginning to emerge. And so, what we have here is just a stunning cross-section of, as I said, the emergence of serious thinking about questions of ultimate meaning.
- 1.26 Paul Tillich, the 20th-century German American theologian, talks about this, that one of the things we're talking about with religion is, let's say, questions of ultimate

significance, fundamental meaning, ultimate significance. It can sound a little bit vague, but it's better to speak in those terms because, in fact, if we think about the word religion, it's very difficult to pin down. I've met professors whose job is the study of religion, professor X of the study, professor, chair in the study of religion.

- 1.27** I often ask these colleagues: What is religion? What is it? It turns out that not even the professors of the study of religion have much of a clear idea what it is. Nobody's really sure. Every time somebody comes up with a shopping list of criteria to define and pin down what a religion is, it turns out either to be far too broad, encompassing things like your favorite football team, your favorite basketball team. There's a certain criterion of religion that could capture a really fanatical fan. Or they're just simply too narrow.
- 1.28** For example, if you define religion by reference to some worship of God, then you're actually excluding many forms of Buddhism, some forms of Indian, of Vedantic thought, that we intuitively want to call a religion. And so, it turns out that the word religion is, as it were, a new kid on the block. It's a very new word, in lexicographical terms, in terms of its development. It's really only in the last, I'd say, 200, 300, 400 years that it's come to mean what it does mean today.
- 1.29** Once upon a time, there was no religion. There was no such thing as religion as we understand it today. Before roughly 1400, 1500, religio just meant a form of worship. This is what Augustine talks about in *De Vera Religione*, one of his classic texts, and he just said, what is—On True Religion, *De Vera Religione*. For Augustine, religio means worship. We sometimes talk about, "Oh, she's joined the religious life, or she's a religious," sometimes you hear people say. What that means is, the person is a nun. The person is in some convent or maybe monastic orders.
- 1.30** That was the old sense. The distinction between religious and secular just meant the difference between the monastic life and the world outside the church, the secular world. But everything was understood to be, the universe was a divine, God-ordained universe. There was no form of human life that was siloed or sequestered that we called religion. And that makes a lot of sense.
- 1.31** If God exists, then God touches on every aspect of reality, every aspect of human life, every aspect of behavior. There's no public square that you can have that is completely neutral, that is completely independent of God. This is quite a strange idea that emerges, particularly in the Christian tradition, the idea of secularism as the sort of God-free, neutral zone where we can agree to park our fundamental beliefs about God and religion, and then, as it were, come up with some consensus as to how we should proceed.
- 1.32** That's a very unusual way of thinking. It's very puzzling, for example, to Muslims and to Jews as well, that Christians have this way of carving up reality into a God-ordained church space. This is, of course, the First Amendment; the separation of church and state is very puzzling within a monotheistic universe. If all of reality emerges as created

by God, how can there be half of it that God is in charge of and the other half that He gives up or allows us to do our thing and is not interested in what happens there?

- 1.33** We'll see that this notion of this pair, you could say, these conceptually complicit terms of religious and secular, as we understand them today, is really only emerging in the 16th and 17th century. You could say that, really, the invention of religion as a term to describe the sorts of things that people might do in a mosque or in a synagogue or an ashram or a church, as something sequestered and siloed and carved away, domesticated, if you like, removed from the public square, is a very new idea. It's a new and would have been a very strange idea to most people living before 1500.
- 1.34** What are the different questions? What are the different angles of approach to philosophy of religion? Before we go down into the weeds of all the different arguments and different classic conceptions of God, I thought we would just step back a little bit and think hard about these different ways, different modes of approaching questions to do with religion.
- 1.35** First off, I talked earlier about this word, metaphysical, but I'm also going to use another clunky word—wait for it—ontological. Ontological. And ontological is from the Greek "tò on", meaning simply being. Being, a very pregnant philosophical term. What is being? It'll come up a lot, of course. And the relationship between God and being. Is God the source of being? Is God beyond being, as some philosophers and theologians believe? What could that mean, for something to be beyond being?
- 1.36** There's a wonderful anecdote of the English poet, W. H. Auden, who escaped England to the shame of many Brits and arrived in New York in 1939, September 1939, at the beginning of the Second World War. He converted to Christianity in early 1940. He was reading a lot of these theologians, very fashionable at the time, people like Paul Tillich, who liked to talk about God, not in terms of a personal being, not in terms of maybe Jesus Christ or whatever personalistic terms, but in these very grand terms of being.
- 1.37** He has a line in one of his diaries, I think, where he says, "I can see what people like Paul Tillich mean when they refer to God as the 'Ground of Being.' But every time I try to pray, 'Oh, thou ground,' I start to giggle." It's a nice little line, that. It's one that, just keep in mind, because it'll keep coming back, this great sort of tension between the pull to want to think about God and the divine as something so radically other and fundamental and special and transcendent that you can't possibly address it as you would address another person.
- 1.38** And yet, on the other hand, this sense that this being is a relational being or is a creator being, for example, perhaps. And there you've got this sense that, well, no, it's not just some sort of big ontological cloud or like the sun or something. It's something that has characteristics of personhood, intention, thought, feeling, capacity for love, and capacity for suffering, maybe even. You see this move from the deep ontological questions to just the personal. That moves back and forth in all the different traditions.

- 1.39 You see it particularly in the Indian traditions with the great Shankara, probably the greatest Indian philosopher in the 8th century AD. He founds the school of Advaita Vedanta, which is, effectively, a philosophy of non-dualism, where reality is undifferentiated. All is being. Then his great successor, Ramanuja, who comes up with Vishishtadvaita, which is the argument that actually, no, there's a proper distinction between Brahman, between underlying being, and personhood and souls. They're separate, distinct.
- 1.40 You see this also in the Abrahamic monotheistic traditions. God is creator of everything distinct from Himself. It's not just an accident that He creates, nor is it a necessity that He creates. It's not a necessity because nothing can compel God to act in the way that He decides to do. It's not an accident because God is the supremely rational, supreme source of all reason and intelligibility. God is that explanation, that in virtue of which the world is legible to us, that it's not just an accidental mess, that it's just intelligible, that we can understand it.
- 1.41 You see this move back and forth. We're going to touch a lot, I think, certainly in these lectures, we'll touch an awful lot on what you might call the creationist way of thinking about religion, the creationist philosophical framework for religion. By creationist, I don't mean young Earth creationism and all the debates that have been raging in America for the last 150, 200 years. It's actually quite a modern debate that older theologians weren't particularly interested in.
- 1.42 But by creationist, I simply mean the claim that the ultimate explanation of why there is anything at all—why this, why this particular world, why us—is one that is to be understood in terms of there being a moment of a bringing into being out of nothing. The Latin phrase is "creatio ex nihilo", by a maximally perfect, supremely rational source of all being, who decides to bring reality into being, or bring reality, created reality, into being. This is common to the Jewish, Christian, and Islamic conceptions of reality.
- 1.43 That introduces some very interesting philosophical problems. The first one, and this is a helpful way to frame the pendulum swing within creationist philosophical frameworks, you've got, on the one hand, this idea that the creator is distinct from creation. The two are different. Once there was no creation. There was a creator. Creation is brought into being out of nothing by the creator, by the creator's intention and will and power. So there's a distinction between God and world.
- 1.44 On the other hand, a key implication of that relationship between creator and creation, between God and world, is that the world is radically dependent upon God for its being, for its existence, for what it is. The world can't just separate itself from God and go off and do its own thing. This is an idea of total asymmetric dependence, one-way dependence, of world on God. With those two poles, you've got two traditions emerging.

- 1.45 On the one hand, if you stress the distinction between God and world, as many theologians want to do, because we're not God, and creation needs to honor and recognize God as something absolutely distinct. That sows the seeds of a separation between God and world, which we really start to see in the 17th century and the 18th century, in the so-called deistic, the movement of deism, like John Toland, and to some extent, John Locke even, the great John Locke in the 17th century.
- 1.46 And these are deists because they tend to think about creation in the world in terms of a pretty radical independence from God. This is, as it were, almost this idea that God creates the world, then gets a bit bored with it, and goes off and has a cup of tea, and leaves the world to its own devices. And you can see, actually, with this God as a kind of landlord, an increasingly absentee landlord, you can see how quickly deism moves into simply atheism.
- 1.47 "Well, we thought there was a landlord, but He's never around. In fact, it's been so long since we've last seen Him that, actually, He's probably just not an absentee landlord. He's just an absentee. There's just nothing there." That's very crudely, you might say, the history of philosophical reflection on religion and God, 17th, 18th, 19th century.
- 1.48 Then on the other hand, remember the other pole, where God and world are just—the world is seen as so dependent upon God for every moment of its being. God can't just go off and have a cup of tea and leave the world to its own devices, because the world is completely dependent at all moments on the sustaining energies and activities of God. It's sometimes called "creatio continuo," or continuous creation. The idea is that God doesn't just create the world billions and billions of years ago, but the world can't sustain itself.
- 1.49 Space-time doesn't just hang there. It needs not only to be brought into being, it needs to be sustained in being. Space-time can't haul itself into existence by its own bootstraps. So there is a radical dependence of world on God. And there you can start to see, well, is there really much difference between the world and God? And here you start to see the emergence of what we call pantheism, or pantheistic ways of thinking about reality and divinity. "Pan", meaning all or totality in Greek, "theos", of course, meaning God. So pantheism, the idea is that God and world are identical.
- 1.50 Then you've got its baby brother panentheism, "en" simply meaning "in" in Greek. Here the idea is that, it's not that God and world are identical, but that the world exists within God. St. Paul talks in Acts 17 in his famous speech at the Areopagus, to the Athenians, he quotes a Greek poet, talks about God as that in which "we live and move and have our being." It's a very clever move by Paul there, because he's—this is what I was telling you earlier about the distinction between the Hebraic and the Hellenic. Somebody like Paul is just as good at using philosophy and reason to convince the Athenians about the nature of what he believes to have been revealed to him.

- 1.51** So, pantheism and panentheism—and once you've got that kind of framework, all the different philosophers and theologians and traditions that we will be coming across in this series, you'll be able to, particularly within the creationist framework, you'll be able to understand how these different traditions are moving between those two distinct poles, between the radical separation of God and world on the one hand, and the radical identification of God and world on the other.
- 1.52** The great challenge for Abrahamic monotheists is to try and walk that tightrope between the two, between not separating God and world too much, and not identifying God and world too much. So these ontological questions, questions about the nature of being—here, you might classify the old questions about God's existence. Does God exist? What does it mean to say that God exists? It probably doesn't mean what—if God does exist, it can't probably mean something like, or very much like at all, the claim that I exist or that you exist.
- 1.53** Already, we're starting to worry a little bit about, "What do we say? What are we saying when we say that God exists?" I mean, for a start, on the Abrahamic traditions, the claim that God exists is not nearly the same. It could not possibly be the same as the claim that flamingos exist, or that the sun exists, or that Athens exists, or that Tuesdays exist. It's something very, very different. Remember that important radical distinction between God and world. We can talk about things in the world as existing, but once we start talking about God existing, we're using "exist" already in a very, very different way.
- 1.54** For example, we would want to say, most Abrahamic monotheists would want to say, that God is the source of existence. God is that in virtue of which anything exists. He's not just another thing that exists. It's not like, as one, the great theologian Herbert McCabe once put it, "God and the world do not add up to two." They're not two domains or two items on a shopping list.
- 1.55** One way of thinking about this is—it's a little bit crude, but I think, hopefully, helpful—is the sun. Someone said, "Yes, the sun, it's a very bright object." It's a very bright object, the sun. Hope you'd agree. That's not wrong. It's not that the sun is not a bright object. It's more that the person who describes the sun as a bright object is not really doing justice to the fact that the sun is that in virtue of which anything is bright at all. The sun does not borrow its light from anything else. God does not borrow His being from anything else.
- 1.56** Now, is it false that God does not exist? No. God exists, yes, but in the same way that the sun is a bright object. It's really shiny, the sun. The sun is the source, it's the ultimate source, of all illumination and all light. It's not like there's a spectrum with a candle and a light, an electric light, at one end of the spectrum, and then at the other end of the spectrum, at the top of the spectrum, you've got the sun.

- 1.57** I think one way of thinking about the Abrahamic monotheistic traditions, it's not like, well, there are these things that exist— tables and chairs and flamingos and lollipops and Athens and Tuesdays. Then at the end of this, a really, really intense form, you have God at the other end of the spectrum. There is a strong tradition in Islam and in Christianity and in Judaism that wants to reject that way of talking about God's existence as being somehow on that spectrum. God is that in virtue of which there's any spectrum at all. There's anything at all.
- 1.58** So, look, we haven't even got into arguments for God's existence at this point, notice. We're still stuck at this question of: What would it mean if we just, even accepted God existed? What would we even mean by that? You can start to see the challenges. So suppose later in the course, when I go through some of the arguments for God's existence, arguments against God's existence, even there you're thinking, "What if there were a slam-dunk argument for God's existence?"
- 1.59** And even there, not quite sure what it means to say that God exists in a way that respects, at least, that important distinction, certainly within the Abrahamic traditions, between God and world. So the nature of divine reality, is it personal? Is it impersonal? What kind of existence does it have? Then this question about the modal nature of God. When philosophers use the word modal, they're covering that area of philosophy that deals with questions of necessity, possibility, impossibility. This is actually a very, very technical and often very difficult area of philosophy.
- 1.60** But the common impulse has been to say that God exists no matter what. God exists no matter what. God didn't just happen to pop in to exist and doesn't just happen to exist or accidentally exist. God exists no matter what. That is to say, God exists as a matter of necessity. One way of thinking about this is, we say, there's no possible world in which God fails to exist. Now, this is the classical theistic tradition, says God is necessary. God has to—there cannot be a world in which God doesn't exist. Just in the same way that there's no possible world in which $2 + 2 = 5$, there is no possible world in which God fails to exist, if God exists at all.
- 1.61** But as we'll come to see when we look at the ontological argument, if God exists at all, then there's maybe one possible world in which God exists. But if there's one possible world in which a being who exists in all possible worlds exists, then God exists in the actual world. Because the one thing we know about the actual world is that it's a possible world. We'll come onto that in a future lecture.
- 1.62** So the question of divine necessity, and on the other hand, contingency. Necessity is something that exists no matter what, in every possible world. Something that is contingent is something that happens to exist but might not have existed. Everything in this world, everything in space-time, might not have existed. The Big Bang might not have happened. It's contingent. That is to say, there's only some possible worlds in which a contingent thing exists. And an impossible thing, a square circle, exists in no

possible worlds. So these questions will keep coming back, questions of necessity and contingency, when we think about divinity.

1.63 OK, getting even harder now. Time. Time. Is time real? Does time flow? Or is it the case that we just think time flows? It seems to us to flow. This is probably one of the hardest areas in all of philosophy. But we can't really get away from it, because when we're thinking about the nature of ultimate reality, we have to think about all reality, including temporal reality. Is God inside time or outside time? Or does God come to be in time at the point at which time begins? How does time begin? Well, Stephen Hawking and Roger Penrose, the so-called Hawking-Penrose singularity theorem that emerges in the 1960s, says that, well, the Big Bang, the implications of the Big Bang, are that time really did begin. There was once when there was no time "before". We might say before, we can't say "before the Big Bang," because we don't even know how to make sense of a temporal point before the Big Bang, because time, the scientists—this isn't just kooky philosophers. The scientists are telling us, the cosmologists are saying that's when time begins.

1.64 Maybe we have to talk about before the Big Bang in the way that we say seven is before eight, or a premise is before a conclusion. We can order it, but we can't allow ourselves to do it in temporal terms, because the scientists are telling us that time begins there. Well, on the creationist model, where God is the source of all reality distinct from Himself, including the Big Bang and any other Big Bang that might have been, any bigger bangs, God is somehow bringing time into being, on our best science, on our best science. So God is outside time.

1.65 OK, well, in that case, how can something that is outside time act in time? How can something that's outside time be something you can address or speak to? This is a troubling thought. There are different ways that one might approach this, try to get one's head around it. You might say, "Is Shakespeare in Hamlet or is he outside Hamlet? Is Shakespeare some sort of—has he got some kind of temporal location, temporal place within Hamlet?" Well, no, of course not. He's not in Hamlet, and yet there's no Hamlet without Shakespeare.

1.66 You might say, if you watch a production of Hamlet, "Shakespeare is everywhere and nowhere." You might say, within the creationist tradition, in all of created observable reality, all of scientific reality, "God is nowhere and God is everywhere." God is nowhere because, just as you can't see Shakespeare in Hamlet, you can't see God in the world. But also, just as there's not a letter of Hamlet without Shakespeare, you can say there is not an atom in reality without God's creative impulses and intentions and desires and will, on the creationist framework.

1.67 Questions to do with epistemology: What is it to say that we believe in God? Can we say that we know God? How do you acquire religious knowledge? We might say, do you have to do a Peterson Academy lecture series in the philosophy of religion to really be

able to get the credential of saying, "Yes, I have acquired a rational belief in the existence of God"? Well, the courses would sell very well if that were true.

- 1.68** But actually, we don't worry about that. The faith of a child, that's religious knowledge, you might say, that is acquired through testimony and through what my dad told me, or what my teacher told me, what people at church told me. Testimony is a completely reliable source of wisdom and knowledge about the world. It's a rational way of learning about the world. Most of what you believe, you've not acquired through careful demonstration and testing, etc, etc, and learning and reading. Most knowledge we have is the result of taking people's word for it.
- 1.69** There's this place called Sydney. I've never been there. But, well, "You've never been there? How do you know it's real? How do you know it exists?" "Well, because my geography teacher told me when I was six." "Yes, but you were six. Did you really have the cognitive capacities to evaluate her claim? Did you check her credentials? What if she was just playing around?" These are not rational. These are not—OK, maybe. Maybe.
- 1.70** But it's still, I can say, I am completely within my epistemic rights, within my knowledge rights, to say, "I know that Sydney is real. I know that Sydney exists. I've never been there. And yes, maybe there's some elaborate conspiracy to convince me from the age of six that there is this place called Sydney, but I'm not worrying about it. I'm not losing sleep over it." Most knowledge we have is acquired through testimony.
- 1.71** Now, we're going to be looking further down, later on in the series, at what other kinds of knowledge we could have about the divine that isn't just relying on other people. Are there ways in which our own mind can, as it were, go from first principles to the conclusion that God is real, that God exists in some kind of way? That's going to be a lot of fun. There's some fantastic arguments out there for the existence of God. There are fewer, but some very powerful arguments, against there being a God, and we'll touch on those when the time comes. I'm looking forward to that.
- 1.72** Then, you'll see within those traditions, you've got different kinds of theology, you might say. "Theologos," God talk. In Greek, this means God talk. Theologos, theology. Here, there's one tradition you might say that, sometimes in the medieval period, you call it the two-books tradition— the book of Nature and the book of Scripture. These are two books. This is like a stereophonic way of tuning yourself into the divine.
- 1.73** The book of nature, as it were, discloses truths about God and God's intention for the world, and the book of scripture does so as well. But these two are complementary. The idea is that these two are complementary, two different ways of accessing knowledge about God. Some people go further in the natural theology camp, where you say, maybe we don't need Scripture so much. We can look at the world and form arguments about the nature of the world that lead us to infer that there is a God who brought nature into being.

- 1.74** Now, some people stress that a great deal, and you have so-called evidentialists. Evidentialists are the people who say, "It is irrational to believe anything without sufficient evidence." Does that sound reasonable? I think on the face of it, it does. But I think, when you scrutinize it a little bit more closely, it all unravels, it all comes apart. Why? Well, I said earlier that most of the knowledge we have, that we're within our rights to call knowledge, we haven't got evidence for.
- 1.75** I didn't ask, I haven't got evidence that Sydney exists. My geography teacher told me. Is that evidence? Not really. I just take it on trust. And pretty sure she wasn't drinking. And pretty sure she didn't want to just fool me for the rest of my, make me systematically mistaken about Australia for the rest of my life. It's totally rational to believe her, but do I have evidence? No, I haven't been there. Can I, therefore, say I don't know that Sydney exists? No, that just seems odd. It's just not how we understand knowledge.
- 1.76** There are many, many things that we not only do not have evidence for, but we could not have evidence for, that we still are rational to believe is true and real. Maybe you've not been enjoying this lecture very much, but I would hope you'd believe, and say that even that you know that I have a mind, that I have a mind. I'm not just a zombie, I'm not just a robot droning at you. What would your evidence be that I have a mind? What do minds look like under a microscope? Nothing.
- 1.77** A mind under a microscope, and no minds under a microscope, it's going to look exactly the same. Do I therefore say, because I have not got evidence, direct evidence, you have not got direct evidence that I have a mind, that somehow I don't have a mind? Well, hopefully you would say that's not a rational position to have. I couldn't show you evidence that the world was not made up five minutes ago with the illusion of age, where mad scientists have programmed our brains into thinking that the world was older than five minutes.
- 1.78** What would evidence look like? Well, the skeptic could always say, he said, "Well, look, I had steak last night for dinner." The skeptic is going to say, "You think you did, because you've been programmed to say that you have. And what's your actual evidence?" I could, therefore, could not have any evidence. No evidence would satisfy you, you the skeptic, that the world is older than five minutes. Because every time I come up with a piece of evidence, you're going to say, "Oh, well, that's just what you've been programmed to think by the mad scientists."
- 1.79** I think there, one wants to say, stop. Here we can touch on one of the most famous and shortest arguments in analytic philosophy of the 20th century by the great Cambridge philosopher, G. E. Moore. "Premise one. Here is my hand. Here is a hand. Premise two. Here is another hand. Conclusion. The external world exists." And any skepticism about it, or any demands for high thresholds of evidence for it, are irrelevant. We don't need them. It's not where we start. We don't start doubting the world, like Descartes does.

- 1.80** We just say, "Look, I believe that these are my hands, really my hands, and I don't believe that a mad scientist is programming my brain in a vat to believe that these are my hands. It's not impossible, I guess. I'm never going to be able to satisfy the skeptic, but that's the skeptic's problem. I'm just going to say, the world is, roughly speaking, as I found it." Good bit of English, British common sense, empiricism— we take things, roughly speaking, as we are.
- 1.81** We don't follow the strange continental Europeans, who always come out with these crazy rationalist schemes of doubt and skepticism and so on. Good old John Bull empiricism. I think once we've got rid of that evidentialist strand which dominated a lot of 20th-century philosophy of religion, we can start to think about the idea that, maybe we can say that God exists without demanding the kind of evidence that we might require of, say, a scientific proof. Because it's a completely different kind of exercise.
- 1.82** If God exists, on most traditions, certainly on the Abrahamic traditions, God is not a material being. God is not in space and time, because the claim is that He created space and time. And so He can't be in space and time, because that'd be like divine bootstrapping. Nothing can be the cause of itself. Nothing can bring itself into existence, because in order to bring something into existence, there's got to be something already in existence. So nothing can be the cause of itself.
- 1.83** So God is somehow distinct from space and time, and therefore, distinct from science. Because what is science, ultimately? What is the domain of science? The domain of science is just the domain of space and time, with laws of nature within the spatiotemporal block. And whatever's going on outside that spatiotemporal block, science can't tell us. Science has to be agnostic. The physicist has to become a metaphysicist, because those questions were already, by definition, outside the domain of what science studies, namely stuff in space and time, causes, effects, laws of nature, stuff, that kind of thing.
- 1.84** To ask for evidence, to ask a creationist theist for evidence or scientific evidence, direct scientific evidence, is already to, as it were, put the theist at an unfair disadvantage. It's to misunderstand the nature of theistic belief, which just is that there is a being, a source of being, a source of creation, that is distinct from creation. We can't use the tools that we ordinarily use to study things in creation to tell us anything about what is outside creation and brought creation into being.
- 1.85** That way of that skeptical engine for a lot of atheistic attacks on the rationality of religious belief, I think, has faded quite a lot since the 1950s and '60s when it was at its high noon. Now, philosophers are a lot more comfortable with the idea that you can say that you know that God exists, there's a kind of basic belief, roughly in the same way that you believe that the world is older than five minutes, even though you can't give proper evidence, make proper evidence for it, or that other people have minds, even though you couldn't put those minds under a microscope.

- 1.86 It doesn't matter. I still say, "I know that person has a mind. I know that the world was not made up five minutes ago with the appearance of age and with scientists programming my brain. I know that these are my hands. Yeah, OK. Do I know 100% in a way that's going to satisfy the crazy skeptics? No, but I'm not bothered. I don't mind. I can navigate the world without these crazy skeptical nightmares."
- 1.87 Maybe belief in God is a little bit like that. It's not that it's—you can't show that— if you could show that belief in God is completely irrational, like believing in a square circle or maybe believing in unicorns, perhaps, maybe you'd start to say, "Well, I think we've got to challenge this claim that you know that God exists." But that's not the case. We'll come on to whether or not the concept of God might be like the concept of a square circle. I say it's not. You can't think of a square circle. Try it. You can't. Can the atheist think of God or think of what God is, or might be, if God existed? Yeah. There's nothing contradictory in the thought "God."
- 1.88 On most views, on most views, we'll come onto some ways in which you might think that the very concept of God is an incoherent one. If you can show that, that it's just something just like a contradiction in the meaning of the word God, in a way that there's an immediate contradiction in the claim that there's a square circle, then maybe you could say that it's not just that you're irrational to believe in God because there's no evidence for it, it's just you're irrational to believe in God because it is irrational to believe something that is conceptually contradictory, that could not be the case in any possible world.
- 1.89 Coming into land, we'll come also to the last phase of this opening scene-setting lecture. We'll come back again and again to this question of language. We touched on this a little bit when I was saying that just those two words, "God exists," is a challenge because we don't want to say that God exists in the same way that flamingos exist, just as we don't want to say that the sun is a bright object in the same way that a candle is a bright object or an object that illuminates.
- 1.90 And so, there's this tradition of saying that language sort of fits onto God, but also it's radically inadequate to capture God. And so, you have these two different traditions, so-called cataphatic tradition, where we can describe God or we can say things about God, and the apophatic tradition, "phatic" simply means saying or statements in Greek. The apophatic tradition is saying, "No, we can't actually say anything about God. We can't use the language that we apply to creation to describe the creator."
- 1.91 Here, many atheists will say, with Wittgenstein, "that a nothing will do as well as a something about which nothing can be said." If there's nothing that can be said about God, then God might as well be a nothing. A nothing will do as well as a something about which nothing can be said. But we'll come on to those questions in future lectures. For now, thank you for listening to this opening lecture of introduction to philosophy of religion.

- 1.92** Hi, Dr. Orr. My question is, without a necessity for God, the world or people, from my perspective, would be more tempted or persuaded by nihilistic, reductionist, or even hedonistic views. So my question is: Wouldn't it be more beneficial for people, and their flourishing, to have faith in God and His power than believe nothing has meaning or that man is just atoms?
- 1.93** Great question. The first thing that a philosopher would say to that is: it can't be that truth is a matter of what works or what is conducive to our flourishing. But that's not the proper philosophical posture that we should have towards the world. Unless you are what's called a pragmatist, like William James, John Dewey, the great—really, the only American philosophical tradition is the pragmatist tradition. The trouble with pragmatism is that it doesn't work.
- 1.94** The pragmatist's chief end is always to be something more than a pragmatist. When you ask yourself, "Does X work? Does this watch work?," what you're presupposing there is that there's something beyond it working, that there's some horizon beyond it functioning, while it's telling me the time, and the time is what I need. I don't really care about, I want the watch to work, but in order for me to be able to tell time.
- 1.95** The question—leave aside the philosophy of religion, and let's just say that on all of these different metrics, religion makes you healthier. Religion makes you happier. Religious societies have more babies. Therefore, they have a better future. Therefore, they have a better economy, and so on and so on and so forth. Those are not philosophical arguments, I would say, for the existence of God. In the end, they're not going to be an answer to the nihilist who says that nothing has meaning.
- 1.96** You don't have to worry about the nihilist who says nothing has meaning because he's contradicted himself with his first statement. If nothing has meaning, then so does a statement that nothing has meaning. There must be something that has meaning. Otherwise, what is a nihilist? But you might say, look, there might be arguments for religion. Those are good arguments for a society, for it to be better for a society to be religious than not religious. But it could never be an argument for or against the existence of God, I don't think.
- 1.97** I guess mine's not really a question, but more of something—
- 1.98** Yeah, a response? Short speech disguised as a question? Anything you like.
- 1.99** It seems we have to get the meaning, definition, of God right before one comes to God or truth. Let's say someone comes to see God or the truth but doesn't have the right definition. What then?
- 1.100** Well, part of the business of philosophy is definitions, because you can't really have an argument about it. You're going to have a dialogue of the deaf if you're not agreed, roughly, on what it is you're arguing about. And so, as we'll see in a future lecture, one definition I quite like is "that than which, *aliquid quo maius nihil cogitari possit*," as

Anselm puts it in the Proslogion. "God is that than which nothing greater can be conceived," or thought about. God is that which lies beyond the limits of our conception, just beyond it, that's greater than all of that.

- 1.101 Or God is a maximally perfect, maximally excellent being. God is the sum of all perfections, and there is no shadow of imperfection. That's a very standard way, a classical way of thinking about God, partly because there's this idea that God is that that is maximally worthy of worship, and maximally worthy of, as it were, shaping our behavior and our response to the source of all being. You might think of God sometimes as the ground of being, that in virtue of which there is anything at all.
- 1.102 God is the answer to the question: Why anything? Why this? Why is there something rather than nothing? But maybe also God is Zeus. All you need to prove or disprove the existence of God is to go to the top of Mount Olympus in Greece and look around. Not here. That God, that Zeus does not exist. You can say that because the claim is that Zeus is just this huge human-like, just much, much bigger, but a human-like thing, in space and time. We've inspected all of space and time, and there's no Zeus. The claim is, we can say that that God doesn't exist, because the claim is that God is in space and time.
- 1.103 So yeah, you've got to get the definitions right, or at least you need to have the right scope, an agreed domain of what the word could mean. Some might say the notion of God is contradictory because, as a maximally perfect being, it's contradictory because you can't have a being that is both omnipotent and omniscient. Because a being that was all-powerful could not know what it's like to be afraid. What could make an omnipotent being afraid? What would an all-powerful being, a being, by definition, more powerful than anything else, how could such a being know fear?
- 1.104 But if you can't know fear, then there's something that—not only is there something He doesn't know, the stuff that we know, little old us knows, that God doesn't know. So He's not even omniscient. So you can't be both omnipotent and omniscient. Anyway, we'll come onto these. I'm slightly stealing my thunder for future lectures, but we'll come onto that question in more detail.

Lecture 2: The Nature of God

At a glance — On the nature of God — the divine attributes and how philosophers have tried to characterize God.

- 2.1 Welcome to lecture 2 of Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. In the first lecture, I provided a kind of roadmap for the terrain, how we think about philosophy of religion as a form of human inquiry. What is its scope? We realized that the scope, both synchronically, that is to say, across all the different areas within philosophy, is vast, and also diachronically, historically, its sweep is also extremely extensive.
- 2.2 Really, from the very beginning, from the dawn of thought, as I said, human beings have been thinking about the nature of ultimate reality, have been projecting, what we might call, the religious impulse onto the world. One of the curious features of so-called secular humanism today is that it resists and denies and repudiates that which is most distinctive of being human. The religious impulse is one of the most distinctively human impulses.
- 2.3 From the cave art so many thousands of years ago, you could see that there is that religious impulse. Yes, early on, in quite primitive forms—that expression, that religious yearning, took quite primitive forms, but it became very quickly a philosophically sophisticated form of inquiry. In fact, as I was saying earlier, before 1500, the word religion didn't really mean anything, and the word philosophy meant just as much theology as anything else.
- 2.4 It just seemed obvious to people in the medieval period and before that, that asking questions about God was to ask philosophical questions. It wasn't a separate, strange area of human activity. It was: Is time real? Is God real? Is the world real? These are totally legitimate philosophical questions. And so, there wasn't even really much of a distinction between philosophy and theology in the sense that we think of today. Quite the reverse.
- 2.5 I mean, for somebody like Thomas Aquinas, 1224 to 1274, famously in the Summa Theologiae, the one-million-word-long work that is unfinished, lay unfinished, after Aquinas has a fascinating religious experience—we'll be talking about religious experiences towards the end of the course—in early December 1273, he lays out in the Summa Theologiae, that is to say, the compendium of theology, a case that the commitment to the existence of God has extraordinary explanatory power for so many aspects and dimensions of reality.
- 2.6 It accounts for, he claims, motion. It accounts for causation. It accounts for degrees of perfection. It accounts for being itself. It accounts for souls, human beings, relationships, love, and so on. God is not seen in that intellectual universe as a threat to understanding, but as the key to understanding the world, and as that through which we can have a more integrated understanding of the way the world is.

- 2.7** C. S. Lewis' famous quote is often repeated because it's true. He says, "At one point, I believe in God in the same way that I believe in the sun, not so much because I can see the sun, but because through the sun, I can see everything else." It's to say God has a heuristic power. It's like an explanatory lens that makes sense of so many otherwise strange and inexplicable features of the world and of human experience.
- 2.8** Now, of course, here we're moving more into questions of arguments for and against the existence of God, because one of the key claims that an atheist will make is that, no, it doesn't. God does not provide the kind of explanations that are adequate for understanding the world. Science does. And you have this great, I think, pretty confected warfare, the so-called warfare thesis between science and religion, that becomes very popular in the 19th century. But I think we'll come to see that science and religion actually fit together in ways that are actually a lot more, much more harmonious than that conflict thesis makes out.
- 2.9** It's not an accident that it's an intellectual world committed to the idea that reality and nature are intelligible, legible, understandable, because they've been shaped and brought into existence by a single source of agency and intention and will. It's not an accident that the great leaps forward in science occurred within that intellectual universe, a creationist intellectual universe.
- 2.10** If you think how sophisticated, say, Chinese civilization is, long before, whilst we're still in mud huts in this rainy northwestern rim of Eurasia with terrible food and terrible teeth, the Chinese are way ahead of us, way ahead of us, in their technology, in their philosophy, in their literature. But China produces no Darwin. China doesn't produce a Newton or a Faraday, that is to say, these scientists or great figures in the history of science who think about reality in this complete way.
- 2.11** There's lots of fascinating local discoveries, obviously, that the Chinese make or India makes. But it's not one that operates on the assumption that all of reality is just legible and totally shot through with intelligibility. This is the so-called, the famous Needham question, N-E-E-D-H-A-M, named after the famous Cambridge sinologist, Joseph Needham, the person who really founded the modern study of China, sinology, in the West.
- 2.12** And he used to ask: Why is it the case that civilizations as advanced as Chinese and Indian civilizations didn't produce a Darwin and a Newton? But Europeans who come along so much later, really just in the last 500 years, manage to, 5, 6, 700 years, manage to produce these comprehensive pictures, scientific pictures of reality. And a lot of that is to do with this idea that theism isn't opposed to science. It's actually, it's not opposed to understanding the world. It's actually a key to understanding it.
- 2.13** Let's back up a little bit and stop and pause to think: What is it that we're talking about, at least in the monotheistic tradition, when we're talking about God, in the classical tradition? When I say classical tradition, I mean, roughly speaking, reflections,

particularly philosophically sophisticated conceptions of God within the Abrahamic traditions from, let's say, 150 to 200 AD, all the way up to, let's say, 1300, I think. That's really the end of the Middle Ages or the beginning of the late Middle Ages.

- 2.14** This is the high point. That period, that thousand-year period, is really where philosophical reflection, classical conceptions of God, are where they're most intense and penetrating. The basic thought here, the basic spirit animating conceptions of God in this period, is this idea of God as a perfect being, God as that most perfect of all beings. God is the sum of all perfection. There's nothing God can't do. There's nothing God can't know. There's no good that God is incapable of. There's no evil that God is capable of.
- 2.15** God exists necessarily. God exists no matter what. He doesn't just happen to exist. He doesn't depend upon anything for His existence. He doesn't borrow His being from some other being. If He did, He wouldn't be God. This is the basic idea that God, whatever God is, He must be the sum of all perfections. He must be that most perfect of beings. Omnipotence, we've got a lot of the omni words, omni, omnis, meaning "everything" in Latin. You have omnipotence, potency, "power." God is capable of actualizing any logically possible state of affairs.
- 2.16** The atheist might say, "Aha, but God can't make a square circle, so He's not omnipotent. Or God can't create a stone that's too heavy for Him to lift. Aha, got you." Most theologians, most philosophers, accept that those are very bad objections to God being an omnipotent being. It is no constraint, it's no limit on omnipotence that you can't do nonsense, you can't do impossible things. In fact, God's omnipotence for some philosophers is a very good way of understanding the nature of possibility and impossibility. Impossibility just is whatever God can't do. God can't do it, it's just not possible.
- 2.17** Now, there are more subtle objections along these lines. If God can't make it the case that $2 + 2 = 5$, what is it? What is it that constrains God's capacity there? There's a famous letter of René Descartes to one of his correspondents, Mersenne, where he says, actually God is that powerful. God is so powerful. I'm so resistant to the idea that there could be any constraint on God's power, that yes, God could make it the case, could even make it the case that $2 + 2 = 5$.
- 2.18** Very few people have followed him down that route that prizes God's power and omnipotence above almost everything else. You might say it prizes God's omnipotence above His omni-rationality, this idea that God is supremely rational. Why would a rational being make it the case that $2 + 2 = 5$, hence collapsing all of mathematics? Because if it's possible that $2 + 2 = 5$, infinitely many mathematically impossible things are actually possible. I mean, it would just be odd if it was possible for $2 + 2 = 5$, but impossible for $2 + 3 = 4$. I mean, why?

- 2.19** So, you have tension here. One way of thinking about objections to classical theism, developed by the brilliant Yujin Nagasawa, I think he's working at the University of Oklahoma. Professor Nagasawa comes up with this very helpful formulation: three categories of objections to the omnigod, the God as a perfect being.
- 2.20** Category number one, you might say, the claim is that one or more of the traits that this perfect God, as a perfect being, is alleged to have doesn't make sense. It's not coherent. This idea, for example, that God is omniscient. Well, there are facts about what it's like to be me, that only I could know. There are facts about what it's like to be you, to which you alone have private, privileged access.
- 2.21** If anybody else had access to those facts, you wouldn't be you. They would be you. So, not even God could know what it's like to be me, because I'm not God, and God is not me. And there are all sorts of facts, therefore, that I have, so-called indexical facts, things that only I could know as a me, as I, from my perspective, that God doesn't know, couldn't know, because He's not me.
- 2.22** This, you might say, is one category of objection. The objection is that there's this one trait that the perfect-being classical theist people say that God has that God can't have. Now, there have been fairly standard responses to this, but the ones that I think are probably the most compelling are that as it's not a limit on God's power to say that He can't make a rock that's too heavy for Him to lift, we can say it's not a constraint on God's knowledge, that there are facts that He does not know, that He could not logically know, as it were, that are impossible for Him to know. It's not a constraint on God's knowledge, that.
- 2.23** Obviously, if God wants there to be a me, then He's going to grant that there will be, as it were—He's making space for local pockets of ignorance, divine ignorance, about what it's like to be, about the facts that I have access to, that God doesn't have access to. You might also say that, actually, the facts that you know that are indexical, that only you can know, are not really facts. They're not really facts in the same way that that chair is red or $2 + 2 = 4$. They're not those sorts of facts, and therefore, they're not the things that God, the omniscient being, would know. Anyway, that's the first category of objection: take one of the traits and say it doesn't work.
- 2.24** The second category of objection is to say that two or more of the traits are in tension. The idea that an omnipotent being is also omniscient is problematic, because an omnipotent being would not know what it's like to feel afraid. There's a clash; there's a conflict between those two. Therefore, the claim is: there's something incoherent about the idea that God is a perfect being, because there couldn't be a perfect being. There couldn't be a being that is both omnipotent and omniscient, because an omnipotent being would not know what it's like to feel fear. So there's a tension between the traits.

- 2.25** The third category of objection that Professor Nagasawa draws our attention to is some tension between traits that this God, as a perfect being, has and facts in the world, facts in the world. The most famous example of an objection to perfect-being theism here in this category is the problem of evil. So the claim there is that, OK, there are these traits that God has in virtue of being a perfect being. He is all-powerful, and He's all-loving, maximally loving, maximally powerful.
- 2.26** It's not that there's a contradiction between those two traits in and of themselves, taken together, but there is a tension between those traits taken together and the prevalence of innocent suffering in the world. It's the third category of objection. We'll come on to talk about the problem of evil in a subsequent lecture, but what I want to do for now is just to show, set out the three categories of objection, three lines of attack that are typically taken against this classical high conception of theism, of God as a perfect being.
- 2.27** I mentioned in the previous lecture questions to do with modality, necessity. Again, the thought is that it is more perfect for a being to exist in every possible world than it is for a being to exist in some but not all possible worlds. That's pretty plausible. A being that just could not fail to exist does seem to be more perfect, more excellent, than a being that exists in this world maybe, but might not have existed in other worlds. Again, it's this notion of greatness and excellence and perfection that is driving this way of defining what God is.
- 2.28** Questions around immutability—God doesn't change. God is not subject to change. Why? Because God is not, God is not passive. There's nothing that God can't be affected in any way. God is beyond space, beyond time. You can no more affect God, or God can no more undergo change, than the number 2 could undergo change, if the number 2 exists. I don't know who here thinks numbers exist. But pretty plausibly, numbers do exist. I mean, the scientists—physics is not getting less mathematical. The nature of the best science is now, best physics is basically just mathematics.
- 2.29** When we're studying mathematics, are we studying something that's not real? Like, things we're making up as we go along? Well, there are some people who do believe that. There are some philosophers of mathematics who do think that mathematics is an elaborate fiction. Now, I find that a very difficult view to take seriously, but it is an increasingly dominant view over the last few decades, partly because of an orthodoxy within philosophy called naturalism, naturalism.
- 2.30** When I use the word naturalism now and in subsequent lectures, or naturalistic, the adjective, I'm just meaning, very roughly, that term to describe a philosophy that thinks that all truths are scientific truths. All truths are scientific truths. Or maybe all truths are scientific truths, plus truths that you can reduce to scientific truths or eliminate in favor of scientific truths. We might talk about minds, but really, what we're talking about is facts about the brain. We talk about minds because we're in the grip of this

strange superstition that there's something beyond the human being, beyond the merely biological makeup of human beings.

- 2.31** But the dogma, the orthodoxy, is that science is the be-all and end-all is the only way we can ultimately understand the world. It's a very strange superstition, in my view, but it's a dominant one. It's the sensible, reasonable philosophers all take for granted, pretty much, that naturalism, or some version of naturalism, is true. I'm definitely in a minority in thinking it's a superstition and false.
- 2.32** For example, one of the reasons I think it's false is that I believe that $2 + 2 = 4$ is a truth. Not only do I believe that $2 + 2 = 4$ is a truth, I think it is the truest truth of them all. Why? Because it's a truth that couldn't fail to be true, in a way that every single scientific statement might not have been true. It's contingently true. As I said in a previous lecture, it might have been $E = mc^3$. There's no law of logic or necessity that forbids there being a possible world in which $E = mc^3$ is true. Whereas I do think that there is a law of mathematical necessity that tells me that there is no possible world without me even needing to visit all possible worlds, in which $2 + 2$ fails to add up to 4.
- 2.33** But if that's a truth, then not only is there at least one truth that is not a scientific truth or reducible to a scientific truth or eliminable in favor of a scientific truth, there are infinitely many truths that are not scientific truths, that infinitely dwarf the total domain of scientific truths. There are truths that are true that are not in time and space. The truth of $2 + 2 = 4$ does not depend upon the Big Bang having happened or not having happened. It doesn't depend upon their being's matter or time or space.
- 2.34** Why am I encouraging you to think about, why are we spending so long in the philosophy of mathematics? Well, because I want you to start to think about God in some ways, a little bit like how philosophers of mathematics who think that their mathematics is real, think about the mathematical domain. Because it's a little bit easier to, certainly when you're trying to understand the classical conception of God, a nice analogy, I find, is the philosophy of mathematics. Because, yes, look, the number two, I'm not saying the number two is God, or indeed any number is God.
- 2.35** But what I am trying to get you comfortable with is the idea that something that is outside space, is outside time, you can't see, you can't smell, you can't touch, may not only be real, but actually more real than anything that's here today, gone tomorrow, in this fleeting spatio-temporal continuum, that once upon a time didn't exist, and once upon a time will cease to exist. It's not that God is a number, but we can get our heads around there being, even if you don't think the number 2 exists, like I do, you can still see why somebody like, why I might think that the number 2 is real, the number 2 exists.
- 2.36** You can start to think, OK, there may well be a reality. It's very plausible that there's a reality, without getting into the religious stuff, without getting into God stuff. Yes, there is a reality, that I can make sense of the idea that there's a reality that transcends the

world, that transcends nature, doesn't depend upon nature. It's not spooky to believe that there's something outside space and time. It's not spooky to believe that something exists no matter what, that timelessly exists, that couldn't fail to exist, that $2 + 2$ couldn't possibly fail to add up to 4.

- 2.37** I think this is not a perfect way of thinking about God in this classical conception, but it should be helpful. You can start to think why it's not so odd or irrational. The reason that we tend in modern culture to think of belief in God as kind of kooky, spooky, irrational is partly because of the imaginary, let's say, the philosophical and cultural imaginary of modernity, which for the last, let's say, 300 years since the Enlightenment, crudely has said that what's real, the benchmark for what counts as real, is what we can see and touch and taste and smell, what science can tell us about. That's what's real. Well, that's what's most real.
- 2.38** Then it's not that other stuff is fake or illusory, but we're a bit murkier about the stuff we can't see; it's a bit murky. This, in the whole sweep of human thought, is a very unusual, is very topsy-turvy way of thinking about things. I'm sure you've all listened closely to my lectures for the Peterson Academy on Plato. In those lectures, I talk about Plato's famous myth of the cave, in which, this comes in Book 6 and then Book 7 of Plato's Republic, his greatest work, where he comes up with this analogy, his way of thinking about reality as two-tiered.
- 2.39** The picture that he presents is of prisoners shackled together in chains in a cave, staring at the back wall of the cave, with a fire behind them, flickering, causing, with the shadows flickering on the back of the walls. The prisoners are entranced, are mesmerized by the falsehood, the illusion that the flickering flames on the back of the cave are reality. That's what they can see. And Plato says, there's this brave figure who manages to break free of the chains and turn his back on the flickering flames and find this pathway up, up, up out of the cave, into the sunlight beyond, blinded by the sunlight until his eyes adjust to the sun.
- 2.40** The allegory there is Socrates breaking the chains, turning his back on the conviction that what's real is what we can see and touch and taste and smell. In other words, what's most real is the world of science that we can experiment on. He says what's really real is the world of the sunlight outside, the things that are flooded with light, no flickering flames, where everything is light and everything is pure and clear, and as it were, necessary. The sun is what it is.
- 2.41** The whole thrust of that allegory is that what's really real is actually not what we can see and touch and taste, but what we can only think, we can only access through thought. And actually, for Plato, mathematics was the best way of beginning to think about the good as this transcendent being outside space and time. Doing mathematics, in fact, everyone who joined his academy had to do many, many years of mathematics before they were even allowed to sit down and do philosophy with Socrates.

- 2.42 Why? Well, for the same reason that I was using the illustration of $2 + 2 = 4$ earlier to help us think about God. There's some useful ways into thinking about God, and Plato insists on this in his academy. And so this is a picture of the world, where what's real is not what science tells us. Because for Plato, I think quite reasonably, his view is— for Plato, the view is that the world of flux, of change, is a world that is unstable when it comes to knowledge.
- 2.43 Here's an example. If I discovered that my daughter was being taught science using a physics textbook from the 1920s, I'd be very worried. I'd be ringing up the school and I'd be saying, "Please, could she be taught the last 100 years of physics?" I'm not happy with her being stuck in 1924 in her understanding of the physical world. I think that would be a reasonable position.
- 2.44 If I discovered that my daughter was being taught mathematics using a textbook from 1924, I'd be delighted. I'd be, wow. I'd be calling up the school saying, "That's fantastic. Thank you. Well done. How do you do it? How do you do it?" Because I'm not worried that mathematics has changed in the last 101 years. Mathematics doesn't change. OK, new theorems are approved and so on and so forth. Maybe new techniques for doing sums and arithmetic and so on, but those are the tools. It's not the content, mathematics.
- 2.45 That's basically the Platonic view, and I would say, the dominant view up until the Enlightenment is that the world that is not subject to change and space and time is a more resilient real world precisely because we can't see it. That's why it's strong, that's why it's resistant, because it's not part of the world of sense experience, which is a world that is constantly changing, to the point where new physics textbooks have to be written and revised and updated in a way that is not true of mathematics textbooks, except that they have to be dumbed down and made weaker as we get stupider, or less able to deal with complex mathematics.
- 2.46 Back to the traits for the classical conception of God, this idea that God is not subject to change and that that's a power, that's a perfection, that God is not subject to change. Very difficult for us attuned to the world of science, as the benchmark for what counts as real and what counts as true, very difficult for us to accept that. But in the classical theistic mind, the fact that God is not vulnerable to change is part of His perfections.
- 2.47 Similarly, impassibility—God is not capable of suffering. He's not passive; He's not a victim of anything. He's not affected by external circumstances. We might say that God can change and He can suffer, but we're talking there in an anthropomorphic terms. We might talk about God changing, but in fact, what we mean is that we're changing. If somebody is standing to my right, then I am to that person's left. But if the person goes around my back and then stands to my left, my position has changed because I am now to that person's right, when I was to that person's left.

- 2.48** Have I undergone a change, though, really? No. I've just been standing here. The person has moved around. You can say, this is what philosophers call a Cambridge change—I can't quite remember why it's called a Cambridge change, but it's called a Cambridge change. Peter Geach is the philosopher who comes up with this. Geach's argument is that God changes in roughly the same way that I change, when I go from being on the person's left to being on the person's right. But I've not actually undergone any change. So God changes, but only in that way.
- 2.49** Also central to this notion of God being maximally perfect is this sense that God is one. God is unified. The famous Shema from Deuteronomy 6:4, "Hear, O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is one," proclaimed at the beginning and end of every day by the observant Israelites. And of course, we have in Islam this absolute centrality on the doctrine of Tawhid, absolute oneness, uniqueness, oneness, unity, simplicity of Allah. And yet, tensions emerge. You see this in Indian philosophy, too, with Vedanta, Brahman, this being that underlines everything, and that all reality is really just an undifferentiated reality.
- 2.50** And what we think of as plurality is, in fact, is Maya, is an illusion. This is central to Advaita Vedanta, Sankara's, probably the most famous school of Vedantic Indian philosophy. And so, there's this notion of oneness or monism, this idea that everything is one. But then there's also this tug on these doctrines of the many and of plurality and of diversity. You see it in all the traditions. In Judaism, think of the figure of Lady Wisdom in many of those texts, in many of the Hebrew texts. Wisdom is almost up there with God.
- 2.51** There are hints also, the Messianic hints in the Old Testament, of there being this being who's somehow on a par with God in some strange way. So that it's actually that God is not one, there's a kind of many in one, one in many. Now, most famously within Christianity, the doctrine of the Trinity emerges. This idea that God is one and is unified, and yet there's plurality in the oneness. From very, very early on, it seems early Christians insisted that Jesus of Nazareth was not just a very special, extraordinary human being, not just a miracle worker, not just a healer, not a soothsayer, not a wise teacher, but God. God.
- 2.52** All sorts of interesting arguments for that, but that does seem to have been, from very early on, the conviction of these radically monotheistic Jews in Galilee and Judea and Samaria. The conviction is that, for these people who are saying every day, twice a day, "Hear, Israel, the Lord your God, the Lord your God is one," are convinced that actually, no, there's a second, there's a binitarian way of thinking about God. That gets resolved at the Council of Nicaea in 325 AD, exactly 1700 years ago, in, I think it was September, where Constantine, Emperor Constantine, gathers all the bishops together in Nicaea, near Istanbul.
- 2.53** They had this huge debate as to whether or not Jesus is the second person of the Trinity or just a very, very impressive human being. But there was once, as Arius says,

the heretic says, "There was once when He was not. There was once when He was not." There was a point in time when Jesus did not exist, and he lost. And the Council of Nicaea insists that Jesus is not of a similar substance to God, but the same substance, partakes in the same substance. So this idea of plurality begins to emerge and test this claim of the radical unity of the divine.

- 2.54** Then with the Council of Constantinople, I beg your pardon, in 381 AD, the Holy Spirit is admitted into the Godhead, and we have a Trinity. So one in three, three in one, and so on and so forth. This tension between the one and the many, between unity and plurality, between, you might say, independence and autonomy and relationality and togetherness, is there everywhere.
- 2.55** It's even within Islam, even with Islam's enormous stress on Tawhid, on the absolute non-negotiable oneness of Allah, even there, and I sometimes tease Muslim friends about this, I asked them about the status of the Quran. And I ask the question that was asked of Arius, and Arius raised, "Was there once when the Quran was not?" Is the Quran a creature? Is the Quran something that comes into existence? Or is it the word of Allah that coexists eternally with Allah? That's the correct answer within Islamic theology.
- 2.56** So it seems there's more than just Allah. There's Allah, and there's Allah's word. Two things. There's the Quran. The Quran is not Allah, and Allah is not the Quran. But the Quran is also the word of Allah. That's why you can't really translate it out of classical Arabic. It is literally the word of God.
- 2.57** Different, by the way, from the way Christians understand the New Testament or Jews understand the Torah. For them, Scripture is a vehicle for the word of God, which for Christians is Jesus of Nazareth, the second person in the Trinity, Jesus Christ. It's just a vehicle. And the word, as it were, the word of God is the person, is the second person in the Trinity. Within Islam, Muhammad is the vehicle, imperfect human vehicle. And it's the language, it's the Scripture, the words that are the word of God.
- 2.58** It's a different way of thinking about it. It's completely opposite, a completely reverse way of thinking about the nature of scriptural authority. But within Islam, there is this idea, a hint of plurality within the Godhead, Allah and His word. If you think of the centrality of angels within Islam, angels aren't quite God, but they're very, very close, very, very high deities, and almost they've got sort of characteristics of the divine. So there are these great tensions.
- 2.59** Now, it's worth noting that these tensions are not particular to religion. They span across all philosophical ways of thinking about the nature of ultimate reality. Philosophers, whether they're religious or not, are always arguing about whether the nature of reality is ultimately one, an undifferentiated oneness, or whether it's radically plural and radically diverse. You might say that materialists, people who believe that all

reality is just stuff, is just matter, are, they're monists, they're oneists, because it's just one stuff that we're all basically reducible to. It's just atoms, just stuff.

- 2.60** If you are an idealist, you believe that all of reality is ultimately just mental. It's just mind, immaterial mind. Most theistic frameworks will be like that. But there's also this idea that the relationship between God and world is such that you've got two radically different categories, two radically different kinds of being, creator and creation. There's a plurality there that is non-negotiable, and that reality doesn't just reduce to a single substance, a single stuff.
- 2.61** We see this back and forth in secular philosophy, too. This is very common, actually. You'll often see that, as people get less interested in philosophy of religion, get more interested just in pure philosophy, putting away childish things, putting away questions of religion and God, you still see the same problems reemerge.
- 2.62** Let me give you an example. One of the oldest debates in the philosophy of religion, particularly within Abrahamic monotheistic theology, is the relationship between God's foreknowledge, God's knowledge, and human freedom. The problem, roughly, is, "If God knows what I'm going to have for breakfast tomorrow morning, and I'm staying in this lovely hotel with a great menu, it's just so much freedom to choose what I want, am I actually free? Could I falsify God's foreknowledge? Could I make God wrong? Could I make Him make a mistake by going for bacon and eggs over granola, when He was clear that it was going to be granola?"
- 2.63** Problem: I want to be free, and theologically, I have to be free, because if I'm not free, then what sense does it make to say that I've done wrong or that I sin or that I do good? What would it even mean to say, if I'm forced to do something, how can I—ought implies can. An obligation can be—that is where if you're coerced to comply with, does not earn you any praise, and it can't earn you any blame either. The freedom seems to be absolutely central. But if God's knowledge freezes my freedom because I can't act in such a way that would falsify His freedom, His foreknowledge, then am I really free? It's a classic problem.
- 2.64** Now, there are different ways of approaching this and resolving it. Some are more successful than others, but Augustine's view, for example, is that, no, God's foreknowledge doesn't undermine my freedom. God's foreknowledge underwrites, guarantees my freedom. What God knows is what I'm freely going to choose to have for breakfast tomorrow morning, says Augustine.
- 2.65** Another way of thinking about this—my children, when they were growing up, every Friday afternoon, when they came back from school, they were allowed pizza in front of the television—very, very relaxed liberal parents. When I was around, I would put a pizza in the oven before they came back from school. My son would walk in, and I'd say, "What do you want to do? What do you want to have for supper?" He says, "I want pizza." I said, "It's already in the oven, already in the oven." He was free to go for

spaghetti bolognese. I didn't tell him to have pizza, but it was already in the oven. Now, it's not a perfect analogy, but there are ways of reconciling the two.

- 2.66** Why do I bring up this example, this old chestnut, this old headache? Well, because even now that we put away childish things and we don't talk about God and religious questions anymore, we're still worrying about the relationship between scientific determinism and human freedom. If my actions and my behavior are programmed into me by adaptive fitness and survival of the fittest and so on and so forth, or by my genes, or by my environment, or whatever it might be, then how can I be free?
- 2.67** Because to be free, to act freely, is to say—if you say that somebody's acting freely, you are saying that they are acting over and above in a way that transcends the cumulative chains of scientific cause and effect that lead up to that action. To be free is to say, "I can intervene in the world and I can act freely without being conditioned exclusively by my genes and by my environment," and so on and so forth.
- 2.68** And so, the debate there is a secular debate. It's no longer a debate in the philosophy of religion, but it's still a problem. The relationship still between that sense of there being a framework that forces and determines me to act in particular ways, and on the other hand, this sense that we are free. The belief that we're free is a belief that is a bit like the hands that I mentioned in the previous lecture, is a belief I might not be able to prove that I'm free. What does freedom look like under a microscope? The same as nothing under a microscope. But does that mean it doesn't exist?
- 2.69** Well, just imagine to yourselves what it would be like if you really weren't free or you didn't believe you were free. I would propose that it's almost unthinkable. It's very, very hard for us to even contemplate how different the world would be. And it's just this basic commitment that is impossible to get rid of. It's a starting point around which we've got to organize all our other philosophy.
- 2.70** Now, that is actually a fairly radical position these days in contemporary philosophy. I'm a heretic on that issue, too. I really do believe we're free. It's this crazy idea that there are numbers and God is real and that we are free. These crazy, crazy beliefs. But I think it's both Cicero and Descartes said that there is no belief in the history of thought that isn't so absurd, so crazy, that some philosopher at some point hasn't signed up to it and defended it.
- 2.71** We've talked a little bit about classical theism and the different forms that that can take. These days, you might say there has emerged, particularly in the 20th century, in the last 100 years, a kind of theism that rejects classical theism but still understands itself as theism. There's not a great label for this, but let's call it theistic personalism, after the philosopher Edward Feser.
- 2.72** Theistic personalism—the idea here is that the standards that classical theism sets are just far too high, that we can't make sense of God as a person who we can pray to, have

a relationship with, ask for things, confess things to, thank things, thank Him for. He's this lofty, maximally perfect, excellent being that we can't really connect to at all.

- 2.73** And so this philosophy of religion has emerged that treats God more in, you might say, anthropomorphic or human terms. For example, like the philosopher Richard Swinburne, still alive, I think he's just turned 90 in Oxford, one of the great philosophers of religion of the modern age, along with Alvin Plantinga, an American from Calvin, taught at Notre Dame and Calvin College, both of them are theistic personalists.
- 2.74** Both of them reject the classical conception, the high conception of God as this perfect being, maximally excellent, maximally worthy of worship. For them, God is not, for example, a necessary being. God is contingent. God might not have existed. God is not outside time. God is a temporal being. God is a person with feelings and can suffer and can change. This is, if you like, a big debate now within philosophy of religion, particularly within monotheistic, Abrahamic monotheistic philosophy of religion, but particularly Christian.
- 2.75** I think, in Islam, the stress on Tawhid and the stress on the doctrine of absolute transcendence is so strong that it's very difficult for theistic personalism, really, to get off the ground within Islamic philosophy of religion. But it is the case more now in Christian philosophy of religion, that you're having this debate.
- 2.76** Interestingly, I would say in the last 20 years, the pendulum has begun to swing back to the classical conception. Actually, my sense, is, the arguments are now beginning to move in favor of this higher view, of this much more classical, austere picture of God as that perfect being, a maximally perfect being, the God of Augustine and of Anselm and of Aquinas.
- 2.77** What we're going to consider in the next lecture is one of the most fascinating arguments in the history of philosophy: an argument for the existence of God that goes right to the heart of this debate between the idea that God is a perfect being with all the omnis, the omni-god on the one hand, and on the other, this idea that that's just too high a threshold; it's too high a bar. It removes God as any kind of being with whom we can have any kind of relationship or any grasp or any understanding.
- 2.78** That, of course, is now called the ontological argument, the ontological argument. That is to say, an argument that goes to the heart of the being of God, top on, what God is and the nature of God's being. And we'll have a look at this argument which comes into being, as it were, like the world, out of nothing, in the mind of Anselm of Canterbury. He thinks of it, then he forgets it, and he has many sleepless nights. What was that incredible argument for the existence of God? He's just got it, and then he finally remembers it and develops it in this famous text, the Proslogion.
- 2.79** It is a fascinating argument. We'll come onto it in the next lecture. It's a fascinating argument because it doesn't rely upon inspecting anything in the world. It doesn't rely

on evidence. It relies on just being able to shut your eyes and reflect on the nature of God, the essence of God, and some claims, it's an extraordinary claim, that you can get to God's existence by just thinking through the nature of what it is to be God. Thanks for listening.

Lecture 3: Arguments for God

At a glance — The classical arguments for God's existence — cosmological, ontological, and design.

- 3.1** Welcome to lecture three of Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. We're now moving into the good stuff. We are moving into philosophical arguments, argumentation. In the last two lectures, we've just been really doing some scene-setting, getting a sense of the overview of the discipline. Now we're going to look at some arguments, theistic arguments, arguments for the existence of God. We'll be looking at the classical ones in this lecture, and in lecture four, we'll be looking at some more unusual ones, more contemporary arguments. That'll be it, actually. In a lot of philosophy of religion lecture programs in universities, an awful lot of time is spent on these arguments. We're just going to devote maybe a quarter of the course to them. There are various reasons for that.
- 3.2** First of all, I think one can overstate what philosophical arguments can do when it comes to religious supporting or providing some scaffolding for religious commitment. Because it turns the religious life and the spiritual life, or risks turning it, into an exercise in logic-chopping and dialectical philosophical dispute. And that is, whatever else the religious life is, it's not that. And so I want you to, as we go through these different arguments, for the arguments to sit quite lightly and not to be something that, really, is the be-all and end-all.
- 3.3** Often we talk about proofs for the existence of God. There are no proofs for the existence of God. Anyone who tells you that there's a proof for the existence of God doesn't know what they're talking about. I mean, there's an old sense of the word proof, which simply means to test, to probe. "The proof of the pudding is in the eating" means that the testing of the pudding is in the eating. But it's come to mean, the word has come to mean, that word has come to mean, something much more like dispositive, demonstrative proof, as you might get in mathematics or perhaps even science.
- 3.4** But that's not how philosophy works. Certainly not how philosophy of religion works. It's not actually how philosophy more generally works, either. There is no argument in the history of philosophy that amounts to a proof. There is no argument in the history of philosophy that a rational person couldn't hear and understand and still say, "Sorry, I don't buy it. I'm rationally entitled not to accept that argument." Theistic arguments are no different. There are no slam-dunks, as it were, in philosophy, and there are none when it comes to philosophy of religion.
- 3.5** What I will say, however, is that there are strikingly many arguments for the existence of God, relative to any other topic in the history of philosophy. Whether we're talking about those other big questions in philosophy: whether we have minds, whether there are souls, whether time is real, whether what is ultimate is material or mental, and so

on and so forth, whether we're free or whether we are determined—lots of arguments for and against those different positions in philosophy. But when it comes to questions, arguments, about the existence of God, there are dozens and dozens and dozens.

- 3.6** We're now going to be looking at the three, let's say, the three families of classical arguments, the ontological arguments, cosmological arguments, and teleological arguments, because there are at least half a dozen in each category. So, this is how we should be thinking about things. If God is God, if God is real, then arguments for the existence of God are going to be ones that we need to hold tentatively, as it were, treat as tentative, and simply be willing to be quite skeptical about what they can show, even if we find them convincing.
- 3.7** Let's start to think about what we're doing here. Let's think about the method. There are two basic approaches to how we explore the world, how we come to understand it in philosophical terms. We've got two fancy Latin phrases: *a priori*, *a posteriori*. *A priori* arguments, or *a priori* knowledge, really, *a priori* is a label that describes how we have knowledge, what kind of knowledge we have about the world, is knowledge that we have prior to getting up out of the armchair and inspecting the world and reasoning from the world and inferring from the world, inferring from observation.
- 3.8** *A priori* arguments are arguments that you can think through by just shutting your eyes and thinking. You don't need input from beyond the armchair. *A posteriori* arguments are arguments that are based on knowledge you acquire after you've got up off your posterior from the armchair and have started inspecting the world, taking in data, observations, and you infer from the observations. So two categories of arguments: *a priori* arguments and *a posteriori* arguments.
- 3.9** What's so striking about the first family of arguments we're going to be looking at, the ontological arguments, is that they are *a priori*. They are arguments that you can think through by simply sitting in your armchair and closing your eyes. And the ontological argument, the whole history of the ontological argument, begins really with Anselm of Canterbury. He was not, in fact, an Englishman. He was a European. I think he was born in the 11th century, around 1033. He is one of the first archbishops of Canterbury after the Norman invasion in 1066. A brilliant man, a brilliant mind, who emerges at a time when there isn't much literature around at all.
- 3.10** I once did an investigation into the library holdings in the monastery in Normandy that he had spent his early career in. It turned out that the library was virtually empty. He had access to very little beyond Scripture and a bit of Augustine. Perhaps it's not surprising that he had a lot of time with his own thoughts, wandering around the cloisters, round and round and round. In the course of one of these circumambulations, he comes up with this extraordinary idea, this extraordinary argument.
- 3.11** Now, there are actually almost certainly two versions of the argument. It goes something like this. It starts with the insight that, if God is that object, that which

commands our worship, commands our loyalty, our commitment, then that being must be a being that is somehow supreme. If it isn't supreme, then there'd be something incoherent and irrational in devoting ourselves, directing our worship towards a less-than-supreme being.

- 3.12** And Anselm takes this insight for granted, and it's not an entirely unreasonable one. And so he develops this thought in the Proslogion—this is the text, Chapter 2 of the Proslogion— and says, "God is that which," in the Latin, "aliquid quo nihil maius cogitari possit." "God is that than which nothing greater can be conceived." God is, as it were, that which dominates the very edges of the conceivable. This idea of God as a perfect being—we've touched on this idea already. God is maximally excellent.
- 3.13** He says that you can shut your eyes, you can sit in your armchair, and you can reflect on this idea, the limits of our conception. He then says, he moves on to say, well, when you're sitting in the armchair, you're holding God, as it were, the idea of God, this idea of God, as that than which nothing greater can be conceived in intellectu, in the understanding. He says we can just about do that. We can hold that. Even if we can't contain God with our understanding, we can have this idea of this maximally perfect being on the edges of what we can grasp.
- 3.14** Then he said that if God only existed, if such a being only existed in the understanding, then such a being would not be greater, more perfect, more real, more excellent than a being that existed in our understanding and also in reality. That's the key move. You hold this idea of a maximally perfect being in your mind, sitting in the armchair. Question: Which is greater? The being, the maximally excellent being that you're holding in your mind, or the maximally excellent being that you're holding in your mind that also exists? Which is greater?
- 3.15** Intuitively, Anselm thinks, obviously, it's greater to actually exist in reality, as well as to exist in our understanding as we're sitting reflecting in the armchair. And so God, as that maximally excellent, perfect being, exists in reality. That's the first version of the argument.
- 3.16** There's a famous objection to this, which is put into the words of a guy called Gaunilo. Gaunilo develops what's called the perfect island, or it's sometimes known as the perfect island objection. What Gaunilo says, he says, "I can conceive of a perfect island, my dream desert island. Then I can say, well, is it more perfect for the perfect island simply to exist in my fantasies, in my lottery fantasies? Or is an island more perfect if it exists in my fantasizing and in reality?"
- 3.17** Surely, it's more perfect for an island to exist in reality as well. But there is no such perfect island." This is in philosophy, this is what we call the *reductio ad absurdum*. Gaunilo says, "I've shown you a parallel argument, which ends in this plainly ridiculous conclusion; and therefore, the God argument, the ontological argument, also ends, the theistic version of the ontological argument, is also absurd."

- 3.18** Now, there are various responses that Anselm offers to this, and I think they're quite good counter-objections, but they lead him to refine the first version of the argument into something a little bit stronger. What Anselm points out is that, no, there's actually a relevant difference between God and an island, and a difference that, for Anselm, breaks down the parallelism between the arguments.
- 3.19** What Anselm then says is, islands are contingent. No island exists necessarily. Every island we can think of or point to might not have existed. It depends on something else for its existence. Whereas God does not have that status. God exists necessarily. Part of God's perfections is that He exists no matter what, if He exists at all. Therefore, there's a relevant distinction there.
- 3.20** But what it then does is force Anselm to refine his argument. He says, "God is that than which nothing greater can be conceived." And adds this version, adds this idea that a being that exists necessarily is more perfect than a being that happens to exist but might not have existed. This is his idea. A being that exists no matter what, who doesn't depend upon anything for his existence, who can't go out of existence, who can't cease to exist, who's never failed to exist, who exists in every possible world, is more perfect, is more worthy of worship, than a being that just got metaphysically lucky and happens to be around, maybe will be around for many, many millennia, but at some point will cease to exist, or only exists or exists eternally in one possible world, but not in all possible worlds.
- 3.21** Anselm then tweaks his argument and says—the definition of God—and says, "God is that being who cannot be conceived not to exist." You can't conceive of God not existing. The reason this responds well to the island objection is that islands just are the things that could exist or not exist. Even a perfect island is contingently perfect, just happens to be perfect; it is still dependently perfect. But God, if he exists at all, says Anselm in this third chapter of the Proslogion, exists by necessity.
- 3.22** This is the basic framing of the ontological argument. There were many—what's so interesting about it is—this was the 11th century AD—many more versions of it began to emerge. We have Descartes, the great philosopher, Descartes, 1596 to 1650, develops a version of it, slightly different. Spinoza develops a version of it as well, the Dutch philosopher of the 17th century. Kant, in his Critique of Pure Reason, in 1781, rehashes it, not in a way that—it is very hard to understand which version he is drawing on and tries to attack it and dismantle it, not very successfully, but it's still there, obviously, in the 18th century.
- 3.23** Then, in the post-war period, in the late 1960s, 1970s, the American philosopher Alvin Plantinga at Calvin College and then Notre Dame developed what's called the modal ontological argument, where he, as it were, rebuilt and reconceived the ontological argument in a way that made it very difficult for contemporary philosophers to dismiss or ignore. What Plantinga suggested was that we should really think of God in terms of

maximal excellence, that is to say, having all of the perfections that make something excellent. Then he introduces this idea of maximal greatness.

- 3.24** What's the difference between the two? For Plantinga, maximal excellence is the sum of all perfections in one possible world. Maximal greatness, a maximally great being, is a being who is maximally excellent in all possible worlds. Plantinga says that is, effectively, the equivalent of what Anselm is getting at, with God as that than which nothing greater could possibly be conceived, or rather could not be conceived as, not as failing to exist.
- 3.25** And so he goes on and says it's perfectly possible that there is a being who is maximally great. It's possible that there is a being who is excellent in all possible worlds. Certainly, you can think of at least one possible world in which God is maximally excellent, has all the perfections. Plantinga says, and one of those perfections is that He exists necessarily. But if God exists necessarily in one possible world, then there's no possible world in which he doesn't exist. Because what it is to exist necessarily is just to exist in every possible world.
- 3.26** If the atheist can grant that there's one possible world in which such a God, such a being exists, he has to grant that such a being exists in every possible world. And since the actual world is a possible world, that's probably the easiest premise of all to accept—the actual world we're living in, we know that's a possible one. Well, and since such a being exists in every possible world, God exists in the actual world.
- 3.27** It's a very powerful argument, and again, it's an argument from the armchair. We're not looking at cosmological constants. We're not arguing about Darwin. We're not arguing about biology or motion or causation or anything like that. We're staying in the armchair. It's all a priori with our eyes shut, just reflecting on what it is that we're talking about when we're talking about God.
- 3.28** Now, there have been all sorts of attempts to attack the argument. I mean, one, for example, I came across a few years ago, can't we run an argument for a maximally evil being? And say, well, to do a bit like the island parody, say, well, you could run this idea that there is a maximally evil being who exists in all possible worlds, or some other absurd necessary existence—various problems with that.
- 3.29** But of course, whatever it is we think evil is, plausibly, what evil is, is at the very least to lack perfections in some way, to have some defectiveness or deficiency, to be imperfect, to lack perfections. So it seems implausible to compare a maximally evil being with a maximally perfect being. There's nothing in the concept—a maximally evil being—that would lead us towards the view that such a being would exist in all possible worlds, in a way that there is, with this notion of a maximally perfect and excellent being, who is so supreme that, as it were, it floods all the possible worlds.
- 3.30** It's not a slam-dunk argument. As I said, there are no slam-dunk arguments. But what it does is, it puts a very heavy burden of proof on the atheist, because effectively, it

pushes the atheist into a position where he's got to deny that God exists in any possible world. He has to say that the very concept of God is incoherent, like a square triangle. Square triangles don't exist in any possible world, and God has to be of that logical contradiction, an impossible thought.

3.31 But I think, if you talk to most atheists, that's not their view. Their view is that God doesn't exist, but it's very rarely, God could not possibly exist, that there's no possible world in which God exists. I think you'll find very few atheists who are willing to go that far, that the very thought of God is like having the thought, the impossible thought, of a square triangle. That's a very, very high bar.

3.32 But then Plantinga's argument kicks in. The atheist will say, "I don't believe God exists. God does not exist, but God might have existed. There might have been some possible world in which such a being exists." Once he's granted that, then he has to explain why such a God would not also have the perfection of necessary existence. Once he grants that, then it is accepted that there are no possible worlds in which such a being does not exist, including the actual world.

3.33 So lots more to be said about ontological arguments. You can pick up any book on it and on the arguments, and you will see that there are at least two dozen sophisticated versions of the argument, and the philosophers are still fighting and battling away about it in the pages of the top-tier philosophy journals to this day. It's one of those arguments that just won't go away. That's the most famous a priori argument. That's the first family of arguments, the ontological arguments.

3.34 Let's move now onto the cosmological arguments. Why are they called the cosmological arguments? Well, partly, "kosmos" in Greek means world, but it also means order, decoration, harmony, beauty, even, where we get our word cosmetics. The word cosmos means world, but also ordered world, harmonious, attractive world.

3.35 Cosmological arguments are arguments that infer God's existence from certain features of the way the world is arranged, the way the cosmos is arranged. There are many different versions of the cosmological argument, at least three by Thomas Aquinas in the *Summa Theologiae*. There's an argument from motion, an argument from causation, and an argument from contingency or dependency. They all develop in a roughly similar way.

3.36 The argument from motion, probably the least popular these days, begins with the premise that things in the world are in a process of change and flux and motion. Motion doesn't really mean locomotion, but more— things in the world are in a constant state of transition from potency to act, from potentiality to actuality. This is an Aristotelian way of understanding change. And Aquinas then says, "Nothing moves itself. Everything is moved by another." Every transition from potentiality to actuality must be brought about by something that is already actual.

- 3.37** If something is just potential, then it can't bring itself into being because it's still in a potential state. So Aquinas says that there must be something, some actuating principle, that brings the thing in potentiality into actuality. And he says—and you can then ask: the actuating principle, what brought that actuating principle to be, out of potentiality? Well, some other actuating principle. And so on, you start this regress.
- 3.38** Aquinas' argument then is—and this is a feature of all cosmological arguments— can the regress go on forever? Can we keep writing checks that we can never really bank, promissory notes that we keep promising, but we can never quite deliver on? Aquinas says, "No. You can't have just an infinite series, an infinitely long series of actuating principles going all the way back."
- 3.39** There's a lot of debate and arguments as to whether or not it can be an infinite series. Mathematicians will note that you can have infinite series within a finite mathematical duration or number, just things that are infinitely divisible all the way down, but within finite parameters; that's not completely incoherent. But that's not what we're talking about. We're not talking about mathematical infinities when we're talking about the processes of causation, cause and effect, potency and act within nature, within the actual world.
- 3.40** One thought might be to say that if the process of change and motion stretches all the way back, infinitely far back into the past, how long would it have taken to get to the point where I'm speaking to you today? Well, presumably, it would have taken infinitely long to get to the point where I am speaking to you today. We would never actually have got to the—that chain would never, in fact, ended with me talking to you today, because it would have taken infinitely long to get to the point where I'm talking to you today.
- 3.41** But I am talking to you today. We stand at the end of some chain. However long it might be, it's not infinitely long. It's finite, because we're here, at the finis, at the end. So it must be that, however long the chain might be, of actuating principles of transitions from potency to act, motion, it's a finite one. It began at some point.
- 3.42** The question then is: How do we make sense of an actuating principle that doesn't require any other kind of activating, that is just pure act with no shadow of potency at all? Something that moves everything, but is not itself moved, an unmoved mover? Aquinas says, look, "Et hoc dicimus dei," and this is what everybody is talking about when they use the word God.
- 3.43** Now, as with all of these arguments, you could say, "An unmoved mover, a sort of big-daddy actuating principle, is not God. It's not the God of Abraham. It's not the God of the Bible. There's all these other claims that religious people make about God. He's not just this celestial mechanic, bringing everything into being." That's true, but it's also asking too much of the argument. It's not what the argument is trying to show. It's

simply trying to show that there is a being on which all of nature depends for its being brought from potency into act.

- 3.44** Now, that may not be the God of the Bible. It may not be the God that one thinks about, or one prays to on a Sunday in church or in a mosque on Friday or wherever in the synagogue on Saturday, but it's a pretty thick slice of God. It's probably too thick a slice of God and divinity for the atheist digestive system. That's OK, and that's enough for the theist. It's building up cumulative arguments and saying that it may not take us all the way to what is typically understood, traditionally understood as God, but it's taken us far enough down the road to abandon atheism. That's Aquinas' first way.
- 3.45** Second way, not so much from motion, more from causation. This is a particular way of understanding causation, not really in terms of temporal causes and effects over time, but more in the sense of what sustains space-time in creation at every moment of its existence. I think I mentioned in a previous lecture that you can't think of space-time holding itself up by its bootstraps. There's nothing in space and time that can hold up the space-time block. And so the question is: What is that sustaining?
- 3.46** Aquinas draws this distinction between what's called in Latin "per accidens" causation, cause and effect, ordinary cause and effect in time. A snooker ball or pool ball knocking into another pool ball, for example, that's one kind of causation. Or a grandfather, a man having a son and that person having a son, and there you've got a sort of causal sequence. And if the grandfather dies, the father doesn't, and if the father dies, the son doesn't necessarily. They're discrete; they're separate. That's per accidens causation.
- 3.47** Then Aquinas says there's "per se" causation. And per se causation is slightly different. Here, the example is, imagine you're holding a stick and you're pushing around a rock in a pool. So you've got arm, stick, and rock. There, Aquinas says, what you've got is a hierarchical causation, where there is dependence. So you take away the stick, and the rock ceases to move. You take away the arm, and the stick and the rock cease to move. There's a hierarchical ordering of causation.
- 3.48** It's not the temporal causation of grandfather to father to son. All of the, as it were, those three ingredients depend upon each other in a hierarchy in a way that is not the case with the grandfather, father, son. The grandfather can survive without the father and the son, and so on and so forth. Aquinas says the whole of the universe is like this. You think of the universe like a stick or like a rock. There is something that must be holding it up at every point in its existence. Something must be sustaining it, sustaining it now. If you remove any link, the series collapses straightaway.
- 3.49** Again, Aquinas argues, there must therefore be some first mover or first sustainer of creation, holding it all together. And so on and so forth. So that's an argument from motion. There's an argument from causation. We observe causation in the world. Nothing can be the cause of itself. And therefore, and an infinite series, an infinite regress of causes, is impossible, says Aquinas, for reasons that we touched on earlier.

And so, there must be some first ultimate cause that is not the cause of itself, that just exists no matter what. It's the second way.

- 3.50** Then the third way is from contingency. Things in nature, like Gaunilo's island, might not have existed. Everything in the natural world might not have existed. If everything were like that, if everything were contingent, then at some time, nothing would exist. If nothing ever existed, then nothing would exist now, because nothing can come from nothing. Nothing can't bring anything else, anything into being. And so there must be some being that exists no matter what. This is a cosmological argument from contingency.
- 3.51** Leibniz, the great 17th-century philosopher, develops his own version of this argument, not so much from contingency, but from explanation, from sufficient reason. Leibniz starts with this famous question, why is there something rather than nothing? Why is there something, why is there anything, when there might so easily have been nothing?
- 3.52** He develops this principle, the principle of sufficient reason. He says that for everything that exists, or rather everything that is true, there must be some reason why it's so. There must be some reason why it's true. There's nothing that exists or is true for no reason at all. Everything has a sufficient reason for its existence or for its truth. The collection of all contingent things that exist or are true is itself contingent.
- 3.53** And contingent things, dependent things, things that might not have been, cannot provide their own reason, their own sufficient reason, for why it is that they exist. There must be some being that is self-explaining, that is its own reason for why it exists at all. In other words, there must be some necessary being that just exists no matter what, that doesn't require explanation, that points to some other thing. Otherwise, there would be an infinite regress. This is Leibniz's cosmological argument.
- 3.54** The fifth and final cosmological argument I'll draw your attention to is one that has been brought back to life in the 1970s, partly as a result of discoveries in cosmology, particularly by Stephen Hawking and Roger Penrose in the 1960s, and in particular, the discovery of the Big Bang and Big Bang science. This is an argument that actually goes all the way back to the golden age of Islamic philosophy, in the last quarter of the first millennium. It's called the Kalam cosmological argument, and it's fairly straightforward to state.
- 3.55** Premise one: Everything that begins to exist has a cause. Premise two: The universe began to exist. Conclusion: The universe has a cause. Now, the first premise doesn't seem that uncontroversial, and the second premise doesn't seem so uncontroversial in the wake of Big Bang science. Before Hawking, before Big Bang theory, that second premise, that the universe began to exist, was one that was widely rejected by cosmologists. The view was that Aristotle was right and the universe had existed forever in a so-called steady-state theory.

- 3.56** There's an interesting anecdote, I think it's true. The college I was at for five years in Cambridge, St. John's College, had a famous cosmologist there called Sir Fred Hoyle. He cornered a young Stephen Hawking one day and said, "I hear you're challenging the steady-state theory with your clever mathematics. What are you going to call it, this beginning for the universe—theBig Bang?" It turned out that's exactly, the name stuck, and it turned out that's exactly what it is now called, without the sarcasm of Fred Hoyle.
- 3.57** It's an extraordinary moment in the relationship between science and philosophy. It's very rare that something happens in science that changes how a philosophical argument goes. But in this case, that discovery breathed new life into the second premise of the Kalam cosmological argument, namely the claim that the universe began to exist.
- 3.58** The first premise is that everything that begins to exist has a cause. There must be something that makes it begin to exist. It can't just bring itself into existence, because in order to bring itself into existence, it must already exist. So they're both quite solid premises. And once you accept them, then it's very hard to walk away from the idea or reject the idea that the universe, because it began to exist, has a cause.
- 3.59** And then you could say, "Is that cause of the universe within the universe?" No. Because nothing can bring itself into existence. Nothing can make itself exist. So it has to be something outside the universe, outside space and time. Well, what could that be? What are the kinds of things that are outside space and time? You might say mathematical objects, numbers, geometric forms.
- 3.60** But the trouble with triangles and dodecahedrons and the number 49 is that they may exist necessarily, and they may exist, they may be immune to the Big Bang, they may be immune to the Big Crunch, they may exist no matter what, but they don't make stuff happen. The number 2 just sits there. The number 49 just sits there. Triangles don't do anything. They are causally inert. The number 2 cannot trigger the Big Bang.
- 3.61** What else is outside space and time that might have vast causal powers, vast powers of reason, intent? What could it be? Well, maybe it's not the God of the Bible, maybe it's not the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, but it is a being that satisfies a lot of the shopping list of criteria that we would associate with God. Again, probably far more criteria than an atheist or indeed an agnostic would be comfortable with.
- 3.62** That's the second family of arguments. We've done the ontological arguments, we've done the cosmological arguments—and when I say we've done them, I really just rehearsed them very, very briefly, and I've not had the time to canvas many and various objections that have been leveled against them. We're moving at speed, so that I can give you a feel for the landscape, a feel for the terrain, and you can then dive in and zoom in closer in your own private study later on.

- 3.63** In the few minutes left, let's look briefly at the third family of classical theistic arguments: the teleological arguments, or better known as design arguments, "telos" in Greek meaning end or goal or horizon, function. Teleological arguments are arguments that appeal to certain claims about what something is for, what its goal is, what it's directed to. There are lots of versions of this.
- 3.64** One famous one is by the late 18th-century English thinker, he was at Cambridge, William Paley. This is Paley's watch. Paley says that you come across a watch on a heath, and you would observe the complex functional organization of a watch, and you would infer, says Paley, a watchmaker.
- 3.65** Then Paley draws an analogy to living organisms. You look at living organisms, you look at their complex hierarchical, functional arrangement, and you'd say that something, some mind must have put all the processes in place, all the enabling conditions in place, to lead up to and to account for this complexity. Therefore, these natural objects have some sort of designer, in the same way that the watch on the heath has a designer.
- 3.66** Now, these arguments come in from a lot of criticism. It's not the best argument. It's probably the weakest of the design arguments. I suppose the main problem with it is that it mistakenly associates living organisms and the kind of design and functionality that a living organism has with the kind of functionality that an artifact has. So, you might say that an acorn has an internal design arrangement that is, as it were, pointing towards an oak tree. It's designed to become, its fulfillment, its telos, as it were, is to be an oak tree. We can account for that, as it were, because of its internal arrangement, not something that has been imposed upon it.
- 3.67** That's not the same with a watch. It's not the same with an artifact. With an artifact, you've got an object with the design and the plan, as it were, overlaid and imposed upon it extrinsically. And what it means is that, if we can account for the internal arrangement of living organisms in some other way, then we don't need to worry about some external power imposing design upon objects as artifacts.
- 3.68** It's interesting that Paley was at the same college, Christ's College in Cambridge, as Charles Darwin. Darwin, of course, in 1859, published *The Origin of Species*, and this was widely considered to have provided some explanation of how it is that living organisms have the complex internal functional arrangements, and that this will do as an explanation. We don't need to appeal to God as a grand, intelligent designer.
- 3.69** Darwin was thought to have a knockout punch because natural selection, adaptive fitness, explains apparent, the appearance of design without a designer. This is what Richard Dawkins calls the blind watchmaker. The watchmaker, of course, is alluding to William Paley, but the watchmaker is blind. The natural selection, Darwinian evolution, is blind. It neither knows nor cares. It's not directed by God. It's not directed by a designer.

- 3.70** Now, those arguments have been quickly dismissed in modern times. I mean, actually, I think that there are ways of reworking them, and the so-called intelligent design movement that has been running, I guess, since the mid-1990s in earnest, people like Phillip Johnson and Stephen Meyer, William Dembski, have tried to resuscitate them in all sorts of interesting ways. Those arguments have spilled over a little bit into the culture wars in the United States, and so they've been rendered a little low-status, you might say. They tend not to have the dialectical power that they used to have.
- 3.71** The one that really has occupied philosophers a great deal more is different version of the design argument, different version of the teleological argument, that isn't at all interested in living organisms, but is interested more in the enabling conditions for carbon-based life to get going at all, never mind the actual details of how it does get going and how it does develop. This is the so-called fine-tuning argument.
- 3.72** Again, this comes from, like the Kalam argument, it comes from discoveries in modern physics. Effectively, what modern physics has uncovered is something that William Paley could never have dreamed of, that there are fundamental constants in the arrangement of the cosmos that appear to be perfectly calibrated for life. No matter how we then come to think about how life, in fact, develops on this rock in a faraway galaxy that just happened to get lucky, it's the conditions that are in place, exquisitely balanced, to provide the life-permitting ranges, that these conditions have to be perfect.
- 3.73** There are various examples that are educed. Martin Rees, who was formerly the Astronomer Royal in Britain and was a master of Trinity College, Cambridge, an extraordinary college in Cambridge that's won more Nobel Prizes than France, produced a lot of brilliant scientists. Martin Rees wrote a book many years ago called *Just Six Numbers*. *Just Six Numbers*, and each number was—he devoted a chapter to each of these numbers.
- 3.74** Each number was one of these perfectly balanced, exquisite cosmological constants. One is the gravitational constant. If the gravitational constant had been slightly stronger, infinitesimally stronger, the stars would have burnt out too quickly. If they'd been weaker, no heavy elements would have formed. No possibility for carbon-based life. The strong nuclear force— if there'd been tiny changes, it would have prevented the formation of carbon, or all hydrogen would have converted into heavier elements and so on and so forth.
- 3.75** There are six of these numbers, and they all have to be exquisitely calibrated together. You're getting to the point where the probabilities are just mind-bogglingly large. The probability of it being just an accident, that we have a cosmos that is perfectly calibrated for carbon, the emergence of carbon-based life, becomes wildly improbable. Look, you might—it is possible, I suppose, for the atheist to say this is just chance. Maybe we just got incredibly lucky, but the odds are astronomically small.

- 3.76** Other attempted objections are the so-called multiverse objection. Maybe the universe that we're living in is one of many, many, many, many, many universes, and it just so happened that this is the universe that got lucky with the constants. Now, as a response, an objection that has become very popular, I think it's a pretty terrible objection because it just pushes the problem further up. It's, "Well, who's generating all these multiverses, including the one that is perfectly calibrated for carbon-based life?"
- 3.77** It also commits what's called the inverse gambler's fallacy. The gambler's fallacy is the guy who goes and plays vingt-et-un in a casino and loses 20 times in a row, and on the 21st day says, "I have to win now. I've got to win this time." Now, that's a fallacy because what are his chances of winning on the 21st day of playing vingt-et-un? The same as they were on day one: 1 in 21. But the gambler, of course, thinks that his lucky number's got to come up.
- 3.78** The inverse gambler's fallacy is the multiverse objector who comes along and sees, "Hey, we won. We've got this life-permitting, exquisitely calibrated, exquisitely balanced cosmos. So it must have been the case that we tried many, many, many generations, many, many times on the gambling table, and then we got lucky. So there must be many, many, many universes before, and it so happens that this time we got lucky."
- 3.79** But what are the odds for every time the multiverse machine produces a universe that just so happens to fall perfectly within these very, very complex, these tiny, infinitesimally small parameters? The same every time. It's the same every time. The inverse gambler's fallacy is, "I just walked into a casino, I saw someone roll double sixes, so they must have been rolling for a very long time." Come on, we look at this universe. The multiverse machine must have been humming away for many, many, many millennia. It doesn't work.
- 3.80** What we have here, then, is a claim that the way that the universe is calibrated can't be really understood in terms of physical necessity. It's not clear what laws of nature could have brought these constants about. Why? Because the laws of nature presuppose these constants being in place, by and large. So it's not a physical necessity. It seems wildly unlikely that it's chance. The only alternative, however improbable otherwise, is that a mind, a will, an intent, as it were, hovers behind, explains why it is that the cosmos is so exquisitely calibrated for the emergence of carbon-based life.
- 3.81** That's the end of—that's the final move, the final development, over the last, what, 200, 250 years of the teleological arguments. And that's the third family of classical arguments for the existence of God. We've looked at the ontological arguments, cosmological arguments, and the teleological arguments. That concludes lecture three, and it sets us up for lecture four, where we'll be considering some more contemporary and, I think, fun and interesting arguments for the existence of God that are not so well-known. Thank you for listening.

- 3.82** You mentioned that teleological might be the weakest. Which one would you say, of the classical arguments, would be the strongest?
- 3.83** I think that final version of the teleological argument, from fine-tuning, which is a kind of design, it's just not biological design, it's more cosmos design, is actually pretty strong. I think the Kalam argument is very strong. Whatever begins to exist has a cause. The universe began to exist, and the scientists tell us that. It's a very good example of science and religion, science coming to the aid of religion. It's science that's telling us that the universe began to exist.
- 3.84** So the universe has a cause that can't—and that cause can't be drawn from within the universe itself because nothing can bring itself into existence. And so it's got to be something outside the universe. And really, the only candidates you've got for that are abstract objects like numbers and geometric forms that don't do anything, or what are the other things that are not completely located in space-time that can act on the world? Persons. You and me. We're acting on the world all the time.
- 3.85** And very plausibly—this is a separate argument for the next lecture series on philosophy of mind—we're not just causal machines. We are, to some extent, programmed by our genes and by our environment, but we're also free. We can intervene in the world all the time in a way that cuts against our genes and physics, forcing us to do particular things. At least we can get a grip on that idea, even if we think it's false. We can understand how you might think that.
- 3.86** You could say that God is a person, God acts, and God can also act in a way that cuts through cause and effect or heredity, or genes, or whatever it might be. God is a person with immense causal powers, immense rational powers, intent, will, desire. We may not like that conclusion, but it's a perfectly plausible one. It's one that, you could say, it's not a scientific one. But remember, we're looking for a non-scientific, something that is outside the universe, because if we don't find something that's outside the universe, it's not going to be a good explanation for why the universe as a whole comes into being.

Lecture 4: New Arguments for God

At a glance — Newer arguments for God, moving beyond the traditional classical proofs.

- 4.1 Welcome to lecture four of Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. We're going to be diving now, having looked at some of the traditional classical arguments for the existence of God that support the rationality of religious commitment, we're going to be looking at some less common ones, some more surprising ones, ones that don't typically make it into the big textbooks, but which are, I think, striking.
- 4.2 This whole question of God and divinity and God's existence is an amazingly generative area within philosophy. It's amazing how it just, new arguments keep developing, keep popping up. Some of them are very interesting, some of them are a little bit more eccentric, but there are dozens and dozens of these now, and each of them is worth spending a little bit of time on. I thought I would just give you a taste in this fourth lecture of what some of those arguments, those more unusual arguments, look like.
- 4.3 The first one I thought we could touch on is— it's an interesting argument. It's not so much an argument for the existence of God directly, but it's rather an argument for skepticism about understanding the processes of human origins and development and evolutionary terms as something that is just guided by the blind watchmaker we referred to at the end of the previous lecture, purely just natural selection, just the forces of adaptive fitness that are directing our development as human beings. This is the so-called, now being called, the evolutionary argument against naturalism.
- 4.4 Remember in an earlier lecture, I had suggested that naturalism is the view that all truths are scientific truths, natural truths, or reducible to scientific truths, and therefore, that there couldn't be God's intervening in natural processes.
- 4.5 This argument that developed, it's developed again by Alvin Plantinga, but you find it in C. S. Lewis' book called Miracles from the 1950s, and there's even versions of it in G. K. Chesterton's Orthodoxy, and even a version of it in a very old and now-forgotten book by none other than a British Prime Minister, Arthur Balfour, who delivered some of the famous Gifford lectures at the beginning of the 20th century, and those, that book became known as, I think, Theism and Naturalism. It's a very interesting book.
- 4.6 The idea here is that what evolution is interested in, what natural selection is interested in, is not human beings developing with the cognitive equipment to track truth. That's not what adaptive fitness and natural selection is interested in. The only thing it's interested in is survival, adaptive fitness and survival. Plantinga's point is that sometimes coming up with true beliefs about the world will mean that we survive better, that we're fitter. But that's not the primary focus of adaptive fitness; it's just survival.

- 4.7 Because there will sometimes be times when believing false things will be conducive to survival. Obviously, if you can count how many tigers are in the next-door valley and how many tigers are in this valley, you're going to tend to have better chances of survival. But there are equally evolutionary scenarios where you could imagine having false beliefs about the world could also confer survival value. After all, what is it that atheists often tell us religion is except for a false belief system that, nevertheless, has existed for a long time? It's a very persistent phenomenon, religion. It's never really gone away. It's been there from the very dawn of humanity.
- 4.8 And so, this is a false belief system. Well, they can't all be true, but nevertheless must have some survival benefit. In order to explain why it's been around so long, it must be capable of conferring survival values, maybe the consoling power of religion, to help deal with grief or the loss of loved ones, loss of loved ones to the tigers you hadn't quite added up properly, but before the attack.
- 4.9 What Plantinga is arguing is that there has to be some process or there must be some overarching, call it, providence, a trajectory of providence, on theism that better explains why it is that human beings have evolved broadly in a way, with cognitive faculties, minds that track truth and not just survival, whereby we can say that our cognitive capacities are, broadly speaking, reliable. Not perfect, of course, but broadly speaking, reliable.
- 4.10 If the ultimate account of how it is we came to think and how we've come to navigate the world and think about the world is only in terms of survival-seeking, then we couldn't really rely on our conclusions, on any of our conclusions about the world being true because the processes that have led to our having beliefs about the world are not interested in truth. They're just interested in survival. And so what that brings in with it is this idea, this specter of skepticism. And it means that we start carving off, cutting off the branch that we're sitting on.
- 4.11 So that evolutionary argument against naturalism is, again, is not quite an argument directly for theism, but it's a very important assault on the central rival in philosophy to theism, namely naturalism. It does, in fact, offer a story on the theistic picture of how it is that human beings have developed with cognitive capacities that are more reliable because, as it were, instilled or overseen by a benevolent creator, rather than a blind watchmaker who's not interested in truth or falsehood or good or evil, but simply survival. I thought we'd just quickly rehearse that one: naturalism seems to undermine its own rational credentials because it appeals, ultimately, to a process that's not interested in reason, not interested in truth, but only survival.
- 4.12 The second nontraditional argument I thought we would look at is one that we've touched already a little bit on mathematics and on numbers and on geometric forms. These are good examples of what philosophers call abstract objects. Abstract objects are typically contrasted with concrete objects.

- 4.13 So concrete objects are objects that are in space and time, have some kind of causal power, and are, generally speaking, analyzable in scientific terms. Abstract objects are outside space and time and are not capable of causal interaction. Now, some people think that there are abstract objects. Other people say that there are no such things as abstract objects. These are just figments of our imagination that we make up.
- 4.14 You have to accept in the first place that there are abstract objects, but many do; many who are not theists accept that there are numbers, that there are forms, propositions, possible worlds, that they have a kind of reality. The question then is, well, how do we make sense of these abstract objects? How do they come to be? What do they depend upon? Are they part of creation, if they've always existed, if they've timelessly existed?
- 4.15 And what you have is this kind of dualism, this split that you find in Plato between the world of the cave and the flickering flames on the back of the cave, and the world of the sun. You've had the world of the concrete cave, cave light, and the world of the abstract sunlight outside. And for Plato, it's just taken for granted that there's this pathway that leads you up out of the cave and into the sun, and you can go back down again. But in fact, it's much harder to see how those two domains are connected. Very, very difficult to see how the two domains are connected.
- 4.16 St. Augustine comes along in the 4th century, and he makes a suggestion. He says that we've got this Platonic heaven full of numbers and sets and propositions and all these abstract objects that sit there timelessly, spacelessly, without ever having come into existence, without ever ceasing to exist, but that can't cause anything, can't have any impact on the world, wouldn't it make sense to move Plato's heaven into the divine mind? Wouldn't it make sense to think of all these abstract objects as something like ideas or thoughts in God's mind?
- 4.17 Once you have that picture, then the relationship between the world of the sun and the world of the cave becomes much easier to understand. It becomes more like the relationship that we are familiar with, of our minds and our thoughts and our imaginations, our beliefs, kind of abstract, if you like, and our concrete bodies, our concrete engagement in the physical world.
- 4.18 It's a much, much better, more plausible analogy of how these two domains might fit together. Because God has causal powers, but he's also outside space and time. So these abstract objects, they're like the thoughts, the ideas of God, but they're not completely sealed off. They are, as it were, woven into the concrete world. So that's an argument from abstract objects, that also explains the necessity of abstract objects and their universality.
- 4.19 Third argument I thought we would look at, the third nontraditional argument, is an argument I've been thinking about quite a bit recently, and it's the argument from information. Information. Again, here we can point to recent discoveries in science, in particular, another Cambridge, other Cambridge scientists, Crick and Watson, the

discovery of the double helix in the Eagle Pub in Cambridge. You can still visit the little table where they sat over lunch and sketched on a napkin, on a serviette, what the double helix would look like.

- 4.20 Why is that so interesting? Why is the discovery of DNA so interesting philosophically? What's so interesting about the discovery of DNA is that DNA contains information. It's not like discovering some rare species or crystals or a planet. As it were, it is a physical object, but that contains information. That's what DNA is, acids that contain information. Information operates within a symbolic rule-governed system. That's what information is.
- 4.21 But we're not reading the information into DNA. We're reading off it. We're not inventing it; we're discovering it when we examine DNA. We're mapping out the human genome. How is this an argument for the existence of God? How is it that we've got, within cellular systems and in proteins, information? How do we make sense of this, and why is it suggestive? Why might it point towards a theistic conclusion?
- 4.22 Well, if you just think of all other kinds of information, all other vehicles, concrete, physical vehicles of information—books, computer programs, maps, blueprints, musical scores—you might look at those and you think, well, we never observe coded information that arises from purely natural processes. There's information in a book—we know that somebody wrote the book. There's information in a computer program—we know somebody wrote the computer program, the map, the blueprint and so on and so forth.
- 4.23 What happens when we come across something in the world that contains not just any old information, but unbelievably complex information? Remember, information is signs, they're symbols. They're not like atoms or molecules. They operate within their own symbolic universe with their own kinds of rules. How do we make sense of this? Well, the inference, the best explanation, so the argument goes, is that the best explanation of the origin of this information is intelligence, some kind of intelligence.
- 4.24 Because remember, what the DNA is, it's like software, programming the hardware of the human body. And so, here we've got—I suppose you could say it's a version of the design argument. It has to be some account of how the information, how information got there. You don't need to necessarily say exactly how it got there. You can completely accept neo-Darwinian evolutionary theory about how it's got there, but that's still not going to be able to explain how it is that there's any information there at all that we stumble upon, that we discover, we can map out, but we don't ourselves impose upon nature.
- 4.25 The fourth argument is an argument from what philosophers call intentionality. Intentionality doesn't mean to do with what we intend to do. Intentionality comes from the Latin word "intendo", which means to point towards, to tend towards, to tend upon. The idea here is that our thoughts about the world point to the world. I can be

thinking about a shoe on the floor, and the question is: What is the nature of that relationship, the relationship between my thought about the shoe on the floor and the shoe on the floor? How does my thought hook onto the shoe?

- 4.26 It's a strange relationship. It's almost certainly not a causal connection, like a knocking into something, because I can think about something millions of miles away that there can be no causal connection to at all. And yet my mind is related to, intends that particular object that could be millions of miles away. Thoughts are about things. They are pointed towards things, but not in some sort of physical way, because thoughts aren't physical. How do we make sense of this?
- 4.27 Well, on a theistic picture, the idea that minds would emerge that were capable of hooking onto the world with their thoughts is not completely unsurprising. Maybe it's not predictable, but it's not wildly beyond what might be expected. On a naturalistic starting point, on the starting point that there are no thoughts, it's just neurons in the brain, and there's no mysterious relationship between cells in the brain and faraway planets or shoes on the floor, it's very puzzling as to how it is that we're able, that thinkers emerge in a naturalistic process that can have thoughts that intend or are directed towards things in the world—the argument from intentionality.
- 4.28 The next argument is one version of, actually, a family of arguments, a family of moral arguments, for the existence of God. This is an argument from, you might say, moral knowledge or moral epistemology. How do we come to know right and wrong? Now, there are different naturalistic accounts of how we come to learn right and wrong. It could be, maybe it's society that tells us what's right and wrong. Maybe it's our emotions that tell us what's right and wrong. Maybe it's our families who tell us what's right and wrong. Maybe we just say that the law is all that's there to tell us right and wrong. Or maybe evolution is what shapes our moral knowledge, our moral impulses.
- 4.29 Now, the trouble with those accounts, a little bit like the evolutionary argument against naturalism, is that this doesn't give us any really secure moral knowledge about the world. You could imagine a society conferring radically inadequate and defective moral knowledge upon us. And if society is just the authority, if society is what tells us what's right and wrong, then we're not even in a position to say that society has told us to know morally wrong things.
- 4.30 So the impulse is that morality must be something that sets a benchmark against which any given society must measure itself. And so, again, we come to this idea of: What is it that could structure a moral universe? What is it that could structure the universe of right and wrong?
- 4.31 Whatever the answer to that is, it can't be a naturalistic one. It's not a scientific problem, that. Morality is not science. Right and wrong is not science. Good and evil are not scientific problems. Some people might think science could explain them away, but morality is something that we feel keenly, as something that is real. We feel horror

when evil is committed. We feel joy and a sense of awe when some noble deed is done and so on and so forth. We feel guilt when we fail in our obligations to one another.

4.32 And so the question is: How do we account for this moral universe? And how do we account for the impulse that is conscience within us that seems to track how the moral universe is structured? Now, one very attractive answer to that is the theistic one, that there is an omni-benevolent, all-loving God, who has structured not only the natural world, but with it, the normative universe as well.

4.33 You have a natural universe and you have a normative universe, and the two come together. The normative, the moral, and value is woven into the natural processes of creation. And our moral knowledge, our moral sense, our moral intuition, may not be perfect the whole time, but generally speaking, human beings have evolved, have developed, in a way that converges upon broadly accurate moral intuitions and moral instincts, moral judgments, and moral knowledge.

4.34 The next argument, back to mathematics. Here we've got—this is argument seven, I think—this is a very unusual argument. It's different from the one that I discussed earlier, the argument that simply appealed to the existence of mathematical objects. This is more to do with this, what the philosopher Eugene Wigner called "the unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics," the unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics. What does he mean by that phrase?

4.35 What he meant by the phrase is: How is it that mathematical reality that's outside space and outside time and doesn't cause anything fits so perfectly with physical reality, reality that is inside space, inside time, that does enter into causal interactions with things? This is a deep puzzle. How is it that you can express physical laws in elegant mathematical terms? It seems so strange, that, because these are two totally different domains.

4.36 In Platonic terms, it's the world of the cave and the world of the sun. These are totally different. How is it possible? How is it possible that a mathematician with a pencil and paper can sit at his desk and predict things about the physical world, just by doing mathematics? As was the case with Peter Higgs, who in, I think, the 1960s, predicted the existence of the so-called God particle, or now called the Higgs boson particle, which I think was discovered and demonstrated to exist, I think, by the Large Hadron Collider in CERN in Geneva, I think 15 years ago.

4.37 But Peter Higgs predicted it, just by doing mathematics in the mid-1980s, said that this is—the mathematics suggests that there is this thing, this particle that exists. And he was right. He didn't do any experiments. He just sat at his desk with a pencil and paper, doing some mathematics. So how is it that there is this relationship between the world of physics and the world of mathematics?

4.38 Most physics now is, in effect, mathematics, partly because the ability of physicists to use mathematics now vastly outstrips our technological capacity to come up with the

experimental equipment that we need to test the conclusions or the hypotheses of our best physicists.

- 4.39** There's no reason, a priori, why maths should be able to describe reality. Why? It just seems a completely different language from science. Science can't tell us why mathematics explains the world, because science presupposes mathematics. You couldn't do science without mathematics. How is it that these two domains dovetail so neatly? How is it that the same mathematical principles cover very, very different physical domains? It seems very, very strange, certainly on naturalism.
- 4.40** You could imagine a universe where mathematics was completely irrelevant to describing the physical world, completely irrelevant to setting out the laws of nature. $E = mc^2$. I mean, why is the multiplication between m and c and the squaring of the speed of light, how can that hook onto the way the physical world works, just that neat square function? It could have been to the power of 64 or cubed or whatever, or it could have been nothing. It could have been no mathematical way to describe it. And yet, we can, perfectly, exquisitely.
- 4.41** So these remarkable correlations cry out for explanation. It's not the philosophically prudent thing to do, to say, "Oh, well, we live in this funny world, and thank goodness, we can do. We can describe the world in mathematical terms. We can do science using mathematics." That doesn't really satisfy. The argument concludes that what is the best explanation on the table for how it is that the mathematical universe dovetails, converges, so precisely, with such exquisite precision on the way the natural world is and how the natural world is to be understood and read.
- 4.42** Again, the hypothesis is that, on the theistic framework, what we're doing when we see all the mathematics within our explorations of the physical world, or when we use mathematics to predict features of the physical world, what we're exploring is, as it were, the harmony that exists between God's mind, between the divine mind, and as it were, God's creative causal output in creation. So it's not surprising.
- 4.43** Just as it's not surprising if we pick up a play by Shakespeare and we can just read it. Yes, it's a book, it's physical, it's paper, but there's also within it the signs of, as it were, drama, there's poetry, beauty, that is woven into the physical pages. It's not surprising on theism that there would be a world that exhibits the kind of rational order that we find when we explore—it turns out that we can explore it using mathematics, or that when we do explore it, it turns out that it exhibits all kinds of interesting mathematical relationships.
- 4.44** It turns out that what Eugene Wigner says, when he talks about the unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics, is that it's not, in fact, unreasonable on theism. It's perfectly reasonable. It's perfectly predictable. It's what you would expect on theism, what you would expect there to be between the domain of mathematics and the

domain of nature and physics. So, that's an important argument that has developed quite a lot. There's been a lot of debates about it in recent years.

- 4.45 It's worth pointing out that, for some people, the best way around this—some naturalists and atheists will say—the best way around this is to say, look, there just isn't really any mathematics out there in the world. Really, what's happening with mathematics is, we think we're discovering mathematical truths, but really, what we're doing is, we are creating them or we're inventing them, or we're trying to map out our own logical worlds that belong to us and not out there in the world.
- 4.46 And so, you have theories like fictionalism, fictionalism. The fictionalist believes that there aren't any mathematical truths exactly, but there are ways that you can be mathematically correct. So the example one might use is, we could say that it's, is it true that Sherlock Holmes smoked a pipe? Well, yes, it is, at one level, but also it's not true that Sherlock Holmes smoked a pipe. Why? Because Sherlock Holmes doesn't exist. He's never existed. He never smoked anything.
- 4.47 And so, mathematical fictionalists, they say that's kind of what mathematics is. It's what we're doing with mathematical truths is we're discovering things, but things that are internal to systems we've already invented. In Conan Doyle world, it is true that Sherlock Holmes smoked a pipe, and it's false that he smoked cigars. But it's also completely false because it's not any description of reality. It's just within the imaginative universe.
- 4.48 So what fictionalists say, to get away from the threat that mathematics poses, mathematics as a real, genuine debate poses, is to say, well, we have this kind of world of human understanding, and internal to that, we develop processes and, as it were, systems within which we can say a mathematical claim is either correct or it's incorrect. It's not that it's true exactly because it's not something that's in the world.
- 4.49 Now, this has been going for—attempts to develop this as a powerful theory have been going on for nearly 50 years now. I mean, yeah, nearly 50 years. Hartry Field is the most famous proponent of mathematical fictionalism. It's very attractive in many ways, but it's not—I think it's fair to say, it's not really commanded consensus across the board. There are lots of different theories of mathematical fictionalism, and it's still very puzzling to accept it as true.
- 4.50 Those of you who know the fascinating story of Fermat's Last Theorem, and Andrew Wiles, this young Cambridge mathematician, or actually he's an Oxford mathematician, but his father spent a lot of time in Cambridge, and the discovery happened in Cambridge. He spent seven years locked away in a room with a pencil and paper, not telling anybody what he was working on, actually working on cracking Fermat's Last Theorem, proving it to be true.
- 4.51 This French polymath Fermat, I think from the 17th century, had left this marginal note suggesting that he had cracked it, he had discovered this theorem. Now, it turns out he

almost certainly didn't, but Andrew Wiles did, and it took him an awfully long time. If you just sit back and look at that wonderful story, it's a wonderful book by Simon Singh that talks about a wonderful account of Fermat's Last Theorem.

- 4.52 But if you just look at what's happening, what was happening with Andrew Wiles, and you watch the interviews with him afterwards, and you think, is this a man who is wrestling with trying to understand the human world of mathematics? Or is he, in fact, moving through unbelievably complex conceptual galaxies, trying to connect and uncover different truths?
- 4.53 It seems to me, maybe this is no more than mere intuition, it seems to me that it's the latter that he was doing, that he was exploring, he was discovering the mathematical world. He wasn't just, as it were, mapping it out or constructing it or just trying to uncover what had been there in virtue of certain human mathematical models. But that would be one way to try to get away from the theistic argument, the theistic solution to the unreasonable effectiveness of mathematics.
- 4.54 Next argument, penultimate argument, is an argument from, you might say, consciousness, consciousness. Here, again, one could say, "Do we really believe that there's such a thing as consciousness, conscious awareness, a kind of subjective what it is like to be a human being, that we couldn't just explain in terms of neuroscience?" Many are convinced that consciousness is something that is real, perhaps in the same way that we'd be convinced that, or it's very hard to convince us, that we are not free.
- 4.55 Try to convince yourself that you're not really conscious, or that your consciousness is an illusion, or a firing of your brain as opposed to your mind. It's very difficult to get to grips with that idea. It really does seem as if we have mental states, conscious states, and beliefs, and that we reason about the world, and that those processes are fundamentally different from the effects and connections and states that science discovers, that science explores, which are physical states, brain states.
- 4.56 But it does seem to be that mental states are not the same thing as physical states. It'd be very odd if we could put brain cells under a microscope and work out what the person had been thinking. That's not a limitation of science. It's just, there are certain areas that science can't dive into. Science studies the objective, what is given, that is describable in the third person. But it can't describe, it can't tap into the subjective.
- 4.57 The omniscient neuroscientist does not know what it is like to be me. The neuroscientist who has completed all neuroscience, who knows all facts that are to be known about every brain state in every human in history, cannot know what it's like to be you and cannot know what it is like to be me. Conscious states, that subjective perspective on the world, is private, it's privileged, and it's incommunicable.
- 4.58 Obviously, I can tell you how I'm feeling, or I can roughly try to describe the world from my point of view, and you will, to some extent, understand it, but you're never going to see it as you see it from my point of view, because you're not me. It's something that is

distinctive and subjective. And yet it is also, of course, tightly bound up with underlying brain states. We still accept that to be consciously aware, our brains need to be functioning, our bodies need to be functioning. So there is some kind of mysterious relationship between brain and mind, even if we accept that the two are distinct.

- 4.59 There have been lots of attempts to make sense of this. Some people say that being conscious is a little bit like computers with software, and the bodies that are conscious are like the hardware. There's a kind of software-hardware distinction. This is a distinction that became very common in the 1970s, particularly with the rapid advance of computational science. Big breakthrough in computers, of course, in the '70s, '80s, and '90s.
- 4.60 And so, the temptation was to say, "Consciousness, gosh, that's a difficult one. Mind, that's a difficult one. We can't really make sense of it philosophically, but we know that it must be something like a computer." Because at the time, it was the computer, and indeed, still today, it was the computer was at the very outermost limits of human creativity, of human genius, of human engineering. It must be that, the inference went, it must be that the mind is like software, and the brain is the hardware.
- 4.61 You see this quite a lot in the history of the mind-body problem, the history of the problem of consciousness. Technology comes to play an important part. I was reading a history of the mind-body problem a couple of years ago. At one point in the 19th century, in the chapters on the 19th century, the author pointed out that the explanations for how consciousness relates to the body were often framed in terms of the technology that underpinned the telegram.
- 4.62 In the late 19th century, imagine this, in the late 19th century, you go very quickly. A technology arrives, whereby you go from a situation where it takes you probably three to four weeks for a letter to get from London to Delhi, to five minutes. It's a long time, perhaps in our terms, but think of the way in what the world just shrinks almost overnight with the invention of the telegram.
- 4.63 You might see that's an even more intense technological revolution than the digital revolution and the invention of the internet. Instant global communication was still possible before the dawn of the internet. But just imagine going from that— you've literally just got to put a letter on a boat and wait for it three weeks to make its way to Delhi, to cables being laid underground and communicating in the space of minutes the same message.
- 4.64 That was such a big technological breakthrough that philosophers of mind said, consciousness mind must operate on something like the technology that we've discovered for the telegram. It's quite amusing to see how these various attempts are made over the years.
- 4.65 So how does this feed into a theistic argument or an argument for the existence of God? How does this work? Well, the basic puzzle is that you can't come up with a

naturalistic explanation of how it is non-naturalistic mental states harmonize so perfectly with naturalistic physical brain states. The two would seem to be qualitatively different, categorically different. And yet, there is this perfect harmony, it seems, between activity in the brain and thoughts, and imagination, conscious states.

- 4.66 So, how is it that these states are so perfectly paired? How is it that there could be psycho-physical laws, which can't be laws of nature, remember, because laws of nature only relate to nature or natural things, physical things? When we're talking about our conscious states, our mental states, we're talking about something that's not technically in nature, but it's somehow got a relationship with it. There's somehow traffic possible between the mental and the physical, between mind and brain. This is puzzling.
- 4.67 When we reason our way through an argument, these are not causal connections. We might say, "I drew the connection between X and Y," but it's not a causal connection. It's a rational inference. It's the mind that connects those things together. One common position here, advanced by the great American philosopher, Robert Adams, in a paper called *Flavors, Colors, and God*, and also in, I think, Chapter 13 of Richard Swinburne's *The Existence of God*, 1979, what Bob Adams and Richard Swinburne advance is an argument for the existence of God from consciousness.
- 4.68 The claim there is that, on theism, it's quite predictable that beings would emerge with non-physical mental states, conscious states, that were still tied to, anchored in, supported by brain states, where those two kinds of state were perfectly correlated. So that we have, although we are embodied beings, we're capable of consciously reflecting on the way the world is, constantly capable of understanding the world, having a conscious awareness of it, and for there to be underlying brain states that those conscious states are anchored in.
- 4.69 Here, again, we have the inadequacy of physical, merely physical processes, the merely scientific processes, trying to explain a relationship between physical states and non-physical states. That's not a limit on science, but it is to say that science couldn't ever possibly come up with some explanation of consciousness, because consciousness is not the thing that science could ever study.
- 4.70 Just as free will is something that science could never discover, because the claim is—about the people who believe in free will—the claim is that free will is something over and above the various chains of physical cause and effect. Similarly, with numbers, the claim that there are numbers, that numbers are real, again, is just the claim that the physical world is not the entire world, that the limits of the physical world are not the limits of the world. Again, with all these different features, we can start to say, on a theistic framework, it's much more plausible to see how these fit together than it is on a completely random naturalistic world.

- 4.71 And so, we come to the view with this fourth lecture that there are features of the world that are much more predictable, much more to be expected, on theism than on non-theism, or at least than on naturalism, the main rival to theism. You might call these the "M" words—metaphysics, morality, modality, mathematics, meaning, semantic content, information. All these "M" words are very, very difficult to fit in to a universe that is purely physical, purely scientific, purely naturalistic.
- 4.72 How do you fit morality into a purely naturalistic world? You can't, without it becoming something other than morality. How do you fit mathematics into the natural world in a way that is totally explained by the sciences? Well, you can't, because the sciences presuppose mathematics. How do you fit the mental into the physical world? Well, maybe it's anchored to the physical world in our brain states, but it's still something that's distinct. Naturalism, science itself, can't account for it, can't explain how it works.
- 4.73 Music—there's another M word. Aesthetic experience. One of Alvin Plantinga's arguments goes something like, "Premise: there is the music of Mozart. Conclusion: therefore God exists." He says at one point, "You either get that one or you don't." But it's true. There are overwhelming aesthetic experiences. May not be Mozart, it may be the Grand Canyon. This is a very, very common human experience of overwhelming beauty, for which there's no obvious evolutionary explanation.
- 4.74 There's no obvious evolutionary explanation for Mozart's Jupiter symphony, for example. It seems totally redundant from an evolutionary point of view, completely pointless, but also not accidental. How do we account for this? How do we account for beauty, for the overwhelming impact that beauty can have on us? Again, it seems like purely scientific ways of describing this, purely evolutionary ways of describing this, are always going to feel inadequate.
- 4.75 That it's right to think of extraordinary moments of aesthetic power of beauty, whether in music or in painting, the plastic arts or in architecture or whatever, as somehow disclosive of the divine, somehow signs or symbols or tokens of a more ultimate harmony and order underpinning the world, and that our intuitions for it and our responsiveness to that beauty in the world is a hallmark of being created and fitted towards being receptive to beauty and wonder.
- 4.76 So there we have it. There's a range of arguments you're unlikely to have heard before, which are animating and energizing contemporary philosophers of religion, as well as the various iterations of the old ontological, cosmological, and teleological arguments. And so as we draw this part of the lecture series to a conclusion, you can see that there's a stunning range of arguments, and I've only touched on a few. There are many, many, many more that we could have looked at.
- 4.77 Arguments that appeal to all sorts of different aspects of the world, all sorts of different aspects of human engagement with the world, and even arguments that don't engage with the world at all, in the case of the ontological arguments. Arguments that don't

require reliance on science or reliance on some contested account of human rationality or whatever it might be.

4.78 To go back to a point I think I made at the beginning of the previous lecture, these are not slam-dunk arguments, nor are they arguments that even might bring somebody to believe in the existence of God, of the kind that we typically understand when we're thinking of religious belief. But you might say that it makes it—these arguments make it very, very hard for atheists to dismiss religious commitment as something that is somehow irrational, childish, just for the playground. These are highly complex philosophical arguments.

4.79 Even if you come to the conclusion that none of them actually work, it's very hard to deny their sophistication, their rationality, the sheer weight, the sheer number of them, relative to arguments for other philosophical positions in the history of philosophy. If you like, it diffuses the standard pop-atheist attack line that religion is something for the benighted, for the foolish, for the stupid. No, not at all.

4.80 The rationality of religious commitment and arguments in the support of the existence of God, whether in the end you think they're successful or unsuccessful, what you can't say is that these are not deeply penetrating philosophical, cognitive exercises that require very sharp minds and that have occupied the sharpest minds for hundreds and hundreds of years, and there's not been any obvious resolution either way. That's a useful thing to bear in mind.

4.81 You might say that, in the end, the philosophical arguments for or against the existence of God are not really at the heart of what it is to be a religious person. They're not, as it were—it's not the great cathedral of faith and of religious belief. But you might say that these arguments are like flying buttresses. They structure and give shape to religious belief and faith. Religious belief and faith could probably survive pretty well without them, but they are there. They are complementary, that reason is complementary to faith, not in opposition to it. Thank you for listening.

Lecture 5: The Problem of Evil

At a glance — The problem of evil as the central challenge to belief in God.

- 5.1 Welcome to lecture five in Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. In the last two lectures, we looked at arguments for the existence of God, how we might support, provide some scaffolding to the rationality of religious commitment. In this lecture and the next one, I want to move from thinking about natural theology to thinking about normative or moral theology, the moral world, the moral universe.
- 5.2 There's something more to the universe than just the physical universe. There is a moral universe. That might seem controversial these days, but within the ancient world and in the medieval period, and even right deep up into the Enlightenment, it was, broadly speaking, taken for granted that the good and the right and evil and wrong were as real as rocks and trees. Indeed, more real in some ways. There are no rocks and trees in the next life, but there's good and evil in the next life. That persists.
- 5.3 And so what we're going to do in this session, in this lecture and the next lecture, is to explore the moral universe of religion. We'll be looking not just at the Abrahamic traditions, but also we'll be glancing across at Eastern traditions, Indian traditions, Buddhist traditions, Vedantic traditions, just because contrast is the mother of clarity. Often we'll see that, although there are some very important contrasts, there are also similarities.
- 5.4 One of the interesting things about our moral impulses or being confronted with evil is that one has to make sense of it. One has to make sense of the impulse to do good or the horror of terrible evil, whether one is religious or not. The world doesn't become less evil because you abandon religion. It's still there. You can still—maybe you can try to explain it away, as I think you would have to do, if you are a naturalistic philosopher for whom there just are no moral truths. There are scientific truths.
- 5.5 And although we may feel and respond to particular situations in the world in certain ways, we can't really say that evil or good or right or wrong is some feature of reality. It's just how we respond to reality. It's all in the end to be explained in terms of our physiology, perhaps, or our brains. And that, for many, will not be a very satisfying response or answer to the sense, the immensity of evil as we witness it in the world, or indeed, the extraordinary transcendent power of holiness, of saintly behavior, of supererogatory conduct.
- 5.6 That is to say, conduct that goes way beyond what is expected of somebody in terms of a framework of obligations that we share. We'll be covering in this next session the question of suffering, question of evil, how we make sense of wrong, and those dark features of human experience. In the next lecture, we'll be turning to think about the relationship between God and the moral universe. Slightly different from the way we think about God, the relationship between God and the physical universe.

- 5.7** Let's begin with the problem of evil. There's a classical version of the problem of evil, but there are many different problems of evil. Evil is a problem in all sorts of different ways, often because it's not easy to explain. I'd say, actually, in some ways, it's easier for religious people to explain evil. There's a less complicated account of what evil is within religious traditions than there is with much more reductive atheistic accounts that effectively are not trying to explain evil, but rather to explain it away.
- 5.8** So, to kick off with, what are we talking about when we're talking about evil? Well, the distinction I want you to have clear in your mind is the distinction, on the one hand, between what we call axiology. And axiology is really that study of the nature of value, the nature of goodness, and the nature of evil, as it were, exists in the world, or may not exist in the world, but it's about the content of those things, of value, of goodness and evil.
- 5.9** That is distinct from deontology, D-E-O-N-T-O-L-O-G-Y, deontology, from "deon" in Greek meaning obligation or necessity or to need, to be necessary. This relates more to questions of obligation, of right and wrong, right and wrong. There's a difference between goodness and rightness, right obligation. There's a difference between evil and wrong. Evil and goodness are terms we use in relation to value and disvalue, the nature of things, you might say. Right and wrong are words that we use to describe our conduct, obligations, behavior. It's a subtle distinction, but it's an important distinction to draw.
- 5.10** Now, you would hope that your theory of value connects to your theory of right and wrong. There are some philosophers who don't manage to fit those together at all, but they are distinct. What are we talking about when we're talking about evil? Well, there are different types of evil. There's, most obviously, moral evil, human wrongdoing, shall we say, murder, cruelty, injustice.
- 5.11** But there's also a way of thinking about natural evil. This is a slightly more complicated idea, natural evil. Was the Boxing Day tsunami in 2004 an evil? Well, maybe. A lot of assumptions hovering around there. Of course, it was bad. Of course, it led to the loss of, what was it? Over, I think, 100,000 lives lost, possibly even more than that in the space of a few hours. It was obviously a catastrophe, a terrible tragedy. Lives cut short and so on and so forth.
- 5.12** We could probably just about get away with calling it evil. That is to say, something that is terrible. But even there, we're beginning to think, well, if there's evil there, there must be some sense of agency. There must be something driving it that we can somehow—some agency whose fault it was to have brought this about. We'll come on to how one might think about that later on. So natural disasters, maybe disease, cancers, death, animal suffering.
- 5.13** Third and final category of evil is what you might call metaphysical evil. This is more this idea of evil as an imperfection or perhaps as finitude, limitation, deficit, some kind of

lack. We might be able to say that that's true of human beings. In some ways, it's a way to understand, say, the Christian doctrine of original sin, particularly common in the Latin Western Christian tradition. The idea here is: to have original sin is to be less than fully human, less than the complete picture of humanity that God intended us to be, to have a sort of metaphysical deficit.

- 5.14** Now, there are various theories as to how we understand what evil is. Augustine, Saint Augustine, 354 to 430 AD, develops a famous theory of evil as the absence of good. This is the so-called "privatio boni" tradition. In *privatio boni* in Latin, the privation of good, the absence of good—a bit like cancer is ontological wasting disease, evil is a kind of ontological wasting disease. Here the thought is—Augustine is constrained by his theological commitments.
- 5.15** Augustine believes in a supremely good, morally benevolent, and all-loving God and creator who creates all of reality distinct from himself out of nothing and brings it into being and sustains it in being. The problem there is how you fit evil into that framework. If God is the source of everything distinct from himself, and he's morally perfect and maximally excellent and so on and so forth, where does evil come from? How do you fit it in?
- 5.16** So Augustine is compelled towards this theory that evil is not some kind of positive force that God introduces into the world. It's more that evil is an absence; it's a gap in creation. And gaps can be evil. Gaps can be damaging. What is it that sinks the Titanic? Is it an iceberg or the absence of steel in the hull? You might say it's the absence of steel in the hull. It's the hole. It's the privation of steel in the hull that brings the Titanic down.
- 5.17** The hole in my sock irritates me. Is it nothingness irritating me? Well, sort of. It's the absence of cloth in the sock that is annoying me, that is irritating. That's roughly the way to think about this very classic way of conceiving of evil, because it's difficult for the Abrahamic monotheists to squeeze evil into a world that is completely superintended and controlled and dominated by an all-loving, maximally morally excellent being. Others would say, no, evil is a positive force. It's a reality. It's a substance that maybe human beings, by abusing their freedom, can bring into the world, and so on and so forth.
- 5.18** So what are the different ways of thinking about this issue? The problem of evil, we've already touched on one problem that theists have, or monotheists have—namely, how do you make sense, how do you fit evil into a world, into a creationist framework that is sustained by a morally perfect being? But the more classic version, the version of the problem of evil that most people will be familiar with, of course, arises in relation to what you might call an inconsistent triad—three truths that the theist seems to be committed to, that seem to be an inconsistent triad, seem to be a triad of truths and commitments that simply do not fit together.

- 5.19** Number one, the commitment is, first commitment: God is omnipotent, God is all-powerful. We saw reasons for that when we were looking at Anselm's perfect being theology, that a maximally perfect being, a maximally excellent being, a maximally great being in all possible worlds, is going to be all-powerful. There's not going to be anything that he can't do, except for the logically or mathematically impossible.
- 5.20** Commitment two of the triad: God is omnibenevolent. God is all-loving. God wills the good of all His creatures. In the classical definition of love, to love is to will the good of the other. The third commitment is evil exists. Evil exists in the world. There is innocent suffering or inexplicable suffering. Why is this inconsistent? Well, an omnipotent being, the objection goes, could eliminate evil, and an omnibenevolent being would eliminate evil. And yet, there is evil in the world. How can this triad be reconciled? Is it not an inconsistent set of commitments? Don't you have to drop one of them, at least one of them?
- 5.21** The objection, the problem of evil distilled to its basic elements is that these three commitments cannot all be true, cannot simultaneously be true. And so the conclusion is, given evil, given the one thing, the one commitment that we do not doubt, but is the hardest to doubt in that triad, there cannot be a being who is both omnipotent and omnibenevolent. There cannot be a being who is both all-powerful and all-loving.
- 5.22** So what response might the theist offer here? Well, the first one is to say, "OK, fine. We'll give up on God's omnipotence. He's not as powerful as we thought." That's a view that Alfred North Whitehead and the so-called process theologians, mainly American theologians, have made in the 20th century. We say that God is more powerful than we are, but he's not maximally powerful. There are certain things he can't change.
- 5.23** There might be some who would give up on the all-loving bit. There's the so-called evil demon hypothesis that some thinkers have developed, to say, well, "He is all-powerful, but he enjoys the suffering." That's so far away from anything recognizable within the Abrahamic monotheistic traditions that it's really a nonstarter.
- 5.24** A more sophisticated response is the one that was developed in the early 1970s by a number of philosophers of religion. Here the thought was that it could be the case that not even an all-powerful God could create a world in which His creatures were free to choose between good and evil, and He determined them always to choose good and never evil. There might be some possible world where that's the case.
- 5.25** And in fact, it doesn't seem an unrealistic possible world. It can't be that you have a human agent, a creature, who is both free to choose between good and evil and determined to choose good. That does seem to be a deep contradiction. God, not even an omnipotent being, could determine a free agent, because if he was determining the free agent, the agent wouldn't be free. And if the agent were free, he wouldn't be determined.

- 5.26 And so, if God puts a premium, a high price, on the importance of creaturely freedom, and you could imagine a possible world in which a God, an all-loving, maximally excellent God, is prepared to take the risks, is prepared to face the trade-offs, the costs, for the sake of freedom, for the sake of creaturely freedom, of that freedom being abused and being deployed towards evil. Now, we don't even need to accept that this is the correct analysis. We just need to accept that it's possible. It's possibly true that that's a situation. It's possibly true that there is a world—that this world is a world in which not even an omnipotent being could compel or coerce agents, creatures, in a way that still preserve their freedom.
- 5.27 And so, here we've got a way of showing that it's not really what we call a theodicy, that is to say, justifying why God permits evil in the world, but it is what you might call a defense to atheistic attacks on the logical inconsistency of being committed to God's omnipotence, God's omnibenevolence, his all-lovingness, and there being evil in the world.
- 5.28 It's possible that an omnipotent being, who is also all-loving, is going to, in His love, bring creatures into the world who are free, who would need to be free to enter into some kind of personal relationship with Him, which is common commitment in all three Abrahamic traditions, and to therefore surrender the power to coerce creatures to choose particular things, particular causes. And what that means is that even an omnipotent being is going to have to take the risk of creaturely freedom being abused, of creaturely freedom being exercised in a way that brings evil into the world.
- 5.29 In the 1970s, most philosophers accepted that that response to what's called the logical problem of evil was compelling. And broadly speaking, even the most hard-boiled atheistic philosophers said, "Yes, it's clearly true that there's no logical contradiction between God's omnipotence, God's omnibenevolence, and there being evil in the world that is equivalent to being committed to the trilaterality of triangles and the rectilinearity of triangles." That really would be just a logical impossibility, to be committed to the view that triangles are three-sided and four-sided. That's what the logical problem says, that this triad is the equivalent to believing in square triangles.
- 5.30 What this response shows is that, no, we could actually imagine a world in which a God, even though He's omnipotent and even though He's all-loving, has to limit himself, has to take the risk that evil will be introduced into the world, because He wants to confer freedom, the freedom to choose between good and evil, upon His creatures.
- 5.31 You could imagine, it's perfectly possible that such a being would prize the goodness and the moral formation, the moral education that bestowing that kind of freedom makes possible, even though there is a terrible risk and cost that has to come with it, namely that that freedom is abused and brings evil into the world.
- 5.32 So, the atheists regrouped and redesigned, came up with a new problem of evil. They accepted the logical problem of evil had collapsed, so they came back with something

called the evidential problem of evil. What is that, you might ask? Well, here the thought is, the claim is that there might be no logical incompatibility in that triad, but there's still the overwhelming weight of evidence of gratuitous evil. There's just too much evil.

- 5.33** Yes, perhaps God would permit certain evils in order to, as it were, permit the higher good of exercising freedom for the good and exercising freedom to enter into relationship with God. But there's still just, there's far, far too much evil for that to be a plausible scenario. There are gratuitous evils. There are evils in the world that seem to have no explanation, no justification at all, that don't serve any greater good.
- 5.34** And if God exists, there wouldn't be such gratuitous evils—the claim continued—and therefore God does not exist. So, here the idea is that the evidence of evil, the amount of evil, the intensity of evil, the duration of evil, is such that it makes not—it doesn't make theism impossible. It's not like it makes belief in theism, belief in square triangles, but it makes theism improbable. The weight of evil, the evidence of, the weight and intensity and duration of evil just makes it unlikely that theism is true, and more likely that we live in a world that has no divine oversight whatsoever.
- 5.35** What responses have been given to this re-crafting of the problem of evil by theists? Well, the most common response has been a position that's called, slightly confusingly, skeptical theism, skeptical theism. It's confusing. It's not a great label, but this is what happens in philosophy. Labels grow up and get attached to things.
- 5.36** But it's not that the theists—it doesn't describe a skeptical kind of theism, but the skepticism goes to the reasons—skepticism that we human beings might know what reasons God has for permitting certain evils in the world, even for permitting the duration and extent and spread and gratuity of the evils that we think we see in the world. That is to say, when the atheist says, "There's too much evil in the world, it's too intense, it's too long, it's too appalling." The response is: Who are you to decide? Who are you to form a judgment, as to the intensity and duration of evil? How do you know it's gratuitous?
- 5.37** Because to know that an evil is, or the extent of evil, is gratuitous, is to assume a kind of godlike perspective on the entirety of reality and how all the vast complexities of goods and evils fit together, and greater goods that flow from intense evils might emerge. We just can't know what reasons God might have that would justify him to permit certain evils in the world, to permit evils even that might seem to us to be gratuitous, that might seem to us to be too intense and too horrific and too enduring.
- 5.38** But that is to take up, as it were, a kind of godlike perspective that is simply not permitted to us in our finitude and our fragility and indeed our fallibility, our moral fallibility. It is possible indeed, maybe it's likely, that there are goods that lie way, way beyond our comprehension, for all we know. It's true, too, that we do regularly witness

extraordinary goods emerging from terrible evil. We see this every week. It's a difficult thing to grapple with, particularly when one is touched by them and affected by them.

- 5.39 But if one steps back, one can see, in the larger calculus of the push and pull between good and evil within the moral universe, one can at least see that it's possible that there are justifying goods that flow from horrendous evils. And so, here we come to the view, we might think to ourselves, "What reasons might we have for thinking that, for all we know, God knows what he's doing in permitting certain horrendous evils?"
- 5.40 I think probably my view is that if this was the only argument in town, when it comes to the existence of God, or the existence of a God who is all-powerful and all-loving and who's got all the omnis, I suspect it would be a fine balance. I think probably, in fact, the atheist side might have an edge. But of course, it's not the only game in town. What one has to do when one's thinking about a philosophical problem, like the existence of God, is to weigh up all of the different arguments for and against the proposition, and then to form a view in the round.
- 5.41 And some of the reasons we have for thinking that God might have reasons that justify him in permitting there to be certain evils in the world are all the other reasons that we have, we can draw on, for thinking that God exists, that a God of that kind exists. And so we can go back to our previous two lectures and say that all of the different arguments have to be in the stadium at the same time. We have to take them all in the round.
- 5.42 In the previous two lectures, we saw that there is a whole range of arguments that would be in favor of the theistic position. We looked at, I think, probably at least a dozen, and we could have looked at a dozen more. We looked at three or four variations of three of them. Now we've got this evidential problem of evil, as it were, coming up against it. And so the task is: How do we weigh up the costs and benefits here? Where do we come down? What are the trade-offs?
- 5.43 But too often, I think, in a lot of these philosophy of religion debates, problem of evil is stressed above all the others, and all the different arguments for and against are not taken in the round. So one answer to the problem of evil as an argument against there being a God, or at least against theism being true, is to say, well, there's a whole range of other reasons, good reasons, for thinking that theism is true.
- 5.44 That doesn't mean that that defeats the problem of evil, but it does mean that it certainly mitigates it and may, in the end, supersede the critical power that the evidential problem of evil presents to theism. There's another angle, too, that should be introduced, and that is the atheistic problem of evil—I've touched on this earlier in the lecture. There are different ways of framing this problem. But the basic challenge is, if there is no God, on the atheistic assumption, how can atheism or humanism make sense of evil and suffering? How do we make sense of it?

- 5.45 First of all, we might say there's the atheistic problem of evil from the problem of moral objectivity, the claim that there is a moral universe out there. We can't declare something to be evil and also say that there's no moral universe. To say that something is evil is to say that there is good and evil in the world, that it's not just something we come up with, it's not something we invent, that it's there, we recognize it.
- 5.46 Then the question for the atheist is: Well, what is it? What is this evil that you speak of? What is this ultimate benchmark? It's not a scientific one. Science doesn't care about good and evil. Nature just is. We talk about the law of the jungle. That is to say, we talk about the world of nature, "red in tooth and claw," as Tennyson puts it. There is no moral rhyme or reason to nature. So it's got to be something else. It's got to be something that transcends nature. But if it's not God, then what is it? What are the objective benchmarks for what counts as evil and good?
- 5.47 To condemn the Holocaust becomes a matter of personal taste, perhaps, or what one particular society or how one particular civilization thinks what they might think is evil. It's just a question of preference, not objective wrongdoing. On a purely evolutionary analysis, there's nothing wrong with genocide. Moral intuitions are just survival mechanisms. They're neither good nor bad. They just are what they are. They're morally inert. They're not tracking moral truths. They're just conferring survival, survival value. That's the atheistic challenge, the atheistic problem, when it comes to evil.
- 5.48 There's another version of the objection—that's the problem of, for the atheism, of the problem of ultimate meaning, problem of ultimate meaning. In an atheistic universe, suffering and evil is ultimately meaningless. There is no meaning to it. There's no redemptive value of any sort. It is what it is.
- 5.49 Nor is there any final justice, nor is there any hope that those who've been wronged or those who'd be close to the victims of some terrible crime, they can't hope for any final restoration or any final justice or judgment, as is the case in most religious traditions, at least in most of the dominant, the classical Western ethical monotheistic traditions.
- 5.50 Here we have the existentialists, the French existentialists, particularly Jean-Paul Sartre, Albert Camus, who insist that life is absurd. There is no meaning to it. It's purely nonsensical. There are no attachments. There's no human good. Albert Camus opens his novel, *The Stranger*, *L'Étranger*, with a famous line, "Maman est décédée hier, ou peut-être—aujourd'hui, Maman est décédée, ou peut-être c'était hier, je ne me rappelle plus. Maman est décédée."
- 5.51 "Mom died yesterday, or maybe it was the day before. I can't remember. Mother's dead," said the telegram. The point of the chilling opening of that novel is that the antihero, the existentialist antihero, doesn't believe in anything, inhabits a completely empty moral universe, where nothing matters. There's no ultimate meaning, there's no final judgment, and even the most basic and vital bond that any human being can have

with another, namely the bond between mother and child, is a matter of indifference to him.

- 5.52** In such a world, it's very hard to even think of evil as a problem. Evil as a problem is something that only theists need to worry about, and yet, it's still a problem. It's still a problem that cuts against our deepest impulses, even to Meursault, Camus' antihero, who has repudiated religion and God as bourgeois virtues and values. It's difficult to know how, in purely secular terms, humanists can, as it were, resist this or make sense of evil. There's no ultimate justice, as I said. There's very little understanding of what cosmic significance might be, ultimate meaning might be.
- 5.53** Then there's the problem of moral psychology for atheists confronted with evil. Why care about the suffering of others, ultimately, if others are simply caught up in an evolutionary race for survival? It makes very little sense. How, ultimately, can a secular worldview sustain compassion amidst, in a world of, basically, of cosmic indifference? So what I'm trying to suggest here is not that this is some answer for theists to the challenges issued by atheists when it comes to setting out the problem of evil, but it is to say that there is no cost-free position here.
- 5.54** The atheist can't just let himself off the hook. There's still this deeply troubling set of questions that need to be answered. The atheist is not just, through being an atheist, somehow free from all the moral impulses and all the attunement to value and all the horror towards evil that characterizes all human beings. People can try to live like nihilists. People can try to live as if there is no moral universe. It's very, very difficult to do.
- 5.55** The people who do succeed in doing it, we diagnose as effectively pathological, as in fact somehow not morally culpable, criminally insane, as the phrase goes. I'm not saying that evil and the problem of evil is somehow a greater problem for atheism than it is for theism, but it is a problem, and it requires a richer account than the philosophical resources that many atheists have to make sense of, particularly those who rely on purely scientific or purely naturalistic accounts of what reality is.
- 5.56** Now, it's worth glancing towards how other traditions think about evil as a problem. In the Eastern traditions, and particularly in Hindu Vedantic traditions, there is—evil is an issue that occupies them a great deal, occupies thinkers a great deal. Within Hinduism, there's the doctrine of karma, of course, and the idea here is that there is suffering, but the suffering, though it might seem pointless in this life, it might seem as if there's no rhyme or reason, is in fact the result of past moral choices.
- 5.57** Now, that might seem itself evil and unfair, but you can see there, there is that very human longing and desire to try to make sense of why suffering that seems to be innocent is in fact not innocent because, in a previous life, poor moral decisions were made, and there's some kind of atonement or a need to compensate.

- 5.58** Now, there are all kinds of problems with this view. The biggest one, I think, is this question of making sense of there being a continuity of the agent in a previous life responsible for wrongdoing, where the responsibility persists and is atoned for by the same agent in the next biological existence. It's very hard to see. I can't think what it would be like to think that I am living out the life and the consequences of me, even though the me in a previous life was a completely different person.
- 5.59** I can't make sense of the idea that I'm somehow the same, that there's some moral continuity between me and somebody from a completely distinct existence. Very hard to see how responsibility can persist. It's hard to think actually how responsibility can persist even from a father to a son, or down the generations. Of course, there are big debates at the moment about reparations and historic injustices, and can the descendants of perpetrators atone for crimes of their ancestors towards the descendants of victims of those crimes, stretching back 200 years?
- 5.60** Intuitively, it's very difficult to make sense of how that moral economy is supposed to be understood. It's very, very difficult indeed. Not to mention all the problems to do with calculating loss and the quantum of reparations and so on. There's a challenge there, I think, for the doctrine of karma. But you can understand how it arises. It's an attempt to, as it were, invest meaning in seemingly innocent suffering.
- 5.61** It's trying to say that actually what it's challenging is, it's not saying it's not suffering, it's saying that it might not be innocent. There may be some moral rhyme and reason here that we can read in. It's an attempt to see the doctrine of karma as an attempt to create a sense of cosmic justice across multiple lifetimes.
- 5.62** There's also, in Advaita Vedanta, that is to say, the form of philosophy developed by Shankara, a philosophy of non-dualism, where there's a undifferentiated reality that is entirely one—there, suffering is understood, and this is a common position in Buddhism, too, suffering and evil are to be understood as somehow illusory and not real. This is a very, very, very common way of thinking about evil in the Eastern traditions. The only thing that is real is Brahman. And suffering, though it seems very real, is in fact part of the world of *māyā*, or part of the world of illusion.
- 5.63** Really, the central task of many of the Indian religious systems is to achieve moksha, or salvation or liberation from this illusion that is suffering. That's a central religious quest. And so, here, what we've got is an attempt to not so much explain evil away. Of course, within the Indian traditions, you don't have the same problem in being committed to a being that is claimed to be all-powerful and all-loving. That is to say, a being that not only could get rid of suffering and limit it, but would get rid of suffering and limit it.
- 5.64** But there's still, within the Indian traditions, the recognition that suffering is bad. Suffering needs to be understood properly. It's not something you can simply ignore, but it is something that one should train oneself to transcend and to recognize as being illusory, as not being part of ultimate reality.

- 5.65** In the Abrahamic traditions, in Judaism, Christianity, and Islam, but particularly in Christianity, that is a completely incomprehensible way of thinking about suffering. Suffering is held to be right at the core of the ultimate reality of the world, the ultimate reality of God's creative framework, obviously through the crucifixion and through the willing embrace of suffering by the second person of the Trinity—Jesus of Nazareth.
- 5.66** And so suffering could not be more different from the Eastern traditions. It's the opposite of illusory. It's really almost the most real thing. It is the crucial defining moment of redemption. You might say that redemption within the Christian world is something that is absolutely central. It's that which is the mechanism of liberation and the mechanism of redemption. Whereas in Indian traditions, suffering, it's actually recognizing the illusoriness of suffering that is the moment of salvation and liberation—very, very different way of thinking about things.
- 5.67** Finally, within Buddhism, we have, central to the four noble truths, dukkha, suffering in Buddhism. It's, for the Buddhists, a universal characteristic of human existence. It's diagnosed as arising from craving or a yearning, a kind of unhealthy attachment to what we think of as reality, but is in fact not reality, is not ultimate reality. The way to free oneself from that suffering is to eliminate the craving, eliminate the sense of detachment.
- 5.68** It's a philosophy of withdrawal and of quietism, of withdrawal from the world, of withdrawal from too much engagement with reality. And by following the eightfold path, the so-called eightfold path that, within Buddhism, that is the means to bring suffering to an end or recognize that suffering is simply a symptom that can be cured by eliminating craving and attachment.
- 5.69** So this gives you a sense of how, despite the variety of different approaches to evil across different religious traditions, it's absolutely central to all of them. Evil presents different kinds of problems, but every religion, every great religious tradition, takes suffering and evil very, very seriously, and has all sorts of strategies and mechanisms for understanding it and living with it, navigating it.
- 5.70** The only one, I would say, the only tradition that doesn't have a fully worked-out way of making sense of evil and, as it were, investing it with reality, recognizing its reality—nor indeed any means of really coping with it or dealing with it or trying to liberate oneself from it, making sense of it—is the atheistic traditions or the naturalistic traditions, the self-consciously secular approaches.
- 5.71** There, evil is really just, it's either ignored, it's pushed to one side, it's treated as—there's a kind of meaninglessness there. There's nothing to be understood, there's nothing to be explained, there's nothing you can do about it. There's no ultimate sense to be made of it. There's no final judgment where perpetrators of evil are brought to account, victims of evil to a state of health and innocence.

- 5.72** And so, the problem of evil—there is no problem of evil; there are problems of evil. Each tradition has to navigate, has to engage with reality of evil, even where the reality of evil is denied, as we see it is denied within the Hindu and Buddhist traditions, at least as being ultimate, as being something that's more than within the veil of māyā.
- 5.73** And so we can see, drawing to a close, that this is the shadow side of human experience, the dark side of human experience, that religion has always—most religions, most of the great religions, have always been able to confront, make sense of, not ignore, not brush under the carpet, but to confront, and to indeed even sometimes make central to the understanding of ultimate meaning and ultimate purpose.
- 5.74** In the next lecture, we're going to move into happier valleys, and we're going to be moving away from evil, and we're going to be thinking more about good. We're going to be thinking more about beauty. We're going to be thinking more about the states of grace, and what is it to think of God as the source of goodness, and what is it to think about how our lives can be shaped for the good, and how our obligations, what obligations, arise to do good, and how we can make sense of those within a religious framework.
- 5.75** And what implications that has for how, what kind of God we understand religious people to be worshiping, if it is indeed God from whom moral obligations arise, and if it is indeed from God that all things that have value, all things that have goodness, all things that participate in goodness, somehow derive that goodness or participate in that goodness through being somehow related to God. Thank you for listening.

Lecture 6: God and Goodness

At a glance — God and goodness — the relationship between the divine and morality.

- 6.1 Welcome to lecture six in Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. We're going to be looking in this lecture at God and morality, the relationship between God and the good. How do they connect together? Many secular philosophers insist that we don't need God to be good. We don't need God to have grounds for goodness.
- 6.2 There are all sorts of reasons why we want to add an O to God, because we can all sign up to the idea that goodness is good, is conducive to social flourishing. But if we take the O out and we just have God, that's much more contentious, and it's going to lead to strife in the public square. There are all these interesting downstream political and social questions that come out of this lecture, but we're going to go right down deep into the philosophical foundations of this relationship between God and the good.
- 6.3 I mentioned in an earlier lecture that extraordinary period, the Axial Age, between roughly 800 BC and roughly 300 BC, where you have this dawning awareness in very disparate parts of the world, the civilized world at the time, an awareness of universal moral structure to the world.
- 6.4 We see it particularly in Chinese thought, in Confucianism and Daoism. We find it in the emerging Indian philosophical traditions of Vedanta, particularly in the the Bhagavad Gita, which is one of the most sacred and important texts within the Indian tradition. It's a sort of extract from the Mahabharata, this enormous long epic. Even in Homer, even in the Iliad and the Odyssey, you start to see this dawning realization or dawning awareness, of this world of justice. You see it in Book 18 of the Iliad and on this extraordinary scene with Achilles' shield, depicting a city at peace and a city at war.
- 6.5 And of course, in the 5th century, you have the emergence of the pre-Socratics, and in particular, Socrates himself, who, though he never wrote anything, inspired Plato, his great student, who in turn inspired Aristotle. And all of these thinkers and others are starting to think hard about what is it, where does the good lie? Where is it anchored? Is it real?
- 6.6 Probably the most famous dialogue of Plato's to address these questions is called the Euthyphro, the Euthyphro dialogue. This is a classic textbook dialogue from Plato to understand these questions. Plato—just a quick note on him to remind you, because, of course, you will all have listened to my lectures on Plato for Peterson Academy— Plato writes around about 35 dialogues, and it's always difficult to pin him down because he never really says anything himself.
- 6.7 The character of Plato never appears in any of the dialogues saying anything at all. He does appear in two of the dialogues. He notes that he's present in the third person. But everything else, all of the dialogues, as it were, are imagined, or I think probably partly

also reconstructed from actual historical conversations between Socrates and this shifting cast of Socrates' victims.

- 6.8** One of the early dialogues is called the Euthyphro. Normally, Plato's dialogues are named after the main interlocutor in the dialogue. And so this young man, Euthyphro, is on his way to court and he's going to sue his father. He gets in conversation with Socrates on the way to the courtroom, and this fascinating conversation begins. It's a very short dialogue, and it's what's called an aporetic dialogue, so it ends in failure. There's no actual resolution.
- 6.9** What it does is, it forces us to think that our assumptions about the relationship between, in this case, holiness or goodness and the divine are a lot more complicated than certainly this young man thinks. The central question that they end up turning around again and again and again is the nature of holiness. What is holiness? For our purposes, we can think of holiness as goodness, as the ultimate good.
- 6.10** Socrates keeps pressing Euthyphro, says, "What is holiness exactly?" Euthyphro says, "Well, it's whatever the gods think that is holy. It's what the gods recognize as holy. That's what holiness is." Socrates then develops this line of conversational attack. He says, "Well, but isn't it the case that if the gods simply determine what holiness is, it's arbitrary?" If you look in the poems of, you look in the Iliad and the Odyssey, gods are constantly commanding things or doing things that we wouldn't typically think of as being holy.
- 6.11** So which way around is it? Is holiness holiness because the gods recognize or insist that it's holiness? Or is holiness holiness because the gods recognize that holiness is holiness? And poor Euthyphro gets very, very confused through all of this, through this conversation, and it doesn't really end with any kind of resolution. But what it's done subsequently is set up this puzzle. How do we understand goodness and morality?
- 6.12** Is morality morality because God says that it is? In which case, we have the specter of arbitrariness, God just dictating whatever is good. Then there are worries there about God maybe commanding abhorrent things, that we are then required to think of as good. Or is it the case that God recognizes what's good, independently of him? He recognizes some standard that even he himself must, as it were, measure up to.
- 6.13** Now, the problem with that horn of the dilemma is that God seems to be less than God. Remember that emphasis, relentless emphasis, on God as being a perfect being, morally perfect being. So how could it be that some standard independent of God, is, as it were, constraining God or telling God how to behave, what morality is?
- 6.14** So on the first horn of the dilemma, you've got the arbitrariness worry, God just stipulating what's good. And on the other, you have a subordination worry, God, as it were, having to accept some standard independent of himself, and presumably superior, at least in moral terms, to himself, which brings all sorts of complications and

headaches in its wake, at least when we start to think about God in the context of the monotheistic tradition.

- 6.15** It's not, by the way, much of a problem for Plato, who's not got this idea, but it's clear that what Plato is doing in this dialogue is suggesting that the old way of doing things, appealing to Zeus or to Hera or to any of the gods in the polytheistic canon, is going to lead to arbitrariness. These are not reliable sources of moral knowledge, the Homeric gods, the Olympian gods.
- 6.16** It looks as if what he's pressing towards is something like an understanding of goodness and holiness as independent and existing objectively up in Plato's heaven, an argument he develops a lot more in the Republic. But for monotheists, you've got this headache, the arbitrariness worry that God is just stipulating what's right and wrong. Secondly, on the other hand, the worry that God is somehow subordinated to some higher standard.
- 6.17** And so, this has been a standard question. It's opened up—you can think of this dilemma as opening up two streams in the great tradition of reflection about God and morality. On the one hand, where God is stipulating what's right and wrong, you have this idea that the primary source of morality comes from God's commands, God's injunctions, God's recommendations, God's will. That is what you might call the voluntarist tradition, from the Latin word "voluntas", meaning will. It stresses God's will, God's commands.
- 6.18** Then on the other hand, this idea that, no, maybe just morality and goodness exists woven into the fabric of the natural world, woven into the fabric of reality. God, as it were, recognizes that and attunes creation to it. He's not issuing commands. It's that we can explore nature, we can understand nature through our own nature, through the nature that has been endowed, that we've been endowed with by God, and we've got the capacities, as it were, without having to consult His commands. We've got the capacities and the instincts and intuitions to behave in a moral way, in a way that conforms to the good.
- 6.19** That's the tradition. On the one hand, divine command theory, you might say, DCT, and on the other, natural law, natural law, the great tradition of natural law. And so, before we leave it, it's worth saying: To what extent is this a dilemma? To what extent is the so-called, the dilemma that comes from the Euthyphro dialogue a real problem for monotheists?
- 6.20** There've been a lot of responses to it, and I think, in the end, the best way for a theist to respond to the worries about some sort of contradiction between, or rather, this unacceptable dilemma between arbitrariness and subordination, is to say that it's not that goodness is somehow independent of God. It's more that God's commands—nor is it the case that God's commands are completely arbitrary. The idea is that God's commands flow from His nature. His nature just is goodness; it is the source of goodness.

- 6.21** Just as it's impossible for God to make it the case that $2 + 2 = 5$, because that would be inconsistent with His rational nature, so too it's impossible for God to issue abhorrent evil commands because that would be inconsistent with His nature, which is goodness. God and goodness are identified, are seen as a single source, in the way that the sun and light are seen as, are identical, as it were, or the same thing.
- 6.22** This is a response that's been developed by various American philosophers of religion, in particular, Philip Quinn and Robert Adams. The idea is that we can handle the problem of moral arbitrariness, because those commands are grounded in the nature of God and God's maximally loving and benevolent posture and attitude towards creation. And so, if we take this a little bit further, we can understand that what we have here is a tradition in which the good is transcendent.
- 6.23** God is goodness. That is to say, morality is not something that is constructed. It's not something that is confected. It's not something that is determined by any particular society or any particular parliament or any particular set of laws. It provides us with a way of thinking about the moral universe as being real, something that we discover, not something that we invent or something that we construct.
- 6.24** Now, you might say, "Why does one need God to do that?" There are plenty of secular theories that say that there are other ways of grounding morality that have got nothing to do with God. In fact, you can look at Plato and say, if you look at the Republic—we've talked in previous lectures about the allegory of the cave—when the prisoner who escapes, emerges, blinking into the sunlight outside the cave, what he's apprehending is the good, which, for Plato, the goodness is even beyond being, he says at one point.
- 6.25** But it's not God. It's this reality that is impersonal that exists in this sort of Platonic heaven. You might say that one could be a Platonist and an agnostic and an atheist. You could still believe in goodness as transcendent and as objective, but you don't need to sign up to all of the complicated religious stuff. How might a theist respond to that? Well, it's true that Platonism does give you very, very solid objective grounds for morality and for the moral universe.
- 6.26** The trouble is that this idea of goodness as wholly impersonal, as this metaphysical cloud floating in Plato's heaven, is, in terms of explanatory power, not as helpful as the theistic framework. Whatever else goodness and value and sources of obligation might be, we would want it somehow to be connected to personhood, to agency, to intention, to will. But Plato's forms don't have any of those. Plato's forms just float there, as I said, like a metaphysical cloud. They don't feel anything, they don't know anything, they don't intend anything, they don't will anything.
- 6.27** Whereas on the theistic picture, you have got, as it were, the claim that the source of goodness is also personal in some way. Clearly not a person in the way that we are, but certainly a source of agency, of will, of decision, of desire, of feeling, of love. We can

get our heads around what it might be for such a personal divinity to be the source of obligations, to be the source of value, I think, a little bit better than a Platonic formulation, which is just entirely mysterious.

- 6.28** Anyway, so these debates have developed over the centuries, and now, attempts to develop objective frameworks for morality have, I think, turned much more towards theistic accounts. We've got lots of different examples that we can go through, that we will go through. One of the problems is, of course, a political one. Over the last 100, 150 years, questions around religion and commitment, religious commitment, have become much, much more contentious, much more divisive, as it were.
- 6.29** And so, there's emerged a political philosophy, particularly in figures like John Rawls, that insists we've got to bracket our commitment, all of our commitments, that are contentious, including those that would involve commitment to the existence of God and commitment to the existence of God as the source of goodness and the source of obligation.
- 6.30** What we've got is a procedural agnosticism in the public square, where people of faith, people with religious commitment, are motivated by their religious commitment, but are not allowed to say that they are, and they're not allowed to introduce into the justification of public policy what it is that they think moral flourishing is grounded in.
- 6.31** This, you might say, is one of the consequences of a radically plural, liberal society where we prize freedom, we prize tolerance, and the ability for people to disagree, or at least to, as it were, domesticate the sources of their disagreement, so that they can find some middle ground. There are all kinds of social, political, and cultural headaches and difficulties invoking a theistic framework for the moral universe. They're always worth putting on the table, of course.
- 6.32** In America, debates around the First Amendment touch on these questions a great deal. Somewhere like England, where we actually have an established religion, you're allowed to talk about these questions even less freely than you are in the United States, at least is my impression. What that's done is, it's put a lot of pressure on secular theories of the good and secular ways of trying to make sense of obligation that are agnostic with respect to the existence of God.
- 6.33** So, what might some of those be? Well, there are a number of famous theories that have emerged over the last, particularly the last 200, 250 years. Obviously, there's the philosophy of Immanuel Kant, 1724 to 1804, and Kant in his great groundwork to the *Metaphysics of Morals*, 1785, and also his second critique, the *Critique of Practical Reason*, 1788, he develops this way of trying to think about morality and obligation that allows you to remain completely agnostic about God as the underlying ground for obligation.
- 6.34** What he does is, he appeals simply to reason, to reason, and reason's capacity to reflect upon duty and to discern duty. He develops, effectively, a theological moral

theory, that is to say, it bears many of the fingerprints of a theological theory in its claims about validity, universality, and objectivity. But he's insistent that you can't know that God exists. He doesn't think that any of the standard arguments for God's existence work. He gets rid of those or tries to get rid of those, not very successfully, in fact, in the first critique in 1781.

- 6.35** But then he goes on to say, in fact, we still need to have the idea of God, even if we can't know his reality, even if we can't accept and be committed to the claim that God exists. And so, Kant develops a theory that, as I said, bears a lot of the fingerprints of a theological framework. He stresses the autonomy of human beings, the dignity of human beings, which he understands as requiring respect for the self-legislating power of human beings through reason.
- 6.36** He never quite gets rid of God, or he never quite gets rid of the idea of God. It's always lingering there. In fact, in the second critique, he develops this very unusual argument for the existence of God, where he says we can't just surrender the idea of God when we're thinking about morality. Why? Well, he says that whenever we're acting morally, whenever we're contemplating a moral judgment, we do it—it's partly self-interested.
- 6.37** That is to say, we've got to be able to make sense of the idea that acting well, acting morally, is somehow conducive to our self-interest. Virtue and happiness must, in the end, come together in order for the moral universe to be a coherent moral universe. Then he goes on to say, but it's obvious that, in this world, virtuous people suffer, and vicious people often do very well. Vicious people often flourish.
- 6.38** So, there doesn't seem to be any kind of proper reconciliation of virtue and happiness. That is something that reason can't cope with, our moral reasoning can't cope with, because it would suggest that the moral universe is incoherent, is broken, is fragmented. And so, he says that we have to, as it were, postulate this idea. We have to posit the idea that there is a being capable of bringing together happiness and virtue in perfect proportion in some subsequent life, in some other world.
- 6.39** And so he argues, we must therefore assume, we must therefore imagine that we have souls that persist beyond this world, beyond biological death, and that we will, as it were, come face to face with what he calls the "summum bonum," effectively, God. And God has the capacity to perfectly bring together happiness and virtue in a way that helps us to think of the moral universe as coherent and as integrated.
- 6.40** It's a very strange and involved argument, but Kant has had an enormous influence over subsequent philosophy, particularly the stress on individualism, on autonomy, and on reason. Most people have forgotten how important at least the idea of God is in Kantian ethics, and have simply taken Kant's framework and, as it were, pressed ahead with it.
- 6.41** And so, that's a very well-known attempt to come up with an account of morality and goodness that is independent of God, is entirely independent of religious

commitments, but even there, God comes, as it were, creeping in through the back door. Other theories that have been attempted over the years, particularly in the 19th century in England, people like Jeremy Bentham, you see bits of it in David Hume, and John Stuart Mill, developed this idea of goodness in terms of pleasure and of happiness, or utility, or the satisfaction of preferences.

- 6.42 This has also been a very sophisticated and, in some ways, compelling and attractive alternative to thinking about goodness that does not invoke, does not presuppose any theological commitment. Utilitarianism, as this great school is called, effectively tries to, as I said, reduce morality to questions of happiness and pleasure. And that the way to understand, the correct way to analyze a moral judgment is to consider the extent to which the act in question, the judgment in question, will bring about, will maximize the overall welfare of the greatest number of people.
- 6.43 And so the question is, you don't consult Scripture, you don't consult nature, you don't consult reason or your sense of inner duty. You simply look at the consequences of the act. Now, utilitarianism has come in for a lot of criticisms over the years. It's true that it can lead to some very unusual outcomes that philosophers like Bernard Williams have drawn attention to, again and again.
- 6.44 One example that Bernard Williams comes up with, I think, is a scenario where he asks us to imagine introducing capital punishment for anyone caught parking on a double yellow line in London. And Bernard Williams argues that the utilitarian should be completely happy with this, because although a few unfortunate souls will be executed without trial for parking on a double yellow line outside Harrods, the sum total of the increased happiness of nine million Londoners, of having more freely flowing streets, will vastly exceed the pain of the poor dozen people who've been executed and their families and friends and so on.
- 6.45 Therefore, the utilitarian should be in favor of capital punishment for parking on a double yellow line in London and should do it without hesitating, without a second thought, because the calculation is clear. We've calculated how to maximize pleasure, how to maximize happiness. And of course, Bernard Williams' point is that it's a *reductio ad absurdum*. This is profoundly counterintuitive. This can't be right.
- 6.46 It must be that—we must think of the good not as something that is something that is purely descriptive, that just makes us happy or is pleasurable. When we're talking about the good, we're talking about something very distinct, something very different, something that is not, in fact, natural. Happiness is a natural property. What gives us pleasure is a physiological and a natural question involving nature.
- 6.47 But the good is something that is non-natural. It is something that is indefinable. It is always going to lead to an open question. What that means is that, if you're a naturalist, that is to say, you think that all truths are scientific truths, then you've got a puzzle as to how you fit in something that is, it seems, non-natural. Here, probably the

most famous thinker, or the most famous theory advancing and defending this claim that the good is not natural, is G. E. Moore, the great Cambridge philosopher, who comes up with a very famous argument called the open question argument.

- 6.48** And what he suggests is that, if it's really the case that the utilitarians are right and that goodness is something to be understood in terms of pleasure, then you wouldn't expect the semantic problems that arise when you frame these, when you put the word goodness into a question, which do, in fact, arise. And so, the point is that any natural property can, in fact, lead to questions that we can make complete sense of.
- 6.49** For example, if we think of goodness as simply that which generates pleasure, then that is something that we will always, as it were, struggle to form into an open question. So think of it this way: I know that eating meat is pleasurable, but is it the right thing to do? Is it the right thing to do? Now, the point is, if the right and the good simply meant that which gives you pleasure, then that question wouldn't make sense. But it does make sense. There's a further element, there's a further dimension to the concept of right and the concept of good, beyond merely giving pleasure.
- 6.50** Yes, I understand that that gives pleasure, but still, is it the right thing to do? I like eating meat. It gives me pleasure, makes me happy, but is it the right thing to do? Moore's argument is that, because that question makes sense, it's clear that the right and the good is something that is more than what simply naturally gives me pleasure or makes me happy. The good is something that is indefinable, something much more resistant to analysis in purely naturalistic terms.
- 6.51** Obviously, at this point, although Moore himself was not a theist—in fact, he's in many ways the founding father of the analytic anglophone philosophical tradition that, at least until recently, has been notoriously allergic to questions about theism and God and religion—nevertheless, Moore opens the door to an understanding of the good that is very puzzling within the naturalistic universe. It's very puzzling to somebody who wants to really understand reality purely in scientific terms.
- 6.52** It's not a problem that theists need to worry about at all. On the theistic framework, you've got a fairly straightforward setup, theoretically. You've got God, and then you have world. The world is to be understood maybe in natural terms, as in nature and space-time. But also, it's to be understood in moral terms. The natural world creation is invested, is infused with, God's normative principles, direction, goals, and so on.
- 6.53** And within the secular world, you have this puzzle of how you get from an "is" to an "ought". How do you get from describing the world to drawing prescriptions from the world? How do you go from descriptions to prescriptions? It's always possible, as David Hume argued, to observe the world, and to describe it, and to be tempted then to say, "Well, that's how the way the world is, and this is how it ought to be." This is how it ought to be.

- 6.54** Hume says you can't do that. You can't move from just the way the world is to injunctions about how we, therefore, ought to behave. There's a split here. There are various reasons why Hume argues this. But on the theological framework, on a theological framework, you don't have that; that issue doesn't really arise. Yes, the world is what it is as we find it, as we experiment upon it, as we describe it. But because within the theistic context, the world emerges from God's created blueprint for it, and because that created blueprint also involves certain desires that God has, what God wills to be the case, then that grounds oughts. It grounds rules and prescriptions and normativity, as it were, morality. The two go together, the normative and the natural.
- 6.55** There are other problems that arise here if you develop a strong secular understanding of morality. For example, if we take the evolutionary account, the standard evolutionary account of human origins and development, and have it as a purely atheistic account, then what we have is the specter of skepticism looming.
- 6.56** This is because, and we've come across this kind of argument before, the basic idea is that, again, just as adaptive fitness and Darwinian theory is not interested in whether or not we reason truthfully about the world, but simply that we engage with the world in a way that confers survival advantage, so too, natural selection is not interested in whether or not we are tracking goodness, whether or not we're doing the right thing or the wrong thing. All it cares about is adaptive fitness, survival value.
- 6.57** So there's a very interesting influential philosopher called Sharon Street at NYU, who's argued that you can't both sign up to a naturalistic, atheistic evolutionary theory and say that there is a moral universe out there that is real and objective. Once you're on Darwin's bus, you can't just jump off it.
- 6.58** Once you're on Darwin's bus, you've got to have an account of human beings that is framed not in terms of seeking the good, because sometimes seeking the good might confer adaptive value. But very often you could imagine that acting well, acting selflessly, acting altruistically, will not be conducive to your survival. And so what Sharon Street argues is that you can't have your cake and eat it. You can't both have this exclusively evolutionary, atheistic evolutionary, naturalistic understanding of human origins and development, and sign up to there being an objective standard for right and wrong.
- 6.59** So what we have there is a back-handed compliment to the idea, from Plato onwards, that there is a conceptual complicity between God and the good. Sharon Street, who's not a theist, she's a naturalist, she's an atheist, but she's saying that, yes, the two do go together. If you're going to remove God and have a purely atheistic evolutionary account of human origins and development, then you cannot also have a commitment to the reality of the good and the reality of goodness.

- 6.60 What we've got is an interesting landscape in philosophy of religion over the last, let's say, 20, 25 years, because you've had the resurgence of a confidence and commitment to moral realism, the idea that morality really is out there. But as various secular theories have struggled to ground moral realism in nature, just in the way that the world, in the way that nature is understood these days, or in terms of utility, or in terms of Kantian duty, the more those have struggled, the more attractive, at least a theoretical theistic account of God and morality has come to seem.
- 6.61 The religious responses, responses within philosophy of religion to secular ethics, have not just touched on the inadequacy of the account of what morality is, but also on a lot of other features, too. Because it's not just the case that we want an account of what morality is, what goodness is, what obligations are. There's also other factors that need to be considered, because morality is not just about describing the way the world is or describing the moral universe, it's also got to give some account of how we're motivated to act morally. It's got to have some account of our psychology. What is it that moves us? What is it that motivates us?
- 6.62 And one of the great contributions that David Hume makes, the great Scottish philosopher, is to constantly stress the need for an account of what is it that makes us tick, morally? What is it that motivates us? It's not just facts. It's not just, as it were, understanding divine commands or Kantian duties. It's also to do with our feelings. It's also to do with how we are moved to act.
- 6.63 He famously argues that just purely having a cognitive awareness of moral judgments is not going to, in fact, be particularly conducive to acting morally, to issuing clear, and reasoning and deliberating in a clear way about one's moral judgments. You can imagine figures from the horror films like Hannibal Lecter. What's so chilling about Hannibal Lecter, of course, is that he's got this complete command. He's enormously intelligent, and there's nothing he doesn't know about how, in theory, to act well.
- 6.64 But of course, he doesn't. He's a serial killer. He's a monster. He's simply unmoved. He's got all the facts at his fingertips. He's got all the moral knowledge and probably more than most people, but there's no motivation there. There's complete indifference to responding to the good in a particular, in the right way.
- 6.65 And so how do we make sense of the problem of motivation, especially in a context where the universe is understood to be ultimately meaningless? Within the atheistic framework, morality is something that is constructed, it's something that you might take society at its word for, but it's not something that is wired into the way the world is.
- 6.66 And so you have these different theories emerging, particularly in the 19th century, about how morality is really a conspiracy trick, in the writings of Nietzsche, of course. Friedrich Nietzsche insists that what morality is, is a conspiracy trick, which the weak play on the strong to try and create this artificial level playing field of equality and

tolerance and freedom, because it's the only way they can keep the overman, the Übermensch, the superman, in check.

- 6.67** The idea here is that religion—Judaism and Christianity—are the tools used to create this. The ethics of Judaism and Christianity, that is what creates this artificial level playing field. Or if you look at somebody like Karl Marx, for Marx, questions of religion and morality are tools that the powerful use, the property classes use, to keep in check the working classes, the proletariat. It's a kind of anesthetic. It's an opiate to keep people numb.
- 6.68** Now, what's interesting is that those two critiques, those two analyses of morality and religion, can't both be right. They are effectively contradictory. On the one hand, morality and religion is something for Nietzsche that the weak use to keep in check the strong. For Marx, morality and religion is a tool which the strong use to keep in check, to keep the weak from revolution. But both accounts are strategies of suspicion and skepticism.
- 6.69** You see other versions of this, too. For example, the emergence of psychology and psychoanalysis at the end of the 19th century in Vienna, at the beginning of the 20th century here the idea is that morality is not something that we need to tune ourselves into the divine to understand. In fact, there's no real morality at all. It's simply deep, suppressed feelings within our psyche that make us tick and make us and shape our moral judgments.
- 6.70** And there we have this idea that the science comes in. You have the emergence of, effectively, a science of the mind, a science of the psyche, and a way of thinking about wrongdoing, about doing right and about doing wrong, that is effectively reductive. It treats wrongdoing more, maybe as a pathology or as a disease.
- 6.71** It's this shift from sin to syndrome, that behaving badly is really something that—it's a psychiatric condition, something that's to be treated and not something that is to be, as in the traditional religious understanding, confessed and accounted for, and the subject of judgment. And so, all of these skeptical strategies have, as it were, fragmented our shared moral discourse, our shared moral grammar.
- 6.72** Some of you might already be familiar with that wonderful opening chapter of a book by Alasdair MacIntyre, who died just a few months ago, called *After Virtue*. And in this opening chapter, he invites us to imagine what might happen in the wake of a nuclear Holocaust, when it comes to understanding and piecing back together the world of the natural sciences.
- 6.73** And what MacIntyre argues is that, in such a scenario, there would be a dim memory of different scientific theories and what they did and roughly what happened in laboratories, but it would be basically pretty incoherent. There'd be all these dialogues of the deaf. There'd be this mutual misunderstanding, huge parts of science that we'd forgotten about and couldn't really make sense of.

- 6.74** And then he says that this, in fact, is what happened in the Enlightenment in the 18th century, when it comes not to the sciences, but to morality, to moral philosophy. He said what the effect of the Enlightenment on understandings of the good, and particularly the relationship of the good and with God, it was something equivalent, the intellectual equivalent, to a nuclear Holocaust.
- 6.75** All of these different theories begin to emerge, whether they're Humean theories, whether they're utilitarian theories, Kantian theories, theories of strategies of suspicion in Nietzsche and Marx and Freud. And what this has done is, it's completely fragmented our hitherto shared moral grammar. And that although we're using the language of the good and of virtue and of vice and of evil and right and wrong, we actually, no longer as a society in the West, have any shared sense of what those different words are doing and what those different words mean.
- 6.76** From a theistic point of view, you might say, well, that's to be expected. If you've got, as it were, foundational to the moral universe, one single being with powers, with intentions, with a will, who's invested the natural order with the normative, with the moral, and you simply remove that, then you're going to see the fragmentation that MacIntyre diagnoses.
- 6.77** In a way, you might say it's what explains a lot of the dialogues of the deaf, perhaps, in the public square all across the West today. Why is it that basically sincere, highly educated, well informed people can disagree so violently and so aggressively about such fundamental questions? It's very puzzling. If those questions were simply in other areas of public policy or questions of economics, yes, the debates get a bit fiery, but effectively, solutions are found. When it comes to morality, there is this sense of almost irreconcilability between different corners.
- 6.78** One explanation of this is that we simply don't have that shared sense of what it is that we're doing when we're using the language of morality. We have completely conflicting accounts of what morality is grounded in. To be clear, one point that the theist is not going to want to make is that, without belief in God, or if you're not religious, you can't be a good person, or you can't conduct yourself morally. That's not the claim that the theist is making.
- 6.79** The claim that the theist is making is that, ultimately, in terms of when it comes philosophically to grounding an account of what goodness is, and therefore, and having a coherent account of why it is that we want to act, conform to our obligations, and why it is we believe that the good is what it is, the theist has a better story, a better account, a better theory, of what anchors goodness, what anchors the moral universe, than the non-theist.
- 6.80** On the theistic view, morality has an objectivity, it has a motivational power, it has a particular structure, it has a categoricity, it has an authority, which is much harder to find on non-theistic frameworks, naturalistic frameworks, that nature just is what it is,

or on utilitarian frameworks, where calculations of happiness are going to vary from situation to situation. There'll be all kinds of disagreement over that.

- 6.81** And in the end, questions of utility and happiness and desire are, for short, for the reasons that Moore explained, of goodness as this indefinable non-natural property, something that is more than mere pleasure, more than mere, more than mere happiness. And so what we have is a much more fragmented moral universe where we're more comfortable talking about rights than the right.
- 6.82** And what you might say that we see in the wake of the Second World War and the emergence of rights-based jurisdictions all across the world, and really, in a global sense, with the United Nations Declaration on Human Rights, is a shift from understanding the good of something that is shared and fundamental and foundational, or the right that is shared and foundational, and into a much more atomized way of thinking about ethics and morality, where human agents, moral agents, are simply autonomous beings with rights and with the power to determine how those rights are to be fulfilled and how those rights are to be exercised.
- 6.83** But there is agnosticism in all of these rights documents, as to what it is that grounds these rights, what it is that endows human beings with dignity. Up until recently, that was an uncomplicated problem. It was not a problem that people faced at all. To have dignity, was, as it were, to bear the image of God. You have this idea in the Jewish tradition, particularly in the Christian tradition, too, that human uniqueness and human ensoulment is something that transcends the merely natural and doesn't require the United Nations or any other body to confer it on human beings.
- 6.84** It is what it is, because you have this very straightforward theological way of thinking about human dignity and the sacred dimensions of the human person. Now, there is agnosticism over that, or it's a forced agnosticism. You're not allowed to—it's too contentious to articulate an account of human preciousness and human uniqueness in theological terms.
- 6.85** So, there are sort of vague allusions in the beginning of the United Nations Declaration on Human Rights to the human family, and our sense of the brotherhood of man, as it puts it. But it doesn't go into any detail as to what it is that actually grounds human dignity and grounds rights. Again, we see there a backhanded compliment to the thought that God and goodness are conceptually complicit.
- 6.86** And that as soon as you unravel them, take them apart, then you start to see that this idea of goodness, or the moral universe that should promote social flourishing, begins to fall apart, begins to break up into silos that can't talk to each other, that no longer share any moral vocabulary and moral grammar.
- 6.87** Drawing to a close now, what we've seen over the course of this lecture is going right back to Plato, right back really to the dawn of thought, this deep impulse that the way to think about morality, and particularly the way to think about morality as something

that is discovered rather than invented, is to ground it in something that is transcendent.

- 6.88** Now, Plato himself doesn't do that, doesn't ground it in God. He insists on adding an O. He grounds it in the good. We looked at various difficulties and challenges with that. We then looked at the tensions between this idea of God stipulating what's right and wrong, and then God subordinating himself to what's right and wrong. We suggested some ways, we looked at some ways of, as it were, trying to find a middle, the tight rope between those two horns of the Euthyphro dilemma.
- 6.89** We then turned to consider what it would be like, to think through morality in a way that is completely God-free. We looked at the various theories of Kant and the utilitarians and the Rawlsians, and we noticed that they all come up with the same dilemma, the same problem, that ultimately there's no anchor, there's no foundational account of what it is that obligation springs from.
- 6.90** In the next lecture, we're going to be turning, going more deeply into questions that—to touch on morality, we'll be thinking about questions of meaning, mysticism, and religious experience. Very often we'll be looking here at how, very often in the history of religious mystical traditions, there is that sense that somehow we can tap into the good through almost a private revelation, through experience that provides the kind of motivating power to be a better person. Thanks for listening.

Lecture 7: Experiencing the Divine

At a glance — Religious experience and experiencing the divine as evidence and phenomenon.

- 7.1** Welcome to lecture 7 in Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. One of the things about studying philosophy of religion is that it can seem almost unbearably cognitive and intellectual the whole time. That is, in fact, not always true of the religious life. Religious people, obviously, very often are interested in the history of their traditions and interested to different degrees in arguments for and against their religious commitments being true.
- 7.2** But of course, up until now, we've been, as it were, airbrushing out, or we haven't really touched on the other dimension to the religious life, you might say, a much more important dimension to the religious life, namely that sense of existential rootedness and of religious experience, the experience that religious people have of the divine, of the world, of one another, in the context of their religious beliefs.
- 7.3** And so, I want now to push us beyond the merely cognitive and the merely philosophical, and to think more about: How do we make sense of religious experience as a cross-cultural phenomenon that many, many people have reported as having, to one degree or another? We can reflect also on how we understand religious experience. How do we understand the great mystics of the world's religious traditions? Can we think of them as disclosing truths about the divine, truths about what it is to be human? How do we evaluate those claims?
- 7.4** And so, it's a central question in epistemology, that is to say, a central question in our theory and philosophy of how we come to know the world, whether or not we can think of subjective religious experiences as giving us some kind of access to, or knowledge of, divine reality.
- 7.5** Of course, religious experience is a universal phenomenon. There are lots of differences in the detail. But broadly speaking, the idea that experiences of the divine is something that is overwhelming, as something that fills us with a sense of the sublime, that fills us with awe, sometimes with fear, a kind of "mysterium tremendum" —that is something that we have a very, very wide range of accounts, all across different religious traditions for. Indeed, these accounts go right, right back to the beginning of recorded history.
- 7.6** There are different types of religious experiences, the accounts that stress, that are mystical union with the divine, a sense of the numinous, a sense of transcendence, visions or conversion experiences. If you think of the famous conversion experience of St. Paul in the Book of Acts in the New Testament, it's very tempting these days—in modernity, of course, the analysis is, "Oh, he must have had epilepsy or something." We've got to be able to describe this in purely scientific, purely psychological ways.

- 7.7 We've got to—it's the neuroscientists that can tell us what's going wrong, when somebody is having a religious experience and so on. There is this complete mutual misunderstanding between secular neuroscience and scientific ways of thinking about human behavior and human experience. And this claim that goes all the way through the different religious traditions, that actually many religious experiences are veridical. That is to say, they are stating the truth.
- 7.8 They're reporting feelings and experiences that have, in fact, been— that have been had, and also that are not simply reduced or reducible to some kind of psychiatric condition or neuroscientific or neurophysiological substrate. And so, there are various figures that I think are illuminating on these questions.
- 7.9 Probably the most illuminating of all is the American pragmatist philosopher William James, brother of the great novelist, Henry James. He produces this extraordinary book called *The Varieties of Religious Experience* in 1902. What James tries to argue is that there are ways, there are criteria we can apply to mystical experience that give us a sense of its irreducibility and of its reality that help us to take it seriously on its own terms.
- 7.10 The first feature that he noted, that he suggests, is a criterion of authenticity, as it were, for a mystical experience— ineffability, ineffability. Meaning, simply, it can't be put into words. The person undergoing a religious experience often struggles adequately to express that experience and its significance in ordinary language. It's more as if religious experiences is more a flow, a flux of feelings, than it is ideas or thoughts or states of the mind, states of the intellect.
- 7.11 But despite that, there's also, James says, a noetic quality to mystical experience. Noetic from the Greek "nous," meaning mind. It's noetic, that is to say, it's not completely non-cognitive. It's not just feelings. There is also a sense of knowledge, there's a sense of, a grasp of underlying reality. There can be illuminations, there might be revelations that are full of significance for the subject of the religious experience.
- 7.12 The third criterion that James draws attention to is just transience. These feelings, these experiences, they can't be sustained for long periods. They tend to be brief but very transformative encounters. Finally, he notes that they are often encounters where the subject of religious experience has a sense of passivity, has a sense that the experience is happening to the subject, is being grasped by some kind of higher power. "The mystic feels," James writes, "as if his own will, his own desires, were being suspended in some way."
- 7.13 And so, this provides us with a very nice roadmap for understanding different mystical experiences down the centuries, all across the different traditions. James goes on to say, "What are we to make of this? How do we understand the varieties of religious experience, and how do we judge them?" James is ever the pragmatist. He says that you look, first of all, at the fruits. Is there evidence of changed behavior? Is their

character somehow different? Then consider the question of personal authority. Are experiences authoritative for the experiencer, but not necessarily for others? That will often be the case.

- 7.14** Then questions of cultural variation, James noticed, is, although there will be very different, in the particulars, different accounts of religious experience from tradition to tradition and from culture to culture, broadly speaking, he thinks those four hallmarks—the ineffability, the transience, the noetic quality, and the passivity—are common to a very, very wide range of reported religious experiences, no matter what the culture, no matter what the religion, no matter what the historical period.
- 7.15** Finally, James helpfully stresses the importance of not over-psychologizing human experiences, not assuming religious experiences, not assuming that the only account, the only full correct explanation of religious experience, must be in terms of science and psychology on the one hand, but also not over-theorizing the theological and the metaphysical account of what the religious experience is. He says that you simply focus on the experience and on the experience as it's reported.
- 7.16** I think that's a very useful framework. A number of people I've met who've undergone religious experiences, who are not prone to mysticism, not prone to getting overly emotional about religious questions, but there's one or two that I do know who've had religious experiences, and these criteria, almost all of them, are met in some way. It's always affected their lives in some transformative way.
- 7.17** They can say that they were genuinely—it was transformative, that they became a different kind of person after the experience. They looked at the world in a different way. They had a better sense of themselves. The question then is, could just a hallucination or just a strange dream or just a strange quirky experience, is it plausible that those experiences can have this lifelong transformative effect on a human being? I suppose it is true, or certainly possible.
- 7.18** But I think, when you read accounts of people's conversion experiences or people's mystical experiences, religious experiences, it does very often, on the fruits criterion, James' fruits criterion, it is striking just what a long-term existential, as it were, psychological impact these experiences can have on people who undergo them.
- 7.19** Another important thinker to bring to the table, in addition to William James, is Rudolf Otto. Rudolf Otto was a famous German thinker, wrote a wonderful book in 1917 called *Das Heilige*, the Holy, or it's translated as *The Idea of the Holy*. Otto introduces this idea of the "mysterium tremendum et fascinans." Of course, that's a phrase that goes far further back. It's Latin for this sense of tremendous mystery, and "fascinans," something that is mesmerizing, a mystery, a mystical experience that mesmerizes.
- 7.20** It's a mystery, a religious experience. There's a sense that we're encountering mystery, because there's a sense we're encountering something that is wholly other, that is radically different, completely beyond the normal categories of thought and

experience. It's "tremendum" because it inspires often, almost fear or awe, a sense of overwhelming power and anxiety and majesty, as well.

7.21 Also, the "fascinans" has this mesmerizing, compelling, attractive quality to it. It pulls the experience in, a bit like William James says, the subject feels passive, as if some greater power is sweeping the person up. Otto stresses, this is not fully rational. It is, as James also argues, a question of an experience of mysticism, transcends moral and rational categories.

7.22 And if you like, we could even talk in terms of a religious consciousness, something that is almost—Otto says it's like this innate capacity. It's a sort of sixth sense. It's also something that's universal, says Otto. It's something that all human beings, in principle, have the capacity for. What he suggests is that, rather than it being an add-on, religious experience is, in fact, foundational. It's actually fundamental.

7.23 Of course, up until now in this lecture series, we've been looking at, in very rational ways, about philosophy of religion. We've been looking at arguments for the existence of God. We've been looking at arguments against the existence of God. We've been looking at questions to do with morality and moral philosophy. This is all very rational, very, very, very cognitive.

7.24 But Otto says, actually, that is the superstructure. The foundations always flow from these profound experiences that have a motivating and transformative power on believers. And so, mystics throughout the centuries, particularly within institutional religion, always got this uncertain place within the institution. Often they start at the edges of it, the mystics. They are often monks. They're in caves. They're not particularly well-known people.

7.25 Those experiences, as they come to write them down, become more and more important, and more and more central, to the devotional life of those people within the religion. If you think of the Desert Fathers from the 3rd and 4th century AD, or you think of famous texts like *The Cloud of Unknowing* or Julian of Norwich's meditations on—*Revelations on Divine Love*. Those are fundamental texts that, although they emerge from the periphery of institutional religion, very rapidly move to the center.

7.26 But it's always very threatening. It's always very threatening, where you have figures who are claiming some kind of private revelation or private insight into the nature of the divine or into theological questions. That can be very destabilizing for an institutional religion. John Henry Newman, the famous convert from Anglicanism to Catholicism in the 19th century, once famously said that the trouble with mysticism is that it begins in mist and ends in schism.

7.27 That is to say, trouble with mysticism is that you start—it has these introspective, private, privileged experiences that you can't, by definition, communicate to others. This leads to tensions within a church, tensions within a community, that requires, in order to be grounded and to be an ordered community, requires certain consensus

around what's true and what's understood to be doctrine and dogma and so on. Many mystics have not ended well at the hands of their co-religionists, but they've always, as it were, sustained; they've always provided a lot of energy for the devotional life of religious traditions.

- 7.28** So we've looked at William James, we've looked at Rudolf Otto, and there are others we could have looked at, but they're probably the two most well-known, the classic texts on the question of religious experience and mysticism. But it's worth also trying to step into a more contemporary context and to come up with some typologies of our own.
- 7.29** One that I find quite useful is that religious experience can be both very introvertive: it's inward-focused, it's to do with the sense of oneself or the dissolution of oneself, and its interior, and it's to do with consciousness, one's own consciousness. And then there's an extrovertive religious experience, which is much, much more outward-looking, that sees the divine presence in the external world, that you might see as a nature mysticism.
- 7.30** Here, you might even think of a Thoreau or an Emerson in the American tradition in the 19th century. That's the Transcendentalists. It's a kind of mysticism that sees the divine, or fingerprints of the divine, in the natural world, in the sense of awe and the sublime that often arise when encountering the natural world.
- 7.31** But both the introvertive and the extrovertive, it's a dynamic that you see all the way through these different mystical experiences and different religious experiences, as a common core to the structure of religious experiences in that way. Often, but not always, religious experiences will be theistic. There will be some sense of the divine or encountering a divine being, whether it's God, whether it's Christ, Allah, or Krishna in the Indian traditions.
- 7.32** Often, it won't be a sense of encountering a divine being at all, but there will be some sense of—the language will often be, there's a sense of being absorbed into the One, into some sort of undifferentiated source of being. This is very common, for example, in the Indian traditions, with this sense of identification with Brahman. You get it in the Chinese traditions, too. In Daoism, this sense of full attunement to the harmonies of nature and the harmonies of the natural world, and almost a dissolution of the self, a forgetting of oneself as a center of subjectivity and the center of experience.
- 7.33** Sometimes these experiences will change or transform people in different ways. Sometimes it'll be very, very sudden, like a bit of instantaneous transformation. More commonly, there'll be a gradual development of the self, a gradual moral transformation, a progressive spiritual growth. And very often in different religious traditions, those will be supported by the different forms of meditation, of prayer, of devotional life, and so on and so forth.

- 7.34** One question that arises immediately: How could we come to assess whether or not religious experiences tell us anything? Are they just psychological events? Is it just a question of the mind or the brain just trying to sort itself out, but it's purely to be understood in naturalistic terms? There's been a lot of debate about this. Can we think of religious experiences as somehow supporting religious rational commitment? Can we think of it as some way supporting the idea that God, or that the divine, might be real and not just a figment of a fevered imagination?
- 7.35** Lots of philosophers have looked at this over the years. One very influential one is Richard Swinburne in Oxford, and he's written a lot about this, the arguments from religious experience and how we're to make sense of religious experience. What Swinburne asks us to apply, when we're considering different religious experiences, is the principle of credulity, the principle of credulity. What does he mean by that?
- 7.36** Well, very roughly, if it seems to be the case to somebody undergoing some experience, or if it seems to be the case that something is present, then probably that something is indeed present. The principle of credulity. We should, as it were, take reports of mystical experiences and religious experiences, broadly speaking, at face value.
- 7.37** Broadly speaking, the default assumption should be that these experiences are self-reported accounts of what the subject has undergone and has felt and believed, or believed to have revealed to him, unless there are certain defeating conditions in place. So the default assumption, the default principle, should be credulity, unless there's very strong reasons to believe otherwise.
- 7.38** Swinburne's point is, look, if somebody thinks that they've experienced God, then that is good prima facie evidence that they have experienced God, that God is real, that God exists. The burden of proof, says Swinburne, should be on the shoulders of the skeptics who want to try to show or provide reasons for doubting that person's account. That's the starting point. It shouldn't be for the believers to provide proof.
- 7.39** In most situations, we take people's word for it. We take people at face value, take people for granted, unless there are reasons that lead us into thinking that they might be making things up. Maybe there's a motive there; they might be doing it to sell books, or they might be doing it because they've had too much to drink, or whatever it might be, or they're notoriously unreliable. It's not a principle of being credulous or overly credulous.
- 7.40** But it is basically noting that, generally speaking, when somebody tells you something, that they've obviously experienced something, they've undergone a particular experience, you take them at their word, unless there's a good reason to suppose that they're not being veridical, that they're not being truthful.
- 7.41** What are the types of defeating conditions that Swinburne draws our attention to? Well, look, if the experience contradicts what we already know to be the case, then

we've got grounds for not applying the principle of credulity. Unreliable circumstances, as I said earlier, where there might be some psychological condition or ulterior motive or extreme stress or whatever it might be.

- 7.42 We might look at the person's track record. Do they have a track record of being truthful? And so on and so forth. One would have to be open to alternative explanations as well, or more plausible naturalistic accounts of experience might be available. But apart from those defeating conditions, the basic presumption should be that the subject is reporting the experiences to the world as they happened, as the person experienced them.
- 7.43 Another point that Swinburne makes is, if you take all of these experiences together, all kinds of interesting patterns emerge. Patterns that display a certain consistency, that often involve somelife transformation, often a costly life transformation, and that, broadly speaking, there's a lot of convergent evidence across all the different reports.
- 7.44 One account that I remember reading about, not so much a religious experience—well, it was a religious experience, but it was a report, in fact, turned into a book by a gentleman called Howard Storm, who was an art professor in Kentucky, I believe, who traveled to France in round about 1985 and had a terrible, I think, a terrible medical incident and was taken to a hospital in Paris, where he claims that he died.
- 7.45 Now, one of the reasons he died is that there were no doctors around, and it was a weekend, and the French doctors had decided not to look after the hospital that weekend. He describes this very, very detailed religious experience, what he calls, what he thinks of and insists was a near-death experience. He insists that he died. A very, very detailed experience, a very interesting book where he claims to have met, come face to face with Jesus, and to have had a conversation with him.
- 7.46 This man was an atheist, very skeptical towards religion, very dismissive and derisive about it. Now, we have to form our own views as to whether or not we think that that book and Howard's account of what he experienced was veridical. But one thing that's striking is that, immediately after that experience, he was somehow, doctors came in, and they managed to get him to the point of recovery. It took a year or two years for him to fully recover.
- 7.47 But from there on, ever since that experience that Howard underwent, his life was completely transformed in a very, very costly way. For example, he became fanatically religious and indeed became a pastor in the end. This is something his wife couldn't really put up with, so his marriage broke up. In the end, he just couldn't fit back into his college in Kentucky, where he had this wonderful tenured job. He lost that job and was out of work for many years.
- 7.48 It was a transformative—it had transformative consequences, this experience. Again, I think one has to apply the principle of credulity and say, "Listen, there's no real reason why Howard would have been making all of this stuff up, at least as it appeared to him,

as he experienced it, because of the transformative impact that it's had, both positive and negative, on his life."

- 7.49** It's a good indicator of authenticity. It's a good indicator of, if not veridicality, of truthfulness, at least truthfulness of the self-reporting. There's no reason to doubt, I think, what Howard experienced, whether or not it's something that actually is disclosive of the divine, or is that we can understand it as being genuinely in contact with some postmortem world or postmortem life. Again, we can remain agnostic about that, but still accept that what Howard believes happened to him was indeed something that he experienced directly.
- 7.50** Another important thinker and philosopher here is William Alston, whose brilliant book, *Perceiving God*, from the early 1990s, starts to try to come up with this theory of mystical perception as a genuine way of perceiving the world, a genuine way of accessing and understanding the world. And what Alston argues is that the mystic, when the mystic is undergoing experiences, is in fact, it is analogous. It's a little bit like sense perception, he argues.
- 7.51** It's because, in religious experience, the divine is experienced directly in the way, as it is when we perceive ordinary things. The divine is not something in a religious experience that we infer or we conclude or we theorize about. It's something that is presentational. It's not something where God is re-presented or thought about in the mind. It's simply, God is presented directly to the mystic, to the person undergoing the experience, or that's at least the awareness or the sense of it.
- 7.52** And mystical perception, says Alston, is actually very similar in lots of ways in its structure and how it feels, how we respond to it phenomenologically, that is to say, in terms of appearance, to the ways in which we experience or perceive ordinary things. And so Alston develops a framework in which we can talk about a mystical practice.
- 7.53** And he argues also, he calls these doxastic practices, practices to do with how we structure belief around religious experience, and that this is completely rational. It's entirely rational to take part in these practices. Indeed, that is what believers do in their place of worship. They are often bodily practices, ceremonies, liturgies, and so on and so forth.
- 7.54** And so, these are the different strategies for understanding what religious experience is and how to understand it. In previous lectures, I've mentioned this idea of properly basic beliefs, or just taking things for granted as they come. This idea of proper basicity that Alvin Plantinga has developed, this idea is that we can believe that God exists. That can be a rational commitment, even though we can treat it as basic.
- 7.55** We can treat it as something that doesn't require foundations. It doesn't require some fancy, clever philosophical argument to support it. It can simply be something that we apprehend and treat as basic. I think the analogy that I gave in a previous lecture was the belief that, your belief, I hope, that I have a mind and my belief that you have

minds. These are perfectly rational beliefs, but they're basic beliefs, because they're not beliefs that I could give any evidence for.

7.56 Because a mind under a microscope looks exactly the same as there being no mind under a microscope. These are not things that we can detect. They're not things that we can provide evidence for. But we can still be rational in believing that there are features of reality for which we can't provide satisfactory evidence. That's the case with other people's minds. We might be able to see other people's brains, but we can't see other people's minds.

7.57 And similarly, it's the case, says Plantinga, when it comes to undergoing, having experience of God, having a feeling that God exists or having a basic belief that God exists. And it can be, in the appropriate circumstances, that can be basic. It doesn't require evidence and it doesn't require argument.

7.58 Of course, the problem very often arises in these debates that skepticism will be keyed to one's prior assumptions about whether or not religious claims make sense. It will be tempting, obviously, for an atheist to repudiate and deny any account of somebody who's undergone a religious experience, or at least to treat that as veridical, to treat it as something that really has happened. Of course, the approach for the atheist would be to come up with a purely psychological, reductive account of what this experience really was.

7.59 Of course, for a believer, it's going to be completely different. At least the believer will be open to the idea that there's a purely psychological explanation, will be open to the idea that maybe the person was drinking too much, or maybe the person is motivated to make it up because he's got a book to sell. But the believer will also be open to the possibility that the experience is veridical.

7.60 In most of the great religious traditions, the view is that the divine wants to communicate itself somehow to believers, to human beings. That human beings are wired with what Calvin calls the "sensus divinitatis", a sense of the divine. It's almost that's part of, that's kind of wired into God's creatures. From the religious point of view, it's perfectly normal for human beings to be open to a sense of the divine, and it's entirely predictable. It's to be expected for the divine to disclose itself, Himself, to the believer in some dramatic, transformative way.

7.61 Now, up until now, we've been talking about mystical experience in a rather grand sense of Teresa of Ávila and Julian of Norwich and all of these really remarkable experiences. But religious experience can be a lot more muted and mundane than that. We find believers often talking of the feelings evoked by natural beauty, a sunset, mountains, or the starry sky.

7.62 Even Immanuel Kant, who is probably one of the most obsessively hyper-rationalistic philosophers that the Enlightenment ever produced, would often say, "Two things stir me above all: the starry heavens above, and the moral law within. They fill me with a

sense of *achtung*, a sense of wonder, a sense of awe." And so even the most hyper-rational philosopher, even somebody like Immanuel Kant, is open to this sense of the mysterious, of awe, of natural beauty, and the moral law within as having a transformative experiential effect.

- 7.63** And that's true, I think, of moral experience, feelings of guilt, feelings, perhaps, of moral obligation, feelings of delight at the workings of grace within the Christian tradition. These, too, can be forms of experience that conform the believer to their religious tradition in some way. Or big life crises—the death of a loved one, grief, existential anxiety—these are also, historically, ways that human beings have opened up to the divine and have opened up to a sense of the transcendent.
- 7.64** Or very simply, you hear very moving accounts, either from Catholics, of religious experience at the altar when they are receiving the Eucharist, or from evangelical Christians, of experiences that they feel or a sense of peace coming down on them when they are reading the Bible or when they are in a prayer group. Again, from Swinburne's point of view, one has to apply the principle of credulity here and think, unless there are defeating conditions, there's no reason not to take these reports and these experiences at face value.
- 7.65** Now, of course, from the naturalistic point of view, religious experiences are not veridical, and they have to be reduced or explained away in some way. We have lots of neurological accounts, from neuroscience, that insist that there's a neurological basis to these experiences. You have, as it were, the MRI scans where you can see patterns in brain activity when a religious person is undergoing some experience, whether it's meditation or whether it's prayer.
- 7.66** The argument is that you can actually see in the brain activity neurophysiological correlates, relationships, as it were, to the reported states, to the reported psychological states, of feelings of peace or the feelings of being in contact with the divine. And so the skeptical neuroscience crowd will simply say, "Well, so we can show it, we can prove that, really, this is all in the brain. This is all a purely, entirely satisfactory naturalistic explanation."
- 7.67** Now, in my view, these arguments from neuroscience are not terribly convincing. Of course, we know that psychological states or feelings or particular emotional responses to the world are going to have some correlate, some connection to our bodies, to our pulse, to our brains. That's not surprising. It's not surprising that we should be seeing these correlations.
- 7.68** However, for the claim to work, the skeptical claim to work, has got to be not that there's a correlation between the brain and these experiential states, but that there's a causal impact, that it's the brain that's bringing about these experiences and not some external factor or some higher power. I think what neuroscience shows us is nothing at all on that front. All it shows us is that there's a correlation.

- 7.69** It does not show us that there's causal traffic. It could not show us that there's a causal connection between the brain states and the psychological states of religious experience. For all we know, for all that neuroscience shows, is that the causal traffic runs in the other direction. That a person has an experience, an overwhelming experience of some higher power, and then the brain, and that's reflected or correlated to brain activity.
- 7.70** So, skeptical arguments from neuroscience that try to reduce or explain away religious experience, in my view, don't succeed on their own terms. They don't show anything one way or the other, just to be clear. Also, neuroscience doesn't show that the brain states are effects of some external psychological experience. But neuroscience is simply limited on these questions. Neuroscience can study the brain. It can't study the mind, because the mind is not an object of scientific inquiry.
- 7.71** It may be that we deny that there's any such thing as a mind. But if we do that, we can't do that on scientific grounds, because it's just trivially true that, if there are minds, they're not scientific things. They're not objects of scientific inquiry. They're not things that science can detect. I think there are things that the mind is something that we can detect, not least because, without it, we can't detect anything. The mind isn't just something we can add on to ourselves and add on to our experience of the world. The mind is the enabling condition of grasping anything at all, of being conscious at all.
- 7.72** Lots of attempts, skeptical attempts, to explain away religious experience through psychological explanations. Freud insists that it's a wish fulfillment or projections of unconscious desires. Others say that religious experience is a return to an infantile state and a prerational unity with one's mother, for example. Many, many other theories that have been introduced to try to explain religious experience away.
- 7.73** Arguments from sociological and cultural factors as well. Again, I think, what do we make of all these skeptical strategies? Again, I think they don't show us a great deal. Even if it were the case that neuroscience does show or did show that brain states are what bring religious experiences about, even if that were the case, that they could show the causal traffic going from brain states to psychological states, I don't see why this would trouble a religious believer.
- 7.74** A religious believer is going to be perfectly happy with the idea that, or as happy with the idea, that God can reveal himself to the believer through some external scenario, maybe just a sunset or an overwhelming sense of God's presence. Or he'll be equally happy with the idea that God can use brain states to bring about these veridical experiences. There's no constraint that the religious believer wants to place on how God brings about these religious, an experience of the divine, an experience of God.
- 7.75** It's perfectly possible, too, that natural causation goes hand in hand with supernatural causation. Again, there's nothing within the believer's worldview that insists that God can't act both supernaturally and there can also be natural causes at play. There can be

multiple causation. And so in the end, it's not clear that naturalistic explanations undermine, necessarily, the reliability and the veridicality of religious experiences.

7.76 Another skeptical strategy is to say that if you look at all these different experiences, you can see that's lots of contradictions between them. So, for example, there might be—you've got doctrinal content that is very, very different from tradition to tradition. In Islam, you have this stress on tawhid and on oneness. In Christianity, you've got the Trinity. Within Hinduism, Vedanta, you've got Advaita Vedanta, which is non-dualism. Then you've got with Shankara, and then Ramanuja, you've got a kind of dualism, this idea of God and self being distinct, and world and self being distinct.

7.77 You see these differences refracted through religious experience, different religious experiences. And so, the skeptic argues, because these experiences are so radically different, they can't be veridical, they can't be true, at least they can't all be true. The response that a lot of philosophers of religion have given to this is to say that, yes, there are definite differences in the self-reporting of experiences with the divine.

7.78 And yet, there is also, there are patterns that emerge. There's a common core to a lot of these experiences, to a lot of these reports, which William James diagnoses very, very well, very, very effectively. Despite the different cultural lenses, there is a sense of often a kind of ultimate reality out there that is transcendent, that is greater than the believer, that sweeps the believer up. Also, there's ineffability that William James draws attention to, the sense of not being able to put the experience into words and so on and so forth.

7.79 There's often also, with the religious experience, this sense of formation of development, of becoming a better person over time or becoming more attuned to the divine over time. And so, although there are lots and lots of problems involved in religious experience and making sense of religious experience, they are, by definition, private. They're incommunicable. You could describe them to people, but you can't make people experience what you're going through.

7.80 You've got privileged access to it as the person undergoing a religious experience. It's a very difficult thing to develop any kind of experiments on, in terms of social psychology, because they're not repeatable. You can't, as it were, put people in a room and make them undergo a religious experience under controlled conditions. Of course, it doesn't work that way. It's very difficult to verify, difficult to check, and so on and so forth. There could be no objective criteria to determine whether or not the experiences are veridical or authentic.

7.81 And so, this verification challenge, which religious believers are asked to meet by those who are skeptical of religious experiences, is not always easy. Again, what tends to have happened in the past and the broad consensus among philosophers of religion here is that one has to just look across the different accounts and look for patterns, see

the extent to which they conform to certain patterns, whether they exhibit internal consistency, whether they fit with the broader worldview of the religion.

7.82 And then one looks for the fruits, as William James says. You look for the pragmatic fruits, you look for evidence of the transformed life, and the long-term positive benefits and effects that it has on the believers, on the experience, as character and behavior. You also look at the extent to which the wider religious community is able to accommodate the person who's undergone the religious experience.

7.83 Where the experience is accommodated, is stitched into the community, that's generally a sign that the experience is, broadly speaking, compatible or consistent with the religious worldview of that community. We can see that mysticism and religious experience, although it's very difficult to get a philosophical grip on it, it's very, very difficult to develop arguments for or against religious experience as veridical; it's something that philosophers of religion are now increasingly waking up to as something that we need to have theories for.

7.84 We need to be able to understand how to make sense of them, and we need to be willing not to follow the secular skeptic down the road of insisting that any reported private unverifiable religious experience is somehow to be treated as trivial or not disclosive of the divine, not somehow taking us into an attunement with the reality of the religion and the reality of the divine.

7.85 Coming in to close, what we've looked at over this lecture is that part of the religious life that is not connected so much to the cognitive. That is, as it were, open to the reality of the divine. And we've looked at the different arguments for and against the veridicality of contact with the divine. And in the next concluding lecture, we'll be moving from mysticism to meaning, and not in fact, that disconnected.

7.86 Because what is animating many people's turn or conversion to religion in recent years, particularly since the high noon of the new atheists, where it was all very cognitive, it was all about arguments for and against the existence of God, now it's much more this sense of whether there's an existential, experiential satisfaction in religion and in contact with the divine. The question is, can religion fill, can it address the meaning crisis? Can it fill the vacuum, the sense of emptiness that modernity seems to have bequeathed many, many individuals in a post-religious context and a post-religious culture?

7.87 I look forward to walking through those issues with you in our eighth and final lecture. Thank you for listening.

7.88 My question is, Alston and Otto give some good arguments for religious experiences or the best to their abilities to explain religious experiences. Wouldn't Otto's stance on experiences as being beyond rational thought be more credible or maybe even truthful, as in capital-T truthful, than Alston's stance of experience as being more mundane, like a sunset or experience of death?

- 7.89 Yes. Well, I think, yeah, there's plainly a spectrum, but I think the influence of, what Alston is trying to introduce is a sort of corrective, because from Otto onwards, from that book onwards, religious experience was seen as something that was extremely rare, really dramatic, a kind of Paul-falling-off-his-horse kind of moment. Whereas, what Alston brings in is a corrective that says that religious experiences can run the whole gamut, from very extreme, dramatic experiences all the way down to quite normal day-to-day experiences that a believer refracts through his or her understanding of the world in religious terms.
- 7.90 You can imagine a believer walking down the streets of Scottsdale and sees the sun come up or a beautiful sunset in Sedona or over the Grand Canyon and simply experiences a feeling of gratitude, an experience that would be alien to a non-believer. And so, the way in which that sunset is experienced will be conditioned by the interpretation, the understanding of what the world is and whether there's God, et cetera, whether God exists. To the non-believer, it'll be, "Oh, that's pretty. It's a lovely sunset, but I don't have a feeling of gratitude that accompanies that." And so our beliefs structure our feelings and structure our experience and mold our experience in ways that we're not always aware of.
- 7.91 If an atheist believes to be reductive about these religious experiences, where does that lead them? Essentially, to say, if they're consistent with that reductionist mindset, does it impact or contradict on how they do science, math, theories, et cetera?
- 7.92 Yeah, it's a good question. I think, whether you are an atheist or not, you can be, when it comes to the science, methodologically naturalistic. So, a religious believer, when he's doing science or neuroscience, is not going to be invoking religious explanations when it comes to coming up with hypotheses and theories about the science. The difference between a believer or a theist and an atheist is that the theist will be open to explanations that science doesn't touch, doesn't cover, in a way that the atheist will not be.
- 7.93 As I said earlier, the theist is going to be perfectly relaxed about brain scans that show heightened activity during a religious experience. That's not troubling to the theists, because there's nothing in the claim of theism that when you're undergoing a religious experience, your brain is not engaged in any way, that it's just the mind or something. The believer can say, "Fine, great. This is a complete scientific explanation of what's going on in my brain. But that doesn't mean that there is not also something that's happening, that my brain is either responding to or tracking."
- 7.94 The science is silent on that. Science is agnostic on whether or not there is something non-scientific in the world. Why? Because science just studies the scientific. It can't study the non-scientific. If there is a non-scientific, it's not for science to tell us about the non-scientific. It may be that there are no non-scientific things, but science itself can't show us that.

7.95 And so, it will simply depend on what assumptions you bring to the table. But my sense is that theists can be more open-minded to different kinds of causation and different accounts of experience to the naturalistic atheist, who has to be close-minded, can only insist that only scientific explanations will do.

Lecture 8: Meaning in Modernity

At a glance — A final synthesis on meaning in modernity, weaving the threads together.

- 8.1** Welcome to lecture 8, the final lecture in Introduction to Philosophy of Religion. In this lecture, I want to bring together, weave together, some of the strands that have been opening up over the first seven lectures. Over the last few lectures, we've looked at the cognitive, we've looked at the philosophical arguments for and against the existence of God. We've looked at the moral. We've looked at questions of right and wrong and of value and how they relate to the religious impulse and to religious frameworks.
- 8.2** In the last lecture, we looked at the experiential. That is to say, not so much the cognitive or the moral, but feelings, the inner life, and the sense of attunement to nature, attunement to the divine. What I want to do in this lecture is to bring all of these together into the question of how we think about what it is to be human, and in particular, what it is to find meaning in life, to find meaning in the world, meaning and the human condition.
- 8.3** We talk an awful lot. And of course, the founder of Peterson Academy, Jordan Peterson himself, has been one of the leading diagnosticians of what we call the meaning crisis, the sense of this void opening up in the lives of many, particularly many young people, and that lack of sense of existential significance, the lack of any sense of groundedness.
- 8.4** And I don't think it's any accident that this emerges in the wake of a digital revolution that liquefies a lot of what we want to hold dear, a lot of what we want to conserve. I don't think it's an accident either that this meaning crisis emerges not that many years after the high noon of the new atheism in 2005, 2006, 2007—the Richard Dawkinses, the Christopher Hitchens, the Anthony Graylings, Daniel Dennett, and so on.
- 8.5** It was a time, 20 years ago, when it was just taken for granted that philosophy of religion was a contradiction in terms, that if you were religious, you weren't capable of doing philosophy, and that if you were a philosopher, you would be putting away childish things. You would not need to bother about these religious questions that were at the same level as belief in a flying spaghetti monster, as Dawkins would sometimes put it.
- 8.6** And yet, 20 years on, 10 years on, and then 20 years on, it's clear that there have been consequences to that sort of loss, the dissipation of any sense of the religious and of the religious life, and of the attempt to sequester faith from reason, to silo it off and to treat it as something about which sophisticated minds, people who want to reflect deeply on the significance of religion, the significance of the divine, the possibility of the divine, that those questions, that approach is simply not possible.
- 8.7** One of the points of these lectures has been to show, as it were, put on display, some of the extraordinarily sophisticated philosophical engagement with the religious life

and with religious questions. Indeed, a lot of philosophy emerges precisely from reflecting on the nature of ultimate reality, and often the nature of ultimate reality as divine reality.

- 8.8** So how do we think about the meaning crisis that Jordan Peterson and John Vervaeke and Jonathan Pageau and others have written and spoken so instructively about? Well, in part, it is the loss of shared metaphysical frameworks, a shared stability within our moral communities, as we experience all across the West very dramatic and radical demographic changes, as the world has got more globalized and more connected.
- 8.9** It's become harder and harder to sustain within our home, within our own moral communities, any sense of a shared framework that could invest meaning in the world and in human experience. It tends to be that a sense of meaning, a sense of significance, a sense of purpose, is very hard to achieve entirely on one's own, just as an individual. It's always going to emerge from communities of formation, communities of shared understanding.
- 8.10** And as the world gets more atomized, individuals get more atomized, particularly through technology, it becomes harder and harder to make any sense of meaning as something that might transcend the mere individual. And those fundamental existential questions still haven't gone away. Technology and prosperity and globalization has not made it, has not resolved any of those fundamental questions, because those fundamental questions are not, in the end, technological questions.
- 8.11** They're not scientific questions. They're not cultural questions. Those deep questions of who am I? Who are we? Why do we exist? Why is there something rather than nothing? Is there life beyond biological death? Is there a God? If there is a God, how does that God, if at all, care about me or invest my life with meaning, invest the world with meaning?
- 8.12** Until 200, 300 years ago, those questions were not questions that arose very much at all, simply because there was a broadly settled intellectual culture, broadly settled commitment to a theistic and theological framework that purported to answer those questions and answer those questions to most people's satisfaction. But in the wake of the 17th century and the 18th century, we have the scientific revolution, the emergence of Enlightenment rationalism, and Nietzsche's death of God, opening up this meaning vacuum.
- 8.13** The scientific revolution is not just a revolution in how we understand the natural world and the progress we can make with technology. It's also, the scientific revolution has to be understood in terms of a fundamental gestalt shift in the West, as to what we count as most true, most reliable. And what happened with the scientific revolution, really, was not just a breakthrough in the sciences, as I said, but also a new way of thinking about reality, and in particular, a way of thinking about reality as, ultimately, the science or, ultimately, the objects of scientific inquiry.

- 8.14** There's nothing more to the world than what science tells us is true of the world. As soon as that shift has happened, it becomes very, very difficult to ask the fundamental questions, the ones I alluded to earlier. Who am I? Who are we? Where did I come from? Where am I going? Is there life beyond biological death, and so on and so forth? Is there a God? Why? Because these are questions that are simply unintelligible on a scientific paradigm, because they're not scientific questions.
- 8.15** What is an "I"? What is a subject, in scientific terms? It doesn't mean anything. There are human beings that you can refer to, and science can understand, as it were, in the third person. But there is no "I," there is no "we," there is no center of subjectivity within science. It's just objectivity. That's what science does. Objective facts. It can't make any sense of subjective experience. It can't make any sense of consciousness. It can't make any sense of meaning or metaphysics.
- 8.16** And so, that whole shift of the scientific revolution, as it were, demystified and disenchanting the world in lots of ways and made it very, very difficult to answer these fundamental questions. But those questions don't go away. They persist. They are part of the human condition. It's very, very difficult to free ourselves from those questions.
- 8.17** In fact, the wealthier, the more prosperous we get, the more technologically sophisticated we get—it's almost as if the more, what's sometimes called "affluenza," sets in, the more that sense of despair and existential dislocation becomes more and more pronounced. It's not a coincidence that it's in the wealthiest and most prosperous society that the meaning crisis is at its most acute.
- 8.18** Similarly, not just with the scientific revolution, but also the revolution in, as it were, reason, elevation of rationality and reason above all else, as the primary key to understanding the world, that is something that religion was always very good at tempering. It was always very good at—religion has tended to be very good at imposing certain constraints on human tendency to put too much confidence in the powers of reason, too much confidence in the powers of rationality.
- 8.19** Religious traditions are much, much more open than secular rationalist traditions are, or, say, secular humanist traditions are much, much more open to the experiential, to the life of feeling, of relationship, of community, even though there is a very sophisticated philosophical scaffolding that surrounds and structures bodies of religious commitment and doctrine and so on and so forth.
- 8.20** Actually, the great irony is that, after the 17th and 18th century, with the so-called revolution in reason, in rationalism, and evidence, and science, and so on and so forth, autonomy, what you actually get, following hard on the heels of these revolutions, is, in many ways, their opposite. We see the emergence, for example, in the 20th century, first half of the 20th century, in existentialism and absurdism. So the rationalist revolution often leads to very irrational consequences.

- 8.21** We see, for example, in the work of Nietzsche, at the end of the 19th century, Nietzsche's 1844 to 1900, we see in Nietzsche's thought an attempt to dissolve and collapse the moral universe, to dissolve and collapse a world of meaning and of significance. And he describes, not in a particularly joy-filled or celebratory tone, as is often assumed, the death of God, the disappearance of God, from Western culture and from Western tradition. He sees the death of God as going hand in hand with a death of morality, the death of a stable moral universe, a stable moral grammar, stable moral way of understanding each other and relating to one another.
- 8.22** Similarly too, you have the emergence after this revolution in humanism and this stress in the Enlightenment on human dignity and human preciousness, very quickly after that, you see the emergence of scientific findings, particularly in Darwin's Origin of Species in 1859, of really the opposite of science beginning to reduce the human as a site of inviolable dignity down to, as it were, the purely animalistic, and that there's nothing more to human beings than organisms that got lucky in the evolutionary lottery.
- 8.23** It's a kind of paradox. We have revolutions in science, revolutions in reason, revolutions in ethics and autonomy. And yet, what follows on from that is the collapse of rational structures of shared understanding and the emergence of nihilism in Nietzsche, the philosophies of annihilation, of nothingness, of elimination, or philosophies of absurdism, as we see with the existentialists.
- 8.24** And so, this is a puzzling phenomenon. There's a sense of metaphysical homelessness, of dislocation from the world, as we get more enlightened and more rational and more scientific and more technological. We grow less at home in the world. This is something which Nietzsche diagnoses very, very powerfully.
- 8.25** There's also a sense of a cultural crisis, as the broadly Christian foundations of Western civilization start to unravel or start to be questioned without anything obvious to put in their place. Nietzsche's response to this is not one of despair, so much as to stress the importance of things like the will to power, this life force that is running through us, says Nietzsche, that is always wanting to assert itself, always wanting to create.
- 8.26** We're starting to see the emergence in some ways of a revival of certain forms of Nietzschean thinking that repudiates religion, repudiates Christianity in particular, as something that suppresses that will to power, something that creates in doctrines, for example, of human equality, undermines the natural hierarchies that Nietzsche believes emerge among, within the animal kingdom, but among human beings in particular, when left to our own devices.
- 8.27** What we have also in this Nietzschean picture is this, effectively, an indifference to the fact that the world of values, of hierarchy, of higher values, have been effectively dissolved and overturned, subverted, devalued. For Nietzsche, morality vanishes, and in its place comes a cultivation of the aesthetic life, of beauty, of vitality, of strength.

Nietzsche prefers this idea of thinking of life as a work of art rather than as some kind of moral achievement or divine plan, as is typically understood within religious traditions. That's one response that we have in Nietzsche.

- 8.28** We have also, as I mentioned already, the emergence of existentialism, partly through the philosopher Martin Heidegger and his famous work, *Being in Time*, 1927. Very, very difficult book to grasp, to understand, but it's extremely significant and had a huge inspiration on Jean-Paul Sartre. The basic idea that Heidegger develops and Sartre picks up is that we should reject all of the philosophical and metaphysical frameworks that religions, in particular, have imposed upon Western ways of thinking.
- 8.29** We should see these frameworks as a cage that has held us back, held us captive, a picture that's held us captive, as Wittgenstein says about something else at one point, that kind of mesmerized us. What the existentialists say is, we've got to get rid of these constraints. One important constraint for the existentialists was this doctrine of essence, that every particular thing in the world exhibits an essence, that there's structure, there's order in the world, there's a framework to the world. The philosophers are telling us this.
- 8.30** Existentialists say we've got to get rid of that idea completely. There are no essences. There are no stable ways for things to be. All there is, is existence. I am the subject. I am thrown into the world, and I find myself, first and foremost, just as a free agent. And I don't want—there should be no constraints on that freedom. There should be no clever philosopher telling me that this is the particular framework in which to understand reality, whether it's Plato, or whether it's Aquinas, or whether it's Kant, or whether it's Descartes.
- 8.31** We're radically free, and we are free to author our own lives. That's why authenticity is the central value, the central organizing principle of existentialists. Once authenticity or self-authoring, authoring one's life, becomes the highest value, it becomes the only value, because to say that there are other values out there, there are other virtues, there are other kinds of meaning that could be imposed upon me, that could structure my course of life, then immediately my freedom is being constrained. Immediately, somebody other than myself is authoring my life, is shaping my life.
- 8.32** And so ethics itself, morality itself, metaphysics, and particularly religious frameworks are an unacceptable incursion on my raw freedom, the raw freedom that I have that arises when I am thrown into the world. He says it's not the case that essence comes before existence. That is to say, what the world is, how it's structured, what God's created blueprint for it might be, comes first with the sheer fact of existence and experience downstream of that; it's the other way around, says Sartre. We start with existence, and then we construct how our lives should be, how we would want them to be.

- 8.33** You might say that, really, the existentialist hero is an antihero. He's too free to be good. There is no sense to the world. There's a sense of nothing but a sense of homelessness and dislocation from the world. Authenticity is the highest value, and the only sin is inauthenticity, an inauthentic existence, living according to social roles, religious commands, or predetermined purposes.
- 8.34** Sartre and the existentialists say, no, we've got to be radically responsible for all of our choices and to acknowledge, to take on and not shy away, from the raw freedom that confronts us when we find ourselves in the world. This is similar to the view that Albert Camus, another existentialist, develops, too, really, through novels rather than through philosophy, plays and novels, as was Sartre's media. Camus develops this notion of the absurd, of absurdism. Of course, there's absurdism in French drama at the time; there's absurdism in art as well.
- 8.35** Camus' idea is that there is this—that absurdity arises when there is a deep dislocation and disconnect between the human need for meaning, for anchoring, for existential significance, on the one hand, and the deafening silence that Camus thinks the world confronts us with, just this empty space, an empty silence. The world does not disclose itself, does not render itself intelligible, does not open itself up to meaning in any way. This is Camus' argument.
- 8.36** Camus says that human beings long for meaning; we long for a sense of unity and coherence and integration. But the world is fragmented. It's irrational. There is this deep conflict between the human yearning for meaning and order and reason and purpose on the one hand, and on the other hand, the dislocation, the irrationality, the incoherence, and the fragmentation of the world as we find it before us.
- 8.37** This leads Camus to raise his famous question, that the only interesting philosophical question is: Why not suicide? Why not suicide? Why anything? What is the point? What is the significance in anything, given that life lacks inherent meaning? Or rather, given that the world seems to lack inherent meaning, even though I want to and yearn for a meaning, to find a meaning in it, it's really that clash and conflict between the two that is what Camus is pushing up against.
- 8.38** The existentialist response is this radical quest for authenticity, but also a sense of revolt, a revolution. That is to say, the extent is so we've got to affirm authenticity, we've got to affirm human values, despite cosmic meaninglessness. There's a political dimension to this, too, that there's—one way of responding to cosmic meaninglessness is through a political solidarity. Many existentialists are radical left-wingers.
- 8.39** There's this strange idea of the hero Sisyphus as this great iconic figure for the existentialist, that it's Sisyphus as a hero, the man who rolls his, is condemned to rolling the rock all the way up to the top of the hill, comes back down again, he rolls it back up. The point there for Camus is that the reason he's a hero is that he persists. He can find dignity in the struggle itself and without the need or without—even though he doesn't

achieve any kind of ultimate purpose, because the rock's just going up and down and up and down. This myth of Sisyphus is one that is very important, shaping a very important frame for Camus.

- 8.40** So if we step back and consider where we've got to here, where do we get to with the Nietzscheans and the existentialists, and we think back to those lectures on arguments for the existence of God, on how to make sense of evil, what the relationship is between God and goodness, how we make sense of moving religious experiences that can have transformative, fruitful effects on people's lives, it can seem as if the Nietzschean nihilism, or Camus and Sartre's existentialism, is almost from a completely different philosophical tradition, almost from a completely different civilization.
- 8.41** Because a lot of the problems, a lot of the sense of dislocation that these more skeptical figures diagnose, does have answers in the religious traditions. It does. Religious traditions do not make light of suffering, as we saw in the lecture on the problem of evil and the problem of suffering. And they don't—nor do they, religious traditions, underplay the reality of doubt and uncertainty and even a sense of meaninglessness or even a sense of dislocation.
- 8.42** If you think of, for example, the Danish philosopher Søren Kierkegaard, who's most productive from the 1840s to, 1830s to the 1850s. Kierkegaard, in many ways, is the first existentialist, but he is a passionate Christian, a very radical Christian thinker and Christian philosopher, who actually shares a lot of the critiques that Camus and Sartre develop.
- 8.43** In many religious traditions, the account that is given of this life is of a life that is dislocated from God. There are these texts from, for example, the second century. The *Didache* is an interesting early Christian text which describes Christians as being wayfarers, pilgrims, through this world. It's a very common idea that the religious life is oriented towards the moment at which union with the divine, union with the creator, is possible.
- 8.44** And so that this world will always be a world in which there is a sense of homelessness, a sense of dislocation, a sense of restlessness and a crisis of meaning which the existentialists diagnose as something that only flows from the repudiation of the divine. Within the religious tradition, yes, it's there, but it's not from repudiation of the divine; it's from a sense of detachment from the divine on the way to ultimate union with the divine.
- 8.45** And so, we have these—there's an extraordinary richness in the religious traditions. If we can think even of the arguments for and against the existence of God, in some ways, those are quite technical and philosophical disputes, but they also speak—many of them speak to the human condition. We think about the ontological argument and reflections on what God must be like, or what God might be like, in terms of perfection, of moral perfection, of grandeur, of worthiness of worship.

- 8.46** This is a being which invests the world, invests all of reality, floods it with an awesome meaning. If that is the horizon of life for the believer, then it's very difficult for life to be seen as ultimately meaningless. There could be no higher prize, no higher value, than entering into a relationship with a maximally perfect being.
- 8.47** So too with cosmological arguments. Basically, what the cosmological arguments are pointing to are structure in the world, order in the world, a sense that the world did not just come into being out of nothing, or that there's just been some infinite regress of explanations for why the world is the way it is. No, there's an answer. There's a point at which the world begins. There's an explanation for the order that we find in the world. It's not meaningless. There's a structure.
- 8.48** As all the scientists, our great scientific breakthroughs have shown, the world is intelligible. It's legible. It's open to our inquiry into it. That would be very surprising if naturalism were true. It'd be very surprising if the existentialists were right, and the world was simply a completely meaningless landscape, brought into being by nothing, for no purpose at all.
- 8.49** And so, we can see there, even in the cosmological arguments, this sense of our place in the world, the structure and order and patterning of the world. In the teleological arguments, we have this notion of purpose, this sense that, no, if we look at the fine-tuning constants, for example, we see that exquisite calibration of the various cosmological constants that enable life to get going in the first place.
- 8.50** Again, it's very hard for the religious believer to be reflecting on those arguments and to come away thinking that the world is meaningless and that human beings are here for no purpose. A proper reflection on those teleological arguments, particularly the fine-tuned arguments, makes it very plausible that the universe, in a sense, saw us coming or is structured in a way that facilitated the emergence of human beings in the world.
- 8.51** Another function that those arguments have beyond just structuring or giving a bit of strength to the rationality of religious commitment, or structuring, as it were, providing some structure to existential commitments of faith that one makes, that the religious believer makes in his or her own life, it's not just rationality, it's not just logic-chopping, it's not just philosophical arguments. Those arguments also speak to an attunement and anchoring of human beings in the created order within the world.
- 8.52** It's good to remember that those arguments do, however successful we might find them, do have their drawbacks. They have a tendency to treat God, as it were, as a neat conclusion to a complex philosophical argument. To go back to Martin Heidegger, the father of existentialism, he was a great critic of theology and a great critic of religious belief in many ways, also had very profound insights into what went wrong and why Western philosophy might have gone wrong.

- 8.53** He says that philosophy has a tendency to create these structures, these human patterns of meaning, human matrices of philosophical understanding, and then to use that to screen off fundamental questions about the nature of being, the nature of the good, the nature of God. Heidegger says we need to get rid of all of this Western philosophical inheritance, and we need to understand that, really, to attune oneself to the divine, to really attune oneself to God, one has to realize that it is an error to think that God can pop out at the end of a cosmological argument.
- 8.54** Or, for example, it's an error to treat God as just some very perfect being, some maximally perfect being. That just treats God as if God was some supreme entity among other entities. And that, says Heidegger, is not what religious people—how they should be understanding God. Or teleological arguments—these arguments, Heidegger says, just treat God as a designer, as an architect, as a kind of anthropomorphism here.
- 8.55** There's a projection of human qualities onto the divine in a way that is not befitting for the divine, is not attuned to it, doesn't properly respect that sense of the numinous and the reality of the divine. It reduces divinity to what he calls technological thinking, in the case of the teleological arguments. That whole approach, says Heidegger, is actually a lot further away, that whole approach of what's called natural theology, is a lot further away from what he claims to be his own more authentic understanding of the nature of being and God's relationship to being.
- 8.56** So, where does this leave us in terms of questions of meaning and significance? Well, it's worth looking at a few arguments and a few positions that have been laid out on this question. There are actually some very famous arguments from this sense of human longing or that desire for transcendence. One famous one is developed, not particularly formally, but in an engaging and compelling way, by C. S. Lewis.
- 8.57** Lewis, from a very early age, was aware, or described being aware, of what he called joy, capital-J joy, a sense of yearning for another world or a glimpse at another world, a glimpse, as it were, through the shadow lands into Narnia, into a world, as it were, flooded by the sun, moving out of the world, Plato's world of the cave, you might say the wardrobe, and into the world of reality, the sunlight outside, or for Lewis, the reality that is disclosed through allegory in the Narnia stories.
- 8.58** Lewis' argument is, "Look, every innate desire that I have corresponds to some real object in the world capable of satisfying it. If I feel thirst, there is water in the world. I feel hunger, there is food in the world. I feel I pine for human connection and relationship, there are human beings with whom I can have a relationship in the world." He says that human beings also, from the very beginning, have had this religious impulse, this innate desire for something beyond this world, a desire for transcendent fulfillment.
- 8.59** The German word that he uses a lot here is Sehnsucht, yearning or searching or a desire, as I said, what he calls joy. We've got this innate desire for the transcendent, for

a world beyond. We often talk about the world, and we talk about time, we talk about space, we talk about our ability to engage with the world in a way that makes—it is the way that people who are not entirely located in the world would talk about it.

- 8.60** He says, "Goldfish don't talk about how wet the water is, but we talk about time as if we could stand back from time and reflect upon it. We talk about space as if we could stand back from it and reflect on it. We talk about agency and action and causes and effect, but in ways that we can interrupt and transcend through our freedom." He said this is puzzling. We have this innate capacity, a desire for attuning ourselves to something that somehow transcends the world or lies beyond it.
- 8.61** What he argues is that there's no finite object, there's no object in the world that fully satisfies this yearning for the transcendent, this ultimate longing. And so, Lewis concludes that there is, very plausibly, some object beyond this world, some non-finite object, some transcendent object, God or heaven, which must exist to correspond to this yearning, this natural longing.
- 8.62** Now, it may not be the most compelling argument, but it's true that this yearning is certainly a stance. It's a posture that people can be very familiar with. It's a pretty universal experience. All across cultures, we see evidence that human beings yearn for something more, a way to understand life more deeply. Of course, there are aesthetic triggers. We think of music, you think of poetry, the experience of natural beauty, all of those hinting at something that lies beyond, a transcendent reality.
- 8.63** If you listen to Bach or Beethoven or Mozart, there is a sense that this is a melody from a world, melodies from a world beyond, power that can't be accounted for fully in purely naturalistic terms. And so, this sense of infinite desire, or a desire for something that is not satisfied in this finite world, is something that requires explanation. And there's a kind of phenomenology. There's a sort of account of what it's like to undergo these experiences, which is pervasive and needs accounting for.
- 8.64** One obvious antidote to the meaning crisis that Vervaeke and others have stressed is this sense of narrative unity, this sense that we are beings on a journey within a particular story, and that the more we can understand and clarify what that story is, the more we can sense that there is meaning to our lives, that there's meaning to the world. Life is a meaningful story. This is the supposed solution to existential dislocation.
- 8.65** There's got to be a narrative structure, and that's how we, as it were, derive our sense of meaning and our identity. And it's how communities derive their sense of meaning and their identity, as well. But then the question is: which story? Whose story? Doesn't the story have to be true, or at least plausibly true? If we're not compelled by it, we don't think it's true in any way, then how could it invest our lives with significance or with ultimate meaning?
- 8.66** I think one thing that religious accounts of the nature of reality can achieve is to provide an overarching narrative that claims to be fundamental, foundational, unique,

and true, not just a nice story to tell. I know that in the American evangelical world, is it a famous film or a book? It's often that the Bible is described as the greatest story ever told.

8.67 Now, it's a story of a particular people, a story that happens in a particular place, but it's also a story that purports to be a story of all humanity, a story of all reality, from the beginning of time to the ultimate eschatological moment within the Christian tradition, of union with the divine. You see it in different religious traditions, that's the Christian one, but there are different ones, too.

8.68 Within the Islamic framework, for example, you've got stress on, as I said, on tawhid, on oneness, on khalifa, a sense of stewardship, the story being that God creates the world and then invests creatures with his authority to steward the world, to guide it. There are narratives that explain why we're accountable in the world, what our eternal destiny is, and so on and so forth.

8.69 Within Hinduism, there's narratives about being caught up in illusion, and pain is part of the illusion that we need to escape from through moksha or through emancipation or salvation, that we ourselves can pull off. That's what provides life with direction and ultimate meaning, because the ultimate meaning is that, as it were, there is no meaning within this world; that what meaning we might think that we have in this world is to be transcended, is to be moved past, is to be recognized as māyā, as illusion.

8.70 Now, you can be agnostic on all of these different stories, these different narrative structures. But what they all have in common is that they are vast communal stories. You can't opt in and out of different parts of the story. The great power of religion is that it has these coordinating principles for large groups of people, large, complex societies, to stitch them together, to organize them, to invest them with a sense of meaning and common purpose.

8.71 That's a very, very difficult thing for secularism or for non-religious traditions to replicate. You see attempts to do so with the political religions of the 20th century, or you think of the personality cults around Marxist-Leninism in, say, Cuba or in North Korea, or you think of the personality cults around Kemalism that emerges in Turkey in the 1920s. And what you have there is attempts to create a substitute religion that is focused around earthly politics and almost always a cult of a particular person or a particular dynasty.

8.72 And these tend not to be very successful at all. They certainly tend not to be conducive to human flourishing. They don't tend to be conducive to communal flourishing either. On quite the reverse. You tend to get a lot of disappointment and restlessness, dislocation, and misery. So there is, you might say, if not an argument for the existence of God, there is a powerful sociological argument for the benefits that religion brings to communities and to individuals in terms of their flourishing.

- 8.73** Religions offer different approaches that are attuned to the way human beings are. So, for the cognitive dimensions of human beings, we are attracted to philosophy, we're attracted to argument, we're attracted to those dimensions of the religious quest. But there is also, of course, the experiential side, the sense of attunement to value, the sense of moral obligation. And religion pulls all of these together into a systematic whole, in a way that provides an existential answer to the meaning crisis.
- 8.74** It provides resources for addressing the fundamental questions. Why is there something rather than nothing? How do we recognize transcendent beauty and truth? What kind of universe are we living in? What is the ultimate nature of reality? And religion stresses the reality of truth, the reality of beauty, the reality of goodness and of love, and doesn't try to reduce them away, doesn't try to explain them away skeptically in purely scientific terms.
- 8.75** That's what all the secular meaning alternatives have attempted to do, whether it's humanism, existentialism, naturalistic spiritualities offering non-theistic responses. Whereas in the religious traditions, you do have a set of answers. Yes, there are often many differences between the answers that religious traditions provide. Nevertheless, they are overlapping solutions. There's a strong degree of systematic convergence and indeed, a strong degree of cross-cultural convergence, when it comes to questions of meaning, beauty, and transcendence.
- 8.76** And so, what we've seen also, in many, many empirical studies, that religious communities, religious societies, tend to simply fare better, that it may well be the case that "the religious shall inherit the Earth," in the name of a wonderful book by my fellow Peterson Academy lecturer, Professor Eric Kaufmann, a book of his from, I think, 10-15 years ago.
- 8.77** One of the points that Eric makes—and I think Eric, actually, is secular. I don't think he's a person of faith himself—but one of the points that Eric makes is that religion, religious societies always correlate very, very strongly with a sense of confidence in the future, very high fertility rates, very strong indicators of psychological flourishing, very strong evidence of social support across religious societies.
- 8.78** The religious frameworks provide human beings with coping mechanisms, particularly when it comes to suffering, to loss, and to mortality, and to this great sense of yearning for meaning. It provides answers which are extremely difficult for secular substitutes to provide.
- 8.79** And so, as I come in to land, it's worth looking back over the last eight lectures. We started with the first two lectures, mapping out the landscape of philosophy of religion, asking ourselves: What is it we're doing when we're thinking about the philosophy of religion?
- 8.80** I suggested philosophy of religion helped us tap into an extraordinarily wide range of different ways, philosophical ways of engaging with reality, whether it's through

metaphysics, whether it's through epistemology, the study of knowledge, our beliefs, our opinions about the world, questions about language, how language hooks onto the world, questions about good and evil, value, right and wrong, and questions of the deepest dimensions of human experience and how we respond to the world and how we find meaning in the world.

- 8.81** I hope that, from these lectures, you've got a sense of the extraordinary breadth of philosophy of religion. These have only been introductory lectures. Every single lecture could have gone on for many, many, many more hours. Indeed, there are entire courses that spring out of each lecture. But I hope that, by the end of this series, you've got a sense, a taste of, just how significant a religious quest is within the story of humanity and how it weaves together the life of the mind, the life of the heart, the life of human experience itself.
- 8.82** It's been a great pleasure traversing these extraordinary territories with you. I hope you've learned and benefited from hearing them as much as I have from delivering them. Thank you for listening.